

The Problem of Faith and Knowledge

A Historical-Critical Treatise

Problemet om Tro og Viden

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Preface

This work reproduces, in all essential respects unchanged, the content of the lectures I delivered at the University of Copenhagen in the autumn semester of 1867 on the relation between faith and knowledge, between religion, philosophy, and ethics. These lectures encompassed the historical-critical part of the investigation and formed the preparation for an attempt at an independent resolution of the problem under discussion, which will be published in the course of this year.

The historical-critical part of the investigation provides, beyond a brief sketch of the problem's genesis, a detailed critique of those proposed solutions that have acquired a special significance in our literature — among them one, the solution originating with S. Kierkegaard, that was executed with an originality, a seriousness, and a depth that will preserve for it this significance at all times. Through the critique of these proposed solutions — which, in the course of their development and justification, have stood in a sustained polemical or mediating relation to earlier and foreign contributions, and which can partly be regarded as results of previously dominant tendencies, and have partly substantially accomplished the critique of such tendencies — the most significant of the older and contemporary proposals have been illuminated, and in part the complete preconditions have been supplied for a final judgment upon them. This historical critique will then find its supplement in the work that attaches itself to this one.

The present state of the problem in our literature is marked by the conflict between, on the one side, a form of theology that borrows in an eclectic fashion from newer philosophical hybrid formations the weapons with which it will defend the union of faith and knowledge, and, on the other side, the anti-theological-religious standpoint, which, by means of the principled opposition between faith and knowledge, aims to secure the validity of religion and science in their mutual independence and the possibility of their peaceful coexistence within consciousness — while at the same time, by virtue of this same principled opposition, denying theology all right to bear the name of science, a name theology claims for itself by demanding to be a “science of faith” [*Troesvidenskab*].

The philosophizing theology, which maintains the possibility of appropriating and

expressing the content of faith in the form of knowledge, and which therefore not only wishes to claim the name of science for theology but assigns to it, as the concluding form of revelatory science, primacy among the sciences and judicial authority over them, has had as its historical point of departure the speculative system that, through an ambiguous extension of the concept of “religion,” brought religion in its specific sense into an identical relation with philosophy, from which it was to be distinguished not by any difference of content, but only by a difference of form. After this ambiguous unity had to be abandoned in the struggles that developed following the emergence of Hegel’s philosophy of religion, the theology influenced by philosophy, exchanging the designation of speculation for that of the Christian, nevertheless preserved the tendency toward mediation; but it now rests primarily upon a different philosophical orientation — and in particular upon the system that, by introducing a redoubling into philosophy, creates room for a “free thinking” which borrows from its close relative, the imagination, the “magic cloak” [*Fjederham*] enabling it to soar above the abysses of mystery; and it cautiously inserts a qualification that cuts off even the “higher science’s” consequences whenever thought, despite its “freedom,” involuntarily comes to follow its own essential laws.

The anti-theological theory, which likewise presupposes Hegelian philosophy, but whose relation to that presupposition is originally negative and polemical, had as its historical incitement also the protest — lodged by a philosophy that presents itself at once as the consequence of and as the opposition to that speculative doctrine of mediation — against the unity of religion and philosophy. The most significant representative of this tendency is Feuerbach — a man whose writings are known only very incompletely and judged only very superficially by those in our literature who have criticized him. Conceiving religion’s standpoint as practical in opposition to science’s theoretical standpoint, and determining the former ever more sharply through the emphasis on its alogical element, he arrived at the irreconcilable opposition as his view of the relation, and demanded, in the interest of genuine cognition and genuine ethical action, that religion be absorbed into science and ethics. Religion as such was to disappear — as something alogical, as an imperfect transitional stage in the development of the human spirit’s self-consciousness — leaving behind only its name in an improper and figurative sense.

In agreement with Feuerbach regarding the opposition, but disagreeing as to its grounds and its application, S. Kierkegaard draws the distinction between religion and philosophy in religion’s interest. The human spirit, which in the restlessness of existence cannot grasp the Eternal in the objective certainty of cognition, and which acknowledges

the limits of its own cognition, finds only in the religious relation, in faith, a subjective existential certainty regarding what is its deepest interest; it finds there, and only there, its true reconciliation. The validity of knowledge is not denied, but objective knowledge is bounded to a domain in which the spirit's deepest interests cannot find their satisfaction. Faith and knowledge thus each receive their own territory, and through this, and through knowledge's subordination, the compatibility of both within the same consciousness is to become possible.

This Kierkegaardian conception of the problem of the relation between faith and knowledge has been taken up by Professor R. Nielsen and presented in such a way that some have wished to place him on a par in originality with the theory's originator, attributing to him the resolution of a task of the same creativity as the one Kierkegaard strove to resolve. How little this view is warranted will be demonstrated in this work. It will emerge that the problem has not been advanced by Professor Nielsen; that the form he has given the solution has introduced only uncertainty and vacillation into the decisive determinations; that the attempt at a psychological and metaphysical grounding of the separation of the principle of faith from the principle of knowledge as absolutely heterogeneous with it has failed and leads to irresolvable contradictions; and that the same holds for his grounding of the proposition that the absolutely heterogeneous principles can be united within the same consciousness.

When, then, alongside S. Kierkegaard — the genuine representative of the anti-theological-religious standpoint — such detailed attention is devoted to Professor Nielsen, it is not because the theory has received from him a deeper grounding or a richer development, but because it has through him exchanged the character of an esoteric doctrine for an exoteric one, penetrated into the broad circles of "the cultivated," and in these circles is in the process of changing from a question of knowledge into a question of faith, and of being fixed as dogma by virtue of an unappealable *ipse dixit*.

As representative of the philosophizing theology, Bishop Martensen appears in this work; but since the argument is closely tied to what is given in his writings, the universal, the typical in the standpoint is nowhere lost from view, nor forgotten in favor of the individual. It has not been necessary to give direct consideration to other theological attempts in our literature.

The ultimate task, whose resolution is prepared through the critique — which immediately can yield only a negative result — is the vindication of a standpoint that has not found expression in our discussions, and that has been advanced elsewhere only in forms that cannot satisfy. This standpoint maintains such an opposition between science

— philosophy in particular — and the positive forms of religion, between knowledge and faith understood as revelatory faith, that knowledge and this faith cannot be brought to unity within the same consciousness; — it maintains the impossibility of a genuine and substantial ethics, one that encompasses the whole, real human life, developing on the basis of positive religion with its supernatural law of action; — and it maintains the inner, indissoluble unity between genuine cognition and genuine ethical action, the necessary dependence of the latter upon the former. But while it maintains this opposition, it asserts with equal decisiveness, on the other side — distinguishing the essential determination of the religious from the phenomenal forms of the positive religions, in which it sees only a partial, imperfect, finitizing expression of the former, and thus distinguishing what is religious in the religions from the religions in their historical forms — the inner unity of the religious, the philosophical, and the ethical, and through this inner unity the inner unity of human life: the condition for its true and complete reconciliation, the reconciliation within reality, the reconciliation of undivided human nature with itself in its essential ground. In affirming the essentiality and necessity of the religious relation for the human being, whose self-consciousness is first fully actualized therein, through God-consciousness, and who according to the fundamental relation of its nature has never been and never will be without religion; — in further seeing ethical action and genuine cognition as gaining a higher significance through their unity with the religious fundamental relation; — and in allowing genuine knowledge and genuine ethical action to become an adequate form of actuality for the religious, it conceives this knowledge and this action as containing within themselves a Highest and Unconditioned, in which what is essential in the religions is preserved. This standpoint we designate as *the religiously reconciled humane consciousness*.

It differs from the position occupied by Feuerbach not merely in that its metaphysical fundamental concept is a different one — one upon which a cognition and an action bearing the stamp of ideality and universal validity can be built, and from which the concept of human freedom can be vindicated and a religious relation grounded to the Absolute, with which the human being is in essential unity — but also in that it combats theology and dogma not only in the interest of ethics and science, but first and foremost in the interest of religion itself, in the interest of the infinity of the religious relation.

It differs from the old Hegelian school's conception of religion's relation to cognition, in that it does not see the religious merely as a form of knowledge, but as the expression of a fundamental relation encompassing the whole of human nature in its concreteness, and in that it does not let the medium of spiritual life be an illusory abstract element of

eternity, but reality with its real conditions and limits.

With the anti-theological-religious theory it concurs in its conception of theology's relation to science. Since it rests upon scientific cognition and, in undivided human nature, assigns primacy to cognition, it must be its task to vindicate the clear concept of science and science's autonomy, grounded in its own nature, against equivocations and against attempts, based on equivocations, to subordinate science to the dominion of a foreign, heterogeneous authority. But while there is thus, in an essential point, an agreement between it and that theory, it enters into a decided opposition to the latter when the relation between faith and knowledge, between religion, philosophy, and ethics, is to be determined. This opposition concerns Kierkegaard's conception, with respect to which it will be shown that it undermines the certainty of all cognition and allows the ethical to disappear into an abstract and reality-less religious sphere. But it concerns even more precisely the form in which the theory has been elaborated and presented by Nielsen — a form that Kierkegaard would certainly not recognize as his own. The form in which Nielsen develops the theory leads, despite all the more or less adroit turns that are made in order to avoid this consequence, to an actual dualism in human nature, to a division of the life of the spirit from its very ground by means of the "absolutely heterogeneous" principles, to the inevitable self-dissolution of consciousness; it corrupts the ethical at its root and opens the path to the religious for all that is superstitious and absurd. With the conviction that the absolute heterogeneity Nielsen posits between the principle of knowledge on the one hand and the principles of faith and action on the other is "a misunderstanding that is ruinous for religiosity, morality, and all genuine character development," I have subjected his theory to a thoroughgoing critique, and sought to demonstrate its untenability, its deficient grounding, its self-contradictions, its ruinous consequences.

In publishing this contribution to the investigation of a problem that through the centuries has had, and will continue to have, the most decisive significance for the human spirit, it is my hope that it may occasion a renewed, serious, and conscientious discussion — a sharp and open conflict between principles. Such a conflict, even if carried on with sharp weapons, can only serve the interest of the cause; and one must therefore hold dear the combatant for whom the cause, and not some egoistic self-regard, is the highest consideration. A firm and deep personal conviction I shall always respect; by sound reasons I shall always be just as open to influence as I intend to be impervious to anything other than these.

Chapter 1

Historical Moments Illuminating the Emergence of the Problem

1.1 The Preparation of the Problem in Antiquity

It is first among the Greeks that a definite approximation to a clarification of the problem of the relation between faith and knowledge comes into view. In the Orient, e.g. in India, one becomes aware, where a thinking relatively independent of religion develops, of the discrepancy between its results and the doctrines of religion, and an opposition forms between a heterodox and an orthodox doctrinal edifice; but the distinctive character of Oriental philosophizing, its lack of thoroughly achieved independence from religious doctrine, of the capacity to develop its content in the form of the concept, and of a clear consciousness of the principle of philosophy, brings it about that no reflection is reached concerning the principled ground of the difference—that is, no consciousness of the essential determination of faith and knowledge. The conscious difference is only the factual difference of content.

In Greece, where the knowing spirit becomes conscious of itself in philosophy, and, in unfolding the content of its knowledge, connects it through a single principle, it can, with this content of knowledge—of whose principle and whose connection with the principle it is conscious—enter into relation with religion as it is given in the forms of popular religion, and the problem is intimated; indeed it even seems, at the close of classical antiquity, to come forward in its decisive form. It will, however, become apparent that even where the question of the relation between the doctrines of philosophy and of religion, and of religion's significance for the spirit's cognition, is most strongly accentuated, one does not get beyond intimations, and that what prevents this is the

specific distinctive character of the Greek spirit.

Already in the earliest period of Greek philosophy we see philosophy standing in a critical-polemical relation to popular religion and its myths. Thus the founder of the Eleatic doctrine of unity, Xenophanes, combats the anthropomorphistic conceptions of the gods in the myths, and his polemic is repeated in other thinkers of that remote time, but without our finding in any of them a genuine reflection on the significance and nature of popular religion. In the culmination period of Greek philosophy, in Plato and Aristotle, the critical relation to the mythical emerges in connection with a clearer reflection on philosophy's position with respect to the myths and cult of popular religion. Here Aristotle's conception in particular becomes significant. What is distinctive for him, as in general for Greek philosophy up to his time, is that philosophical thought, resting and satisfied in itself, passes judgment upon the positively religious from out of itself, without entertaining doubt about thought's authority. In the doctrines of religion Aristotle acknowledges as true only what is confirmed by philosophy; the mythical clothing, on the other hand, he denies truth without hesitation, tracing it back to conscious invention or unconscious anthropomorphizing, and the forms of cult have significance for him only as what is legally valid in the state.

The situation presents itself differently in the post-Aristotelian period, and in this period it passes through two essentially different stages. As Greek philosophy passes beyond its culmination point and becomes conscious of the inner discord that it cannot reconcile, there first appears a greater attentiveness to the religious, in that the relation to it, both the acknowledging and the polemical, acquires a more essential significance for thought that no longer rests securely in itself. We thus see in the Stoics an attempt to rationalize the myth, and we see this attempt bring about a counter-effect of the mythical upon philosophical theory, a counter-effect that becomes evident in the Stoics' theodicy and in their doctrine of divination. On the opposite side we see in the Epicureans a rational opposition to myth, a struggle to free the spirit from the disturbing influence of the fear of the gods, in which Epicurus sees the essence of religion; and in the later Academics, e.g. Carneades, as in the later Skeptics and in the renewal of Cynicism, we find an opposition directed partly against the theological attempts, partly against popular religion.

A new stage in the development of the relation, and one that in this connection is of essential interest, begins around the time when Christianity appears, historically prepared by the development of the Greek and Oriental spirit, in Neo-Pythagoreanism and in the concluding forms of the older philosophical schools. The more thought was

exhausted, the more the spirit theoretically and practically lost its resting point and through skepticism was brought to despair of its own and of reality's truth, the more was truth—the truth of cognition and of action—sought outside the human spirit in the transcendent divine, which through intermediate beings reveals itself to the spirit; and since such divine revelations were seen in the religions, in them a starting point for knowledge was sought. And the relation to revelation—to that occurring through intermediate beings or already given in the religions—was then posited in Neoplatonism as conditioned by religious purifications and by religious practices, in general by a religious life and a religious disposition. Philosophy, which supports itself on this content of revelation and would draw truth from it, is then transformed into theology, and in Neoplatonism, which assigns to philosophy the task of justifying the content of myth, and, in assimilating the idealized myth, of taking the place of the religions as a universal religion, we see within paganism the parallel to Christian-medieval Scholasticism.

At this point one has come as close to posing the problem of the relation between faith and knowledge in its decisive form as can be reached among the Greeks at all. Here there has been reflection on the spirit's—when left to itself—lack of capacity to grasp what is decisive in the last instance in both practical and theoretical respects; philosophy, the unfolding of autonomous thought, has been placed alongside divine revelation, and it has been declared as the result of this juxtaposition that the relation to the Absolute, to absolute truth, cannot be reached through knowledge, but only through the religious life and the religious disposition. Yet the problem in its sharpness does not emerge even here; one reaches only the intimation, and the decisive reason is that the Greek spirit apprehends itself exclusively under the determination of knowledge, that it lets knowledge constitute the essence of the human being—whereby from the outset the possibility is cut off of a principle coordinate with knowledge in its own distinctive character, and still more of a valid opposition to knowledge; but only through the distinction and the opposition can the problem be brought forward and the reconciling unity be recognized.

That the Greek spirit becomes conscious of itself only in the determination of knowledge can be made evident from a double point of view. If we first fix our gaze on Greek ethics, it is immediately striking that in it the concept of virtue becomes the central concept, while the concept of duty recedes. But if we then investigate how virtue is determined, we find it determined as knowledge; and since for the Greeks virtue expresses the activity of the essence according to its undisturbed nature, the proposition that virtue is knowledge becomes equivalent to the proposition that knowledge is the

essential determination of the human being.

To the same result we are led when we consider the way in which the greatest Greek thinkers determine the divine. For Plato the highest is the Idea, more precisely the Idea of the Good, but the Idea is the objectified and hypostatized thought-content, which receives from Plato the determinations *nous* and *phronesis*. In Aristotle the divine is determined as *nous* and more precisely as *noesis noeseos*, which in eternal, uninterrupted energy relates thinkingly to itself and from which all determination of will is excluded. But the essential determination of the divine is the ideal of the human spirit, and it becomes also for these thinkers the highest expression of the essential determination of the human spirit. For Plato the human soul is closely related to the Idea, indissolubly connected with it, and for Aristotle the human spirit in its highest form as *nous poietikos* is in unity with the divine spirit itself, whose essence is exhausted in thought.

How the Greek consciousness, despite the attempts that are made in that direction, does not definitively get beyond the determination of knowledge, becomes apparent when we more closely consider the relation between knowledge and will and between knowledge and faith.

As for the first relation, even where the volitional side of the human spirit is more strongly accentuated—which already occurs in Aristotle, and still more in the last period of Greek philosophy—the distinctive nature of will is never properly recognized, and the attempts to demonstrate the source of this distinctiveness fail, so that will is continually reabsorbed by knowledge. Indeed even where, at the close of Greek philosophy, among the Neoplatonists, it is declared that genuine cognition is conditioned by the right disposition—where, that is, a primacy of will over thought is formally asserted—even there the movement is only a circular movement from knowledge back to knowledge, and knowledge shows itself in the last instance as the sole original. The right disposition, namely—that disposition which turns away from the finite and as such the untrue and vanishing—is immediately determined by a knowledge of this fundamental determination of the finite, such that cognition, in being determined by this disposition, relates only to itself through will, and in its determinateness as concrete cognition has as its actual condition and presupposition the abstract cognition of the fundamental relation. The relation of will to cognition also becomes clear through the abstraction in which will remains: will as will receives no distinctive positive content; it moves only in the generality of the negative; its highest goal becomes the spirit's ecstatic absorption into the indeterminate infinite.

What holds for the relation of cognition to will holds also for its relation to faith.

When we speak of faith, we must make a definite distinction between the concept's application in the earlier period and in a later one. In Plato, *pistis* is placed alongside *doxa* and stands as something lower in opposition to the true form of knowledge; in Aristotle, *pistis* (in the *Rhetoric*) acquires the meaning of means of persuasion. In the meaning of something higher in relation to knowledge, the concept of faith is first used in the concluding period of Greek philosophy. In Philo, who is at least as much a Jewish believer as a Greek thinker, the concept appears in the meaning of the trusting reception and acknowledgment of the content of revelation, and after him the concept is preserved as the concept of that which is higher than knowledge. For Iamblichus the first condition for genuine knowledge of God becomes the faith that nothing is impossible for God. For Proclus, faith designates the immediate relation to the divine unity, in which union with it through the contemplation of its pure being is given. It here forms the opposition to knowledge, which is always determined by the plurality of reflection and which is said to be unable to reach the highest. And yet, despite these determinations, despite the fact that faith, as the higher, is distinguished from knowledge, faith falls under knowledge; the movement here too is only a circular movement from knowledge to knowledge. In the Neoplatonists the indeterminate, infinite unity to which faith relates is precisely nothing other than the negation of determinate knowledge posited through the most extreme abstraction by a knowledge that has come to despair of itself—a negation that exists only through thought, through knowledge, and that in its negativity is determined by it. And in Philo the relation of devotion to the self-revealing divine in its highest and true form becomes the devoted absorption, occurring in ecstasy, into the abstract unity; but this indeterminate unity is the last residuum of abstracting thought, an object of negative knowledge.

The Greek consciousness can thus reach the point of seeing the difference between the content of knowledge unfolded in the system of philosophy and the determinations of religion unfolded in myth and cult, and of becoming conscious of the principle of knowledge; but it cannot, in its monism of knowledge, recognize the principle of religion in its distinctive character, through which it could show itself as something different from or opposed to philosophy and yet valid—just as it cannot, owing to its deficient conception of the movement of the concept, of the nature of spiritual development, while making knowledge its sole point of view, see the principle of religion as the principle of a subordinate stage in the spirit's teleological development toward philosophical cognition as the spirit's true and adequate form.

1.2 The Emergence of the Problem in Christianity

Whereas within Greek philosophy—and only within philosophy could the problem be hinted at among the Greeks—only a preparation of it was reached, but since the sharply defined form of it cannot be found even where all the conditions seem to be present and where the decisive point is, as it were, touched upon, the Christian era brings about the conditions for its emergence. Yet here too they develop only successively, and in the development we can distinguish several stages.

1.2.1 The New Testament's Pronouncements on the Relation

What, as the new doctrine is proclaimed, must at once come to the fore is the opposition between it and that which it is to supersede. This opposition is an opposition between the content of the Gospel of the coming of the Kingdom of God, which is proclaimed and appropriated in faith by Christians, and the conviction of the non-Christian world, which has its common ground in a mode of thought in which the Greek and the Eastern spirit met. Inasmuch as that conviction, in its opposition to the Gospel, is represented most immediately by the cultivated, the knowing, the opposition becomes an opposition between the world's wisdom and the wisdom of Christ revealed to the simple (the wisdom of God); but this form of the opposition too, when "wisdom" is taken in an objective sense, points back essentially to the opposition in content. A new content, formerly hidden from mankind, is revealed, a counsel of God for which the fullness of time has come: a μυστήριον. The concept of the mystery points to the new content, which embraces also what is concealed in the future (thus the future destiny of the Jewish people, the resurrection and the transformation); but it points likewise to that which becomes manifest only to those in whom the Spirit works. Inasmuch as the concept embraces this latter signification, the ground of the opposition, its principle, is thereby intimated; but since there can be no question of the believing consciousness, foreign to knowledge, seeking the ground in a principle of knowledge, the ground of the opposition between the non-Christian and the Christian consciousness is sought in a defect of disposition, of will, which, so far as that consciousness has an acquaintance with the faith-content of the latter, becomes a lack of will to accept the content of revelation; and this lack of will is seen in turn as grounded in the "carnal" and the "psychical," which form the opposition to the "pneumatic." Behind this determination of the opposition lies the opposition of principle which, in its connection with the problem, first comes clearly and sharply forward in Scholasticism: the opposition between the natural and the

spiritualistically supernatural. The concept of the natural embraces the thought darkened and obscured by sin, and for this thought the higher supernatural truth is therefore inaccessible, which becomes accessible to faith only through a divine revelation.

The Christian consciousness's relation to its object is designated partly as πίστις and partly as γνῶσις, and γνῶσις is conceived as the consummation of faith. The view that would set faith and knowledge in unity and maintains the possibility of a science of faith has leaned upon the determination of γνῶσις. But in the New Testament the designation γνῶσις still has only a more indeterminate meaning; it here means an acknowledging cognizance, not a cognition through thought. γνῶσις stands to πίστις as the more concrete to the more abstract, as the unfolded to that which is as yet only beginning, but it falls within the same sphere, does not become a form of cognition, of knowledge, for its content is that which surpasses knowledge. But in the designation γνῶσις there lies a possibility for that conception, and this is seized upon in Gnosticism and in the older Church, in which the spirit, in its urge for cognition, would extend the domain of cognition to that which by its essence cannot be cognized, and therefore lays the signification of a comprehending cognition into the promised γνῶσις.

1.2.2 The Patristic Period's Relation to the Problem

By the patristic period we understand the Christian antiquity that was the time of the production of dogma, and as such we distinguish it from Scholasticism, the time of the Christian Middle Ages, the period of the elaboration of dogma, of the formal appropriation of dogma.

The patristic period unfolds dogma in essential completeness into a coherent Christian edifice of doctrine, and it does this by employing the forms of ancient philosophy, attaching itself from the beginning especially to the Platonic and Stoic philosophy, later preferentially to the restored Platonism. By this unfolding of a Christian edifice of doctrine, which as a totality can be set against the heathen systems, an essential condition is given for a sharper apprehension of the problem. Among the Church Fathers a distinction is drawn between the believing cognition, a Christian γνῶσις, whose relation to πίστις is now more fully determined, and the cognition of philosophy, the heathen γνῶσις; but reflection on the relation does not lead to a definitive result, it does not become clear whether, in the transition from πίστις to γνῶσις, one is to think only of an ordered combination of the faith-content into a coherent unity, whose point of departure remains untransformed into cognition, or of an ἐπιστήμη in the stricter

sense.¹ The opposition therefore remains, even in the patristic period, in spite of the more developed thought, still essentially an opposition with respect to content, and even this opposition cannot, because the consciousness of the matter of principle is unclear, attain its full sharpness.

This is grounded in the patristic period's relation to antiquity. The men who in the Eastern and Western Church represented the Christian gnosis were, by the bonds of language and nationality, by the whole inherited culture, so closely grown together with classical antiquity that the unconscious influence of its thought and view of life could not be warded off. While, therefore, proceeding from the immediate religious consciousness, one set the opposition between the content of the Christian faith and that of heathen knowledge, the after-effect of the Greek conception of knowledge prevented the attainment of full clarity with respect to the principle of the opposition; and during the unfolding of the content of dogma there pressed in, hidden and irresistibly, an admixture from ancient philosophy and the ancient view of the world and of life, and it pressed in even into that which was central for Christianity, as in the doctrine of the God-man and of sin, and the boundary-determination between the oppositions became uncertain for reflection.

1.2.3 The Development of the Problem in Scholasticism

Scholasticism has for its presupposition the unfolding of dogma into an essentially completed whole; its task is, by the aid of a reflecting thought, to appropriate dogma to consciousness by finding, if not the *ratio* of dogma, yet the *rationes* of the dogmas. When we are therefore to designate its age according to its striving, we designate it as the time of the appropriation of dogma. Just as by this determination it distinguishes itself from the patristic period, so it distinguishes itself from the latter by the altered conditions of the time. The dependence on antiquity that was grounded in the immediate connection of nationality had ceased, and the production of dogma was so far concluded that a system, embracing the totality of faith and knowledge, could now be attempted. In the service of the Church and bowing beneath its authority, thought strives to erect such a Christian edifice of doctrine, in which the content of faith and the content of thought are to be fused into a whole. The manner of the joining becomes clear when we consider the great systems that were produced in the flourishing period of Scholasticism. In these we see the ancient view of the world, which gathered itself together in the representation

¹Note the vacillation in the application of the concept that shows itself in Clement of Alexandria. His conception of πίστις points back to Philo and has affinity with that of the Neoplatonists.

of the harmoniously ordered divine Κόσμος, as it were embraced by the frame of the Christian. The view of world-reality, which had to be taken from philosophy given as a historical presupposition, for which the world was a reality, and which for antiquity was the whole, now became, conjoined with the Christian faith-content, a part, fitted into a larger whole. The content of thought taken over from antiquity filled out only the middle part of that world-drama, of which the first and last act belonged to Christianity. Before the natural universe was set the nature-free, almighty, creating God, after it the Christian heaven, the supernatural kingdom of grace. But in this composition the beginning and the end became, by Scholasticism's own admission, something inaccessible to thought, hence in essence heterogeneous with that which filled out the interval; the specifically Christian content therefore presents itself, in spite of the attempted joining, as something incomprehensible to the content of thought. And in seeking the ground of the incomprehensibility, one finds it in the incongruence between natural thought and supernatural revelation. Faith's "higher cognition," which owes its existence to a heightening of the natural faculties brought about by a divine miraculous working, has only the name in common with the cognition of knowledge, which rests upon those natural faculties, which do not stand in a continuous developmental relation to that which is posited by the miraculous heightening. The significance of natural cognition for the faith-content becomes only this: in negative form to assert it as the not-impossible, not positively to ground it. But in spite of the difference of essence, which leaves behind only the likeness of the name, the relation between faith and knowledge is nevertheless determined as a relation between two forms of cognition. Nevertheless there lies in the heterogeneity of the oppositions an inducement to trace them back to different functions of the spirit, and such a tracing back we find, for example, in Duns Scotus, when he posits faith as coming into being only through an act of will and therefore lets theology, which rests upon faith and whose aim is not most immediately cognition but blessedness, the enjoyment of God, stand in a closer relation to the will than to the understanding, inasmuch as it becomes not a speculative but a practical doctrine that is to lay hold of our will.

When we follow the problem through the time of Scholasticism, we find a development that is essentially conditioned by that attempt at union, by which the consciousness of the relation must necessarily be clarified, and the development becomes partly a development within the same point of view: that of knowledge, partly a development by which a new point of view for the opposition is intimated.

In Scotus Erigena, who forms as it were a transitional link between the Fathers

and Scholasticism, whose distinctive character he intimates, while he, like the former, bound by the relation to antiquity, answers the problem through a postulate of the harmony between the activities of spirit sprung from the same source, faith and reason—a harmony in which reason becomes the overarching and primitive. But in the time of Scholasticism proper the development proceeds in the direction that the cognition of reason is subordinated to the cognition of faith, and as the difference posited in the subordination is sharpened more and more, there is reached at last an abstract opposition between faith and knowledge, between the truth of religion and that of science, so that the at first merely quantitative difference becomes a qualitative one, and finally an irreconcilable opposition; and as this development approaches its conclusion, it is that reference is made to a principle which, as principle of faith, is another than the principle of cognition and of knowledge in general.

In the first period of Scholasticism, Anselm posits faith as point of departure and norm, but demands a knowledge that takes up the faith-content into itself, and he ascribes to comprehended faith a higher worth than to the uncomprehended. Among the great representatives of Scholasticism in its culminating period, in Thomas Aquinas and Duns Scotus, a higher cognition of faith is distinguished from the cognition of the reason not illumined by grace, but Thomas maintains, alongside the necessity of faith, its agreement with reason, inasmuch as the latter too is a revelation of God, and Duns Scotus maintains, by his doctrine of the proportionality between the oppositions, the connection between supernatural and natural cognition, even though he must admit that we cannot reach a comprehension of faith, which, as indicated above, he lets have its human origin from an act of will. In the concluding period of Scholasticism, finally, in consequence of the absolute opposition between the supernatural and the natural, the difference between theology's higher cognition, which is given through the faith brought about by a spiritual creation, and natural knowledge is so sharpened that worldly science is not even to be able to give an indication of the divine truth, a preparation for our higher ends. It is now pronounced, for example, by William of Occam, that something can be true in theology that is false in philosophy, and herewith Scholasticism has itself pronounced its judgment upon the union that was its essential task; it has itself sundered the two elements and the two principles that it would force together.

1.3 The Problem's Resolution in Modern Philosophy and Theology

In the Christian Middle Ages, in which philosophy was the handmaid of theology, thought governed by the authority of the Church, the resolution of the problem had necessarily to bear essentially the Church's stamp, and the individual voices that rose in behalf of an independent thought and asserted the supreme right of reason had to be drowned out and silenced. The relation shows itself otherwise from the time when Scholasticism itself dissolved the contradictory unity of the Middle Ages, when philosophy and theology each received its own truth and the emancipated philosophy now autonomously unfolded its truth: the truth-content of the human reason undisturbed in its essence. Against theology's answer to the problem there now stood philosophy's, and the more the latter gained independence and asserted itself unassailed by the Church, the more theology's apprehension of the problem was determined by philosophy's.

Modern philosophy has come into being under an opposition to the unfree, formal, and reality-less scholastic thought bound by the authority of the Church, and to the Church's doctrine itself, an opposition that already in the period of transition developed into a passionate struggle in which philosophy had its martyrs. Taken as a whole, modern philosophy stands in opposition to the religious view of life of the Christian Middle Ages. The apprehension of the essentiality of the natural and of the autonomy of thought and its validity as a source of truth divides philosophy decisively from Christianity's view of the world and of life. Yet there arises, in the relation to Christianity and, in consequence, in the answer to the problem of the relation of knowledge to faith—for which this determinate form of religion was essentially taken as representative—a strongly marked difference between the two main directions into which this philosophical epoch has developed: the realistic and the idealistic.

The realistic direction had necessarily, in accordance with its conception of nature, to mark itself off at once decisively from the Christian, and it has consistently preserved its relation and constantly sharpened it in form, inasmuch as it passes from a formal accommodation, defensively prescribed by external circumstances, through an avowed indifferentism, to an ironic mockery and thence to a sharper polemical relation that gradually assumes the character of a passionate hatred. While thought, which thus successively gives nature the preponderance to such a degree that it is itself absorbed by nature conceived as matter, and, unexplained by it, becomes a riddle to itself, judges, as thought, in the name of reason, religion to be the irrational, the unconditionally

pernicious for man's progress and man's happiness; the source of religion is determined as ignorance, faith becomes superstition, irrationality, even with an admixture of the morally reprehensible, and the authority to judge is awarded solely to that thought which pronounces the immutable laws of nature, of moved matter, of the One-Existing, and asserts them in their application to the human, which becomes only a dependent member in the all-embracing nature.

In comparison with the thoroughgoing uniformity of realistic philosophy's position toward the present problem, the idealistic line of development presents a far greater manifoldness of forms of the relation. The consistent, conscious carrying through of the whole epoch's fundamental thought had necessarily, within this line too, everywhere to bring the opposition to light; but the abstract likeness that obtains between idealism—particularly where it develops as panlogism—and the Christian view of the world, and the fact that, with a single exception, all the thinkers who represent idealism were personally attached to Christianity, has been able to call forth a striving to set religion and philosophy, faith and knowledge, in harmony, and this striving comes forward in various nuances.

The opposition, which throughout the whole of modern philosophy is apprehended essentially from the point of view of knowledge, of cognition, is determined either as an opposition between the true cognition, that of reason, and an untrue cognition, that of imagination (Spinoza: *intellectus* — *imaginatio*), an opposition that essentially coincides with the opposition between the determination of infinity and that of finitude, between the eternal idea and the vanishing historical form (Schelling's earlier philosophy);—or as the opposition between the goal and truth of cognition and a stage of development in cognition that is as yet only imperfect and relatively true, and that in the teleological development is taken up into the perfect truth, the truth of philosophy (Hegel, when the Logic's determinations of the relation between form and content are consistently carried through). To this latter form of opposition are to be traced back, in principle, the attempts that have been made to bring the religious doctrines, by a reinterpretation—moral or speculative—under the domain of the philosophical cognition of reason; for while in these very attempts there lies the presupposition of the teleological developmental connection, there lies therein at the same time an acknowledgment of the necessity of raising that which appears in merely relative truth to the form of the pure absolute truth. That, individually, the consciousness of this connection may be more obscure, that the reinterpretation may be conceived as touching only something unessential, an external difference of form, makes, in principle, no difference to the matter.

The endeavor to bring faith and knowledge into harmony, which comes forward within certain forms of development of modern philosophy, assumes—when we leave aside the superficial notion of a “religion of reason,” a “natural religion,” of which Christianity is supposed to be the proper expression—either the form that a quantitative difference is conceded in favor of revelation (a supra-rational that is yet not to be a contra-rational), or the form that an essence-, content-untouching difference of form is posited in favor of philosophy. The latter nuance was represented chiefly by the so-called right side of the Hegelian school, which leaned upon Hegel’s philosophy of religion, whose restoring tendency, at least in expression, had led to the relation between form and content developed in his *Logic* becoming obscure in its application to religion’s relation to philosophy. From that school this mediating conception was then carried over onto theology’s domain in the speculative dogmatics.

The intimations of a collision-preventing distinction between the domains of faith and knowledge, which in this period are given within philosophy, attain no further significance. When Spinoza gives religion a practical task, and by this determination would ward off the collision with philosophy, it is an accommodating turn that cannot be maintained over against his philosophy’s determinations of the relation between the theoretical and the practical. And when Leibniz somewhere intimates the same distinction, his utterances lose their significance alongside the general determinations of his doctrine, and alongside his endeavor to assert the theoretical truth of the dogmas.

Within the domain of theology the sharply marked opposition between faith and knowledge comes forward essentially in the period of the Reformation and particularly in Luther. Thought’s domain is, according to his conception, the worldly, but in the domain of the religious it can avail nothing without denying itself. He does indeed sometimes seek to assert for thought a significance as negatively determining, inasmuch as he ascribes to it the capacity to decide what the divine is not; but he cannot consistently carry this concession through. Among the old Lutheran dogmaticians the opposition is already softened. During theology’s later development the influence of the mediating philosophy makes itself felt, directly or indirectly, and the difference becomes, where it is not wholly leveled out (as in the rationalistic identification of natural religion and Christianity), a quantitative difference, even where the designations sound qualitative—one that in reality is in principle excluded by theology’s claim to be a science. The attempt made by Schleiermacher to assert, in accordance with what had already earlier been intimated by Lessing, under the opposition between religion and philosophy, the validity of religion by giving each of the opposites its own peculiar domain, by setting each of them in relation

to a peculiar faculty of spirit, has only a subordinate significance in comparison with the attempt at distinction made later by Kierkegaard. We rest this judgment on its significance partly on Schleiermacher's defective conception and arbitrary delimitation of knowledge, partly, and chiefly, on the unclear and contradictory in his position generally, inasmuch as he, on the basis of an—albeit inconsistent—pantheistic philosophical standpoint, would assert the validity of the positively religious, particularly of the Christian, and out of the contentless and purely negative conception of the idea of the Absolute conditioned by his philosophical standpoint, determines the essence of religion and the organ of religion, whereby it must precisely become impossible to reach the concrete dogma and the historical that is indispensable for positive religion.

Against the striving, represented by the Hegelian philosophy of religion and a part of his school, to maintain the essential unity of religion and philosophy under the difference of form apprehended as essential, an objection was raised both from the side of religion and from the side of philosophy. From the former a protest was lodged against the dissipation of that which is peculiar to religion through its transference into philosophy's concepts and into the form of the conceptual process; from the latter was asserted, in accordance with the Hegelian logical development of the concept, the inseparability of the difference of form from a corresponding difference of content. The recognition of the impracticability of the attempt at mediation then led to the attempt to solve the problem through a distinction of spheres. In Germany Feuerbach makes this attempt in the interest of knowledge. The character of his attempted solution has been indicated in the foregoing in its essential fundamental features; a critique of it will, partly directly, partly indirectly, be given in the work that is to follow upon this one. Among us the problem entered a new phase through Kierkegaard, by the attempted solution which, while like Feuerbach's it rests upon a distinction of spheres, aims at the union of the principles in the same consciousness through the recognition of both.

From this attempted solution derives all that has a real significance in the Nielsenian, and this relation between them can already here, at the close of this brief survey of the essential stages in the history of the problem, be made clear by a preliminary juxtaposition of the two with respect to the points that become of significance in this place.

In Kierkegaard the religious is the original and moving personal interest and the goal toward which from the beginning aim is taken; but in the development of the standpoint knowledge is the point of departure, and it is through knowledge's self-delimitation, through the recognition of the barrier that the relation of existence sets for the existing knower, that the necessity of faith and of the relation of faith is acknowledged. The

validity of knowledge is then not annihilated, but is acknowledged as relative, within its determinate boundary; faith becomes, as the highest form of certainty for the existing one, the absolutely valid, that which alone gives the existing one the reconciling certainty, as though wrested out of uncertainty, of that which satisfies the deepest urge of personality. Knowledge can, precisely on account of its delimitation, not disturb the content of faith, nor comprehendingly appropriate it; the only thing it can do in relation to faith is to become serving, inasmuch as it guards the paradox, preserves it as such in its sharpness and inaccessibility. Conversely faith lets knowledge remain undisturbed in its delimited domain, and in accordance with this relation the two principles with their spheres can find their place in the same consciousness without disturbing collision.

In Nielsen too knowledge becomes the point of departure of the development, in him too knowledge delimits itself, so that, through the recognition of its not merely relative but absolute boundary, it is led to acknowledge in its validity the faith-principle absolutely heterogeneous with itself. Knowledge clarifies the relation between the faith-principle and the knowledge-principle and their spheres, and it is capable of this inasmuch as it, reflectingly, embraces its opposite, and so makes that too its object, not only that which it grounds. Each of the spheres that are determined by the principles absolutely heterogeneous with one another unfolds in its inner infinity without outwardly restricting the other and therefore without coming into conflict with the other; and thus, precisely on account of the heterogeneity, the union of the spheres and their principles in the same consciousness does not divide the unity of consciousness.

In the decisive fundamental features the two forms of the theory thus agree. Were a difference to be sought, in the determinations indicated, it would be this, that Nielsen would set both spheres as infinite and unrestricted, both principles, in accordance with their absolute heterogeneity, as absolutely valid, and that he would posit a relation of coordination, whereas Kierkegaard clearly pronounces the merely relative validity of knowledge and the finitude of its sphere, and definitely sets knowledge in a relation of subordination to faith. But on closer consideration such a difference would show itself as illusory.

As regards first the infinity of the spheres, which would have to follow immediately as a consequence of the absolute validity of the principles, and which would have to imply that all reality, reality in its completeness, found its place within each of the two spheres, it cannot be maintained. With respect to the sphere of knowledge, which seems to receive such an infinity through the fact that knowledge also has for its object that which it merely reflects, the infinity would in any case become an infinity with respect to extent,

not to content. By the very separation between that which is assimilated—that grounded and comprehended by thought is assimilated—and that which is merely reflected, there is set in the content of knowledge a boundary that points to an essential delimitation in knowledge as human knowledge, even though this delimitation is postulated as abolished in the idea of knowledge. But the essential delimitation, which comes forward immediately through the delimitation of the content of knowledge, must inevitably lead back again to a delimitation with respect to extent, on account of the dialectical relation between extent and content and their necessary reciprocal determining. It is immediately evident that that which is merely reflected in knowledge—not only when knowledge is taken in the strict sense as appropriating (assimilating) knowledge, and only in this sense is it properly knowledge—is known only according to its abstract being; but that, even when knowledge is taken in the extended meaning, it too is known only abstractly, because concrete knowledge exists only through the cognition of the connection, but for reflecting knowledge the connection of the reflected must withdraw itself, inasmuch as its form—on account of the absolute heterogeneity in the principles—becomes absolutely incommensurable with that of knowledge. And what holds with respect to the infinity of the sphere of knowledge has its counterpart with respect to that of the sphere of faith. This too cannot be maintained in the indicated meaning. Within faith there is found no relation that corresponds to the relation of reflection in knowledge and in accordance with which the content of knowledge could be taken up into it. And even if such a relation obtained, faith would not have all reality for its object, for the corresponding reason to that for which knowledge did not have it. The sphere of faith can thus not assert its infinity. Only this result is sought here; in what follows it will be shown in its place that the factual delimitedness of the spheres, however much the self-delimitation is accentuated, will yet lead to a collision at the boundary with the sphere that is touched therein.

How the delimitation in both spheres is to be conceived is easy to see when we take a concrete object. If we take thus the natural, then the law of nature and the causal connection determined by the law of nature, which are both determinations of knowledge and as essential objects of knowledge have validity as reality, do not exist for faith, which sees things only as created, in their dependence on God. Conversely knowledge does not cognize the form of connection of the creaturely relation of dependence, which, as essential object of faith, according to the positing of form, would likewise have to have validity as reality. The total reality, whose being in knowledge and faith was to give them infinity, is thus reduced for each to an incomplete reality, for that which is object

for knowledge and faith is only the connectionless things, things as it were “an sich,” but not the relation in which they stand to their ground, not the connection with this and with the homogeneous reality, hence not that which makes things what they are; and this connection, which determines the concrete reality, belongs only to knowledge or to faith, and falls outside the sphere of the common reality, but as a reality; for only in it are things what they are. But this really means: in reality the reality is doubled and the doubled reality is divided between faith and knowledge, so that the apparently common becomes only a homonym. And this doubling of reality will show itself as contradictory and impracticable.

As regards the second point emphasized above: the coordination of the spheres, this is in Nielsen, in spite of the determination of the principles as absolutely heterogeneous, only apparent; in reality there obtains in him, as in Kierkegaard, a subordination, so that the inequality between the theory’s two forms of presentation here too disappears. The subordination of the principle of knowledge and the sphere of knowledge under that of faith is in Nielsen not only indirectly posited in several ways: by the determination of the will, which is brought into special relation to faith, as the properly constitutive in the human essence; by the conception of the essential determinations of theoretical and practical cognition and their relation to personality, and by the conception of “the religious ethics’ superiority over the rational”; but it is expressly pronounced in the designation of the truths of religion as supra-scientific truths.

In the points that have an essential significance for the development of the problem, the Nielsenian theory thus coincides with Kierkegaard’s, and the originality belongs to the latter alone. Yet there arises, in the critique of the theory, occasion to keep its forms of presentation apart from one another in order to illuminate the additions it has received in Nielsen through his attempt to set the fundamental determination of the relation between faith and knowledge in connection with his psychological and metaphysical theory, and the contradictions and inconsistencies from which it suffers in him, but which Kierkegaard knew how to avoid.

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After what has been developed in the foregoing, the essential standpoints that have been taken up in the answering of the problem are accordingly the following:

- 1) The religious standpoint, which sets faith, as the relation of appropriation to the divine revelation conditioned by God’s supernatural working, as absolutely raised above natural knowledge, which is conceived as that which not only cannot cognize the content of revelation, but must deny it.

- 2) The standpoint of theology and of a single philosophical form, which posits a quantitative difference in favor of faith².
- 3) The standpoint of pure rationalism, on which the difference is set forth by the notion of a religion of reason, a natural religion, with which Christianity is identified.
- 4) The standpoint of mediation within idealistic philosophy, on which a difference of form is posited in favor of philosophy.
- 5) The standpoint of realistic and of consistent idealistic philosophy, on which, the relation being determined from the point of view of knowledge, knowledge receives an absolute preponderance over faith, and becomes the sole organ of truth.
- 6) The distinction of the spheres in order to set aside the religious.
- 7) The distinction of the spheres in order to bring about the union of both in the same consciousness.

Of these standpoints, as already earlier indicated, the theological and that which through the distinction of the spheres aims at their reconciliation will become the object of a separate, detailed critique; while the others, so far as it is at all necessary, will be illuminated through the critique of those, or through the developments in the work that forms the continuation and conclusion of this one.

²To this standpoint the scholastic distinction of *duæ veritates* in reality goes back.

Chapter 2

Preliminary Conceptual Determinations Illuminating the Problem

In raising the question of faith's relation to knowledge, we take faith not in the vague, effaced meaning—as immediate knowledge, immediate certainty of being—in which the word is used by Jacobi and by theologians who, in the interest of ambiguity, adopt his indeterminacy, but we take the word in a specifically religious meaning, in the meaning of the faith that relates itself to religion, more determinately to positive religion. The determination of the concept of faith therefore becomes inseparable from the concept of religion.

This latter concept we apprehend first in its ideal meaning, in the meaning of that which is the moving power in the development of the phenomenal forms of the religious, the goal toward which the historical development of the religions strives. We reach the concept of religion according to its ideal meaning by taking our point of departure from what is the aim of the religious relation. This we can determine in a single word as the reconciliation of the spirit, its reconciliation in itself and with its principle, the ground of its essence. The human spirit seeks in religion liberation, peace, rest, reconciliation; it seeks it for itself as a totality, according to the full determinateness of its essence; only thus is it reconciled in itself. The religious relation must therefore be a relation in which the human spirit, according to all its essential fundamental activities, comes to rest, a rest that includes reconciliation and satisfaction for cognition and feeling as for the will. It is the undivided human spirit's urge that leads to the religious relation, and when this urge, while reconciliation is sought, comes forward most nearly and most

immediately under the form of a single fundamental activity, then the satisfaction of this activity's urge, which here as it were represents the striving of the other activities, must go in unity with the satisfaction of their urge too: the reconciliation of the whole human spirit must be present under the reconciliation of the single function of spirit. But the full reconciliation, the reconciliation of the spirit determined according to its totality with itself and with its own and existence's principle, can take place only through that relation to the principle by which the spirit, in consciousness of its essential unity with this, in free surrender sets it as the principle of its *whole* being. This is to say, in other words: the religious relation must be determined as the *absolute* relation to the Absolute. This determination includes a threefold. Partly it points back to the fact that the Absolute must be in essential unity with our essence; for only to that with which we are in essential unity, to our Absolute, can we stand in an absolute relation, in a relation embracing at once our whole cognizing and our whole life. Partly it points to the fact that that to which we stand in the religious relation must be the truly infinite; for only in the infinite can the human spirit absolutely find rest. Partly, finally, there lies therein the consequence that the religious relation, precisely as the absolute, cannot fall outside the relative and particular relations, whereby it would itself have to become relative, but must enclose these relations in its concrete, embracing unity.

But when the concept of the religious relation is thus determined according to its ideal and universal meaning, there shows itself an incongruence between this concept and the positive, historical religions stamped as particular forms of the life of spirit. Through all of these there passes, as the moving power of the development, that striving of the human spirit, called forth by the fundamental relation to the principle, after the truly religious, i.e. the absolute relation embracing the whole human essence and human life; it is this striving that, during the historical development of the religious forms, leads them forward from the lowest forms of the nature-religions to the highest of the spirit-religions; but through all the historical, positive religious forms the ideal concept of religion comes forward in a determinateness of relativity and finitude: the positive religions show themselves as *finite* expressions of the essence of the religious. The finitude becomes recognizable through the forms of the human spirit's activity in the religions, through the conception of the divine conditioned thereby, and through the determination of the human's relation of interaction with this.

We seek first the determinateness of finitude in the *theoretical* form of the religious consciousness. This is, at the stage of the positive religions, even though the religious consciousness as human consciousness is worked through by thought, not that of the

comprehending thought developed to clarity and coherence, infinite according to its essence, but essentially that of immediate feeling and of representation, and from this the determinateness of finitude is inseparable. But the peculiarity of the form of consciousness must necessarily determine the peculiarity of the content of consciousness. The spiritual content can indeed have an imperfect form, inadequate to the content according to its essential determinateness, without the content being transformed for consciousness, when it has already been present for consciousness in the adequate form, and from this has consciously been carried over into that. The form then becomes only a clothing, symbol, allegory. But in the development of mankind the form of religion constantly precedes the comprehending cognition: the Absolute is present in its forms before it is present for consciousness in the form of thought. It is thus not set over from a more adequate form into the representational form of religion: this is for consciousness not a clothing, but the *only* form for the content; it counts therefore as the true and adequate form. The content can thus not remain untouched by the peculiarity of the form: it exists only as the thus-formed content for consciousness, and a separation of it from this form becomes impossible at the original religious standpoint. Such a separation takes place only through an awakening reflection, and this comes forward at the religious standpoint only in relation to other, most nearly to subordinate, religious standpoints. In relation to its own content the religious consciousness is, by the nature of the case, not critical: it finds itself again in the thus-formed content.

The specific form of the religious consciousness thus acquires an essential significance, and here particularly the effect of the representational form is to be emphasized, inasmuch as the content of the religious consciousness, which in the immediacy of feeling is in a closed-together, intensive, but unfolded unity, is first unfolded into determinateness through representation, becomes a concrete object for consciousness.

The peculiarity of representation is determined by its psychological position between sensation and thought, between which it forms the middle term. Representation has, as middle term between the two, a moment of both: it combines the receptive dependence of sensation with the freedom of thought, its singularity with the universality of the concept. That which is represented is loosened from the immediately existing external, set over from the external space into the inner space of consciousness; it has begun to be distinguished in relative universality from external singularity and its contingency; but according to content it is still determined thereby. From this it follows that that which is in representation is touched by the form of *sensibility*, that accordingly, when the Absolute is to be apprehended through representation, its universal essence must

be intuited in the form of a single existence determined by a reflex of sensibility, its eternal life-process, embracing and idealizing the development in time, as a process determined by the finitude of time, whose single moments fall separated outside and after one another; that the forms of the pictorial, of the mythical and the historical, must become inseparable from the apprehension of the Absolute.

While the form of feeling made the content finite by letting it remain without unfolding, the form of representation thus brings, through its relation to externality, a determinateness of finitude into the religious consciousness's apprehension of the Absolute. It comes forward in that form of distinction by which the transcendence of the divine is determined; in the apprehension of God under the form of personality, in which the peculiarity of the sensibly determined single personality (the individual) shines through; in the historical in the religions, in which the divine receives a finite limitation of time and space, and in the apprehension of God's working as a working through the single, separated acts of the miracle¹, the discontinuous expression of arbitrariness.

To the determinateness of finitude in the religious consciousness, apprehended from its theoretical side, there corresponds, and by it is conditioned, a similar determinateness of finitude in it, seen from the *practical* side. The relation of thought to the object is a relation of freedom and infinity. The individual is free in the relation, inasmuch as it, through the object, in which thought as comprehending finds itself again, relates itself to itself, and in this relation it has an inner infinity. And as free it lets the object subsist in its freedom, inasmuch as it, when it dissolves the form of being of the object into thought, when it seeks itself in the object, does not seek and find again a subjective, individual thought, but the objective, universally valid thought, which constitutes at once the essence of the object and of the individual. It is thus, precisely because the relation as a relation of freedom is a relation of infinity, uninterested, unegoistic in the relation to the object. Of another kind becomes the relation where representation is the form of consciousness. The representing subject is in a finitude-distinction from its object conditioned by the nature of representation; it therefore asserts itself according to its singularity, does not yet meet with the object in the universal, does not stand in that relation of freedom and infinity to it. Applied to the relation to the Absolute, this entails the following consequence. Inasmuch as the believing individual relates itself to the Absolute apprehended in the form of representation, it stands as a finitely

¹The miracle, the specific mark of positive religion, is not the highest expression of omnipotence, but the making-finite of omnipotence, the expression of an illusory infinity of omnipotence instead of the true infinity of omnipotence, hence in reality the negation of omnipotence. Omnipotence is made finite precisely by the negation of the law of nature, which in the miracle is set as the expression of a working of the almighty will's other, which is opposed to the working of omnipotence.

determined single personality over against a divine single personality, from which in reality the determinations of finitude are not removed. But this relation, in which the finitude is abiding, must precisely for that reason acquire the character of open or hidden egoism. Even if the relation is designated as a relation of love, it holds that love's surrender is only absolutely free of egoism where the love relates itself to the Absolute cognized in its true infinity², and only where love's surrender is absolutely free of egoism is love the true love and reconciliation through love, the true unity with God, possible through it. Where the determinateness of finitude abides, this unity cannot be reached, the reconciliation cannot be apprehended as the individual's reconciliation in its ground of essence, but it must be apprehended as a reconciliation with another being, which by its form of singularity preserves the distinction from man. This transcendent being's demand, its commandment, then becomes determining for the religious relation by which the reconciliation is to be brought about; to the individual's fulfilling or not-fulfilling of the demand there attaches a reward and punishment, which, like the commandment, is determined not out of a relation of essence, but by the unconditioned divine will, and therefore becomes a motive of egoism; and even where the representation of blessedness most nearly touches the thought of unity with God, a determination of finitude presses into it, partly directly in the apprehension of blessedness as reward, partly indirectly through the representation of time, through the representation of the futurity of blessedness, through the distinction of the consequence of the action from the action itself. On the whole the abiding determinateness of finitude shows itself in this, that the religious relation becomes a merely particular relation; for this is one with its becoming a finite relation.

If we, instead of taking the point of departure from the apprehension of the religious consciousness's theoretical determinateness and from this drawing the consequences for its practical relation, wished immediately to hold to the religious consciousness's practical determinateness, and to assert the view that the point of departure had to be taken from this, because the will was the decisive thing for the religious relation, this would yet not lead to any other result. For we would then, inasmuch as that emphasis on the will rests upon an opposition of principle between it and cognition, receive as the determining thing the will in its isolation; but the will in its isolation is, as will later be shown in detail, only unclarified, egoistic drive, hence a form of finitude of the will³, even

²cf. S. Kierkegaard: *Kjærlighedens Gjærninger*.

³However much the will's autonomy and independence of principle are accentuated, its making-finite is yet not avoided when it is apprehended in isolation, for precisely the abstract distinction between the universality-form of knowledge and the singularity-form of the will makes both finite.

though it be adorned with the highest names. Where the will, in postulated autonomy, is set as the constitutive in the human essence, and as that which in its distinction is to express the highest spiritual, it precisely reaches no further than to the imperfect form of the will, which forms the parallel to the form of representation in the theoretical domain. Only in unity with the true thinking does the will reach its truth. Where it unconsciously follows its own law, it is blind drive, and where it is determined by a conscious motive of will not raised to thought ("a will-cognition"), it always has in itself a determinateness of affect; it is determined by craving and passion, and this practical determinateness of finitude inevitably reacts upon consciousness's determining of the object, which shows itself especially clearly in the praying person's apprehension of the divine, which is to be moved by the prayer. The form of affect that comes forward in religion is essentially fear and hope, and the fact that fear and hope in religion are determined by the representation of a *superhuman* being (an expression applicable to all the most diverse religious forms) does not free them from unclarity and egoism, and it does not do so because the divine, apprehended through a form that is not that of the concept, has in itself the determinateness of finitude.

For the determination of the concept of faith in relation to the phenomenal religious forms the presuppositions are now given. Inasmuch as the divine acquires the character of a transcendent and supernatural, of something distinguished from the human essence, the relation of communication of the divine thus determined to the human spirit is apprehended as a relation of revelation, represented in such a way that revelation is not an inner communication of essence proceeding from the essential unity with free necessity, but an arbitrary communication, conditioned by external means, of a content that, as communication about God's essence, is limited by God's arbitrariness, and, as communication about God's commandment, which is to determine human action, has its validity through the will of the subject of revelation, bound by no necessity of essence. Revelation, taken in this meaning, demands its own peculiar instruments, and it grounds a *positive* religion, which contains a law for cognition and action.

These determinations with respect to the concepts: revelation and transcendent, supernatural subject of revelation, have their validity not only for the spirit-religions, but also for the nature-religions, even though, by the nature of the case, they come forward less clearly in these. In the nature-religions too, through the involuntary personification of the nature-power, a transcendence is brought about, so that the nature-power becomes not only a *superhuman* power, i.e. a power higher in degree than the human, but in a certain sense a *supernatural* power, i.e. a power that in its hypostatization is formally

loosened from the real natural and by fantasy is freed from nature's, i.e. from its own barriers; a power that, through fantasy determined by fear and hope, transcends itself, abolishes its own conformity to law—which, at this standpoint, means: the conformity to law that consciousness here apprehends: the relative conformity to law of the customary. From this subjectivized transcendent there is seen also in the nature-religions a revelation as proceeding, either through the stirrings of the religious in the single individuals, or through peculiar individuals as media, or through the supposed signs and workings of the divine.

When religion as positive, historical religion thus becomes equal to revealed religion in the meaning indicated above, and is constituted by the relation, through a content of revelation, to this content's transcendent-supernatural source, then faith as religious faith acquires hereby its closer determination. Faith as religious faith thus becomes the relation of acknowledgment—the theoretical and practical—to revelation, and the relation of acknowledgment included therein to the subject of revelation.

In this determination of the essence of *faith*, which apprehends it from the standpoint of the positive religions, there lies implicitly how this faith's relation to knowledge and to the action resting upon knowledge must be determined from the standpoint of the religions and from that of science. Inasmuch as the religious consciousness standing at the stage of positive religion apprehends its content as *divine* revelation, it must, when it is to determine the relation—as we have seen above with respect to Christianity—set the faith-content as incommensurable with the human power of knowledge, and this incommensurability acquires its more determinate stamp by being traced back to the opposition between infinite and finite, between supernatural and natural, between divine wisdom and human cunning, between the doctrine of the Holy Spirit and the contrivance of the human spirit corrupted by sin. For the distinction between the divine and the human immediately set by the form of the religious consciousness must, inasmuch as reflection, determined by the representational form, apprehends it, acquire the shape of opposition; and inasmuch as faith now acquires a divine object, and likewise—since the object is subject of revelation and revelation is that which conditions faith—a divine principle and origin, it must necessarily, when the relation is to be determined, set itself in a relation of opposition to knowledge with its finite content and natural principle. The form of transcendence and of single personality, in which the divine is apprehended, includes at once that the content of revelation, as having the divine for its object, cannot be communicated to men except in accordance with a free divine creative decision, and that it must be a higher than human thought.

Between faith and knowledge there thus forms itself an opposition, unabolishable in accordance with the separation between the divine and the human, with respect to the cognition of the divine essence; but this opposition embraces likewise the opposition between revealed religion's supernatural law of action and the law of action that is determined by the natural cognition of the human spirit's essence and essential relations.

The difference between faith and knowledge would also in reality be determined as an opposition if the relation between revelation and reason were determined by the apparently quantitative difference that revelation's content was to have a wider extent than knowledge's, was to surpass knowledge, and *abidingly* to be a supra-rational, without its yet being expressly determined as a contra-rational. For that which distinguishes itself from knowledge and within the sphere of cognition—and thus the relation is apprehended here—will limit knowledge, becomes knowledge's opposite and in reality abolishes knowledge. For knowledge is knowledge only as that which according to its concept is closed in itself, which holds the whole of existence within itself, its principle is a universal principle. Were a more embracing than the sphere of knowledge set, then the latter, as going into the more embracing concatenation—the infinite concatenation of the “divine truths”—would have to be determined as an organic member in that; but from this it would follow that it was first apprehended according to its truth when it was apprehended as such, and that knowledge's apprehension of its content would be false, because it apprehends that which is only a member as a whole, and otherwise it cannot cognize it, because revelation's supra-rational content cannot become a content of knowledge. Only faith's cognition would then be the true cognition, knowledge's would be not only incomplete, but essentially untrue.

Apprehended from the standpoint of the believing consciousness, the relation between faith and knowledge will thus show itself as a relation of opposition, but in the same way the relation must be determined when it is seen from the standpoint of knowledge. Inasmuch as science cognizes the limitation of finitude, conditioned by the positive religions' relation to representation, in their apprehension of the divine and its communication to the spirit, and vindicates for itself as its specific form the infinity-asserting, comprehending cognition, it sets the opposition as an opposition between faith's “cognition” and knowledge's cognition, inasmuch as, even when the religious is essentially apprehended from the side of the will, the will-form is seen as standing in an indissoluble connection with a determinate form of cognition, so that the moment of cognition accordingly becomes essential also from this standpoint.

The given conceptual determinations thus lead us to the preliminary result with

respect to the relation between faith in the meaning of positive religion and knowledge, that the difference, both from the standpoint of faith and from that of knowledge, must be determined as an essential and unabolishable opposition, which must lead to the necessity of a choice between them, and that the unity of knowledge and faith becomes possible only when the limitation of finitude is removed from faith and religion, and these are apprehended according to their ideal determination of essence⁴.

A departure from this determination of the relation is now given at the two standpoints that will particularly become the object of a critical examination. From the side of theology, while a positive religion is maintained as truth's absolute form, the difference is, through the claim to the possibility of the union of faith and knowledge in a science of faith, set as a merely quantitative one. From the standpoint that distinguishes the opposites in order through the distinction to reconcile them, the opposition between faith and knowledge is conceded, but against the assertion that a choice between them is necessary because the kind of opposition makes impossible their union in the same consciousness, the assertion of the possibility of such a union is set, while at the same time objection is made to religion's truth being judged from the standpoint of knowledge or subjected to science's judgment, inasmuch as it is asserted that its truth rests upon another principle than that of knowledge and follows its own, higher law.

Through the critique of these two standpoints' answer to the problem the validity of the determination given above will then be demonstrated.

⁴How the relation between science and religion according to the latter's ideal concept, between knowledge and the faith corresponding to that concept of religion, is to be apprehended, will be developed in the work that is to follow upon this one.

Chapter 3

Theology's Answer to the Problem

3.1 Theology's Task as a Science of Faith

Theology's general position toward the problem—a position that is here accordingly distinguished definitely from that of the immediate religious consciousness—is to be more closely determined in the following way. Theology as a science of faith becomes precisely the expression of an essential belonging together of faith and cognition. It does not indeed limit faith to cognition, but sets cognition as an essential determination in faith. It does not deny the difference between faith and knowledge, both when knowledge is apprehended as natural knowledge and when it is apprehended as the knowledge, determined by faith, that would comprehend revelation, but it accentuates the possibility and necessity of giving faith an expression in the form of science. It thus acquires the peculiar task: inasmuch as it sets revelation as a transcendent being's free communication, which no human cunning could discover and which none can dissolve into concepts, and demands that human knowledge give up its autonomy in favor of revelation's authority, of determining revelation and God's essence and working in such a way that they are drawn out of the purely incomprehensible, and on the other hand of letting the concept of knowledge be so transformed, be it by a "heightening" or by an extension, that it can give place to that which yet can never and shall never in the proper sense be comprehended, and of making possible a science that follows another law than that of autonomous knowledge, also embraces that which is unappropriable for this knowledge, and yet does not cease to be science.

The possibility of this task's solution is what the critique of theology is to investigate. This critique will, as earlier indicated, attach itself closely to a determinate theological attempt that in our literature has acquired a peculiar significance and among us can be

regarded as the proper representative of the theological endeavor; but inasmuch as the critique attaches itself most closely to this, it will everywhere trace its treatment of the decisive points back to that which is typical for theology as theology and show it to be expressive of this, so that the critique, through the single theological attempt, relates itself to theology in general.

We first present in coherence this theological theory, which has been developed by Bishop Martensen in his various writings, in its essential fundamental features, in order thereby to indicate the points of attachment for the critique.

The task of the science of faith is this: to unite faith and knowledge in an organic unity, so that on the one hand faith is asserted in its primacy, on the other hand its essential connection with knowledge comes forward. Faith has the primacy because it, as the immediate, is the first, while knowledge, as the mediate, is the derived, and because faith is far richer than knowledge: a new life in the soul, a relation of existence, and can never be exhausted by the comprehending knowledge; but its unity with knowledge must be asserted because faith, which in itself embraces will, feeling, and cognition, is itself in knowledge: the central knowledge, so that knowledge becomes the common determination for science and faith. Precisely this relation makes a "Christian," "religious," "believing" science possible. That faith has the determination of knowledge in itself follows from the fact that God has revealed himself to faith, and that his love and grace have made themselves known under the form of wisdom, as also from the fact that the believer, in virtue of the Christian idea of truth contained in the living faith, must be able to say: I know what I believe. Were faith not already in itself a knowledge, then it would not be the faith of *truth*, and the great opposition between truth and lie, pronounced on every page of Holy Scripture, would be without significance. Were faith not itself a knowledge, then the believer could not confess his faith and could not reject and combat the perverse and erring doctrines. This knowledge in religion itself is what was designated as the primitive, the central knowledge, and, where it comes forward with special vigor, it can be designated as the central intuition, which has in itself the drive to unfold itself into concept. From this proceeds the scientific, the reflecting and speculating (intuiting in the mirror of the idea and seeking possibilities) cognition.

In accordance with this relation between faith and knowledge, the science of faith must stand in a relation of dependence, but in a free relation of dependence, to revelation. Christianity's absolute truth must be acknowledged as given prior to and independent of all speculation; cognition shall be a cognition in faith and out of faith (*credo ut intelligam*). The holy thought of wisdom must in the believing consciousness become the principle of

thought, and human thought is able only through it to search out the depths of revelation, to scrutinize for connection and ground in the Christian representations, to strive to bring forth a spiritual counter-image of the eternal wisdom of revelation.

The Christian science of faith would present the Christian intuition as a doctrinal concept coherent in itself. It is not content with an explicative comprehension, but seeks, in accordance with an inner drive, a speculative one, which does not remain standing at presenting the connection in the given, but asks about possibility and ground. Every «*Ita*» contains a hidden «*Quare*», which under the thorough explication cannot but come forward and call for a higher speculative comprehension. Yet the science of faith, since its object is not a mere truth of reason, but a positive truth, a truth of faith, cannot develop its content or demonstrate its truths with the mathematical and logical necessity peculiar to the merely rational science: there arises a boundary, not indeed for the certainty, but for the clarity; but this is not a defect in the science of faith; it points precisely to its higher worth.

This becomes clear both when we look to what is this science's proper organ in the human spirit, and when we look to its objective principle, to the concept of God that determines it.

As regards the first point, faith is determined as a will's appropriation in love of the divine revelation. The will is accordingly that function of the human spirit to which it has its essential relation, but the will is, just as it is the first in the universe, the properly constitutive in the human personality: man's fundamental being is will. But thus the will becomes the highest, that which has the primacy in relation to the other functions of spirit, which are dependent on it. That what is grasped in faith through the will is not commensurable with thought, with the concept, therefore shows only that the former is the higher and richer.

And to the same result we are led when we consider the science of faith's objective principle. The principle of the science of faith is a higher than that to which the merely logical thinking attains; it is not "reason's dead idol," but an ethical principle, a real principle of personality, a supernatural principle. The ethical concept of God is the higher, which does not exclude, but includes, the logical and physical. It is the concept of the free, willing, personal God, of the not merely logical but holy, absolute truth. The personal God, who is not the idea-bound, but the idea-free, just as he is the nature-free, reveals as creating and miracle-working his freedom and omnipotence, and in his revelation through history the same freedom of personality and of will makes itself felt, in opposition to nature's and the merely logical's necessity, and it shows itself in its

highest form where God not only reveals himself through his workings, but reveals himself in his personal appearance in the historical Christ.

With this concept of God there enters another concept of science than where there is question only of a merely logical and physical knowledge: there is reached the concept of a positive philosophy, the concept of a science of revelation, in which theology becomes the central science. Of the science of revelation in general holds that which was said above of theology, that it does not demonstrate its truths with logical and geometrical necessity, and that it can bring it only to a relative comprehension of the highest truths; but this is precisely the mark of the higher and real science, of the higher cognition of reality. The science of revelation and particularly theology must, by the nature of the case, be richer in intuition than in concept, but it is intuition that gives the dialectic its worth; for intuition is the organ for the whole and reaches further and deeper into the very innermost of things, to their first beginnings and roots, than the merely dianoetic thinking. The science of faith is therefore science in the preeminent sense, while the natural sciences can in no way in the stricter sense be called sciences, and while the mere philosophy of reason, the negative philosophy, is only propaedeutic, a child's lesson in comparison with that higher wisdom. The latter's peculiar scientific character and higher worth lie precisely in the relation to the free, personal God and his revelation, to the holy will that is the measure of what things in the last meaning are. Just as revelation has proceeded from the divine will's freedom, not governed by an abstract logical or physical necessity, so too its apprehension is conditioned by a free act of will, which determines thought, is not determined by it. The divine revelation can, as a revelation of freedom, a revelation of personality, not be apprehended in the forms of logical necessity, not be dissolved into mere conceptual determinations; it can, as a communication of life, not be taken up through the forms of thought alone. In all revelation of freedom there is something incommensurable with the purely logical thinking, and therefore this thinking inevitably lacks the eye for the historical that characterizes the higher science. But when in the cognition of the revelation of freedom one goes beyond the domain of the merely logical, we are yet not led out onto the domain of the lawless, for the divine freedom is no groundless arbitrariness; it contains a higher necessity, but one that lets itself be cognized only voluntarily. The free divine omnipotence is, as creating and miracle-working, determined by love and wisdom, hence by an ethical necessity of freedom, and necessity in the general meaning acquires again its relative validity, inasmuch as a physical becomes the condition for the ethical will in God, and inasmuch as God is indeed nature-free, but not nature-less, inasmuch as there is in God an eternal

physis that stands in essential relation to the will. In this relation there is also given a point of attachment for thought, by which the spiritual God's creating of a material nature, and his immediate miraculous working, even though the how of creation and of the miracle eternally withdraws itself from human comprehension, is yet raised above the purely incomprehensible, in a certain measure becomes the object of a cognizing.

Thus, then, the possibility of the science of faith is grounded in a higher cognition determined by faith and will, a cognition for which revelation's truth opens itself so far as the divine can be grasped by the human spirit's frailty, while the knowledge that by the human spirit's own power and own means, by mere reason, would comprehend the divine revelation, must distort and deny its truth. The higher cognition is the consummation, the redemption of mankind's general cognition of reason, a higher potency of reason's revelation. Revelation in Christ abolishes the laws of reason in their abstraction in order to confirm them in the Christ-wisdom that is the fullness of the law of reason. And the higher cognition includes in itself the norm and the corrective for the lower; by it the higher science is the ruling science, and thus the right relation is brought about in the world of thought: οὐκ ἀγαθὸν πολυκοιρανίη, εἷς κοίρανος ἔστω.

3.2 The Relation of Will to Knowledge and to the Essence of the Human

What is justified in this theory, that which has an unconditional claim to acknowledgment, is the endeavor to bring the human spirit's highest forms of expression, its most essential fundamental relations, into inner harmony. The goal toward which there is striving is the spirit's highest: the spirit's true reconciliation. Even though, therefore, the means by which what is aimed at is sought to be reached are insufficient, even though the way that is followed cannot lead to the goal, this theory will yet constantly be able to make claim to a respectful, unprejudiced, and penetrating critique, all the more as it comes forward in a form that is not only fine and full of spirit, but bears the unmistakable stamp of personal conviction.

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The critique of the theory must from the beginning be directed against a point that is the whole theory's scientific center of gravity; against its determination of the will's relation to knowledge and to the essence in the human and in the divine.

For on this determination, according to which the will is set as the primitive, the essence-grounding in the human and in the divine personality, and as including in itself knowledge as a governed moment, there rests on the one hand the apprehension of a science that goes beyond the boundary of merely logical knowledge, and yet not only, by the moment of knowledge that the will includes, asserts for itself the character of science, but precisely by its overstepping of that boundary acquires a higher worth;—and on the other hand there rests thereon the apprehension of God as in his free willing raised above knowledge's abstract necessity and above the essence-determined freedom that is only a *libera necessitas*, and yet as in his being and working remaining the object of a relative knowledge. When the will's primacy is asserted, then knowledge's necessity is governed, its binding law subjected to the subject's infinite freedom and its individual urge, then the relation of cognition is dependent on a relation of will and the will is entitled, as choosing the truth, to correct cognition's consequences. When the will is set as the primitive in God, then God is the creating and miracle-working, the freely self-revealing, and with this concept of God the concept of the demanded higher science, of its coming into being through a free communication from its principle, is immediately given.

The point of departure for the critical investigation must be taken in the psychological, whose apprehension becomes in general decisive for the determination of faith's and knowledge's relation. In the apprehension of the psychological, the development in Martensen attaches itself most closely to the single philosophers who stand near to theology. It is particularly the not very clear thinker J. H. Fichte from whom the determination of the psychological fundamental relations is drawn, and what he has set forth in the introduction to his still unfinished *Psychology* is reproduced in part with his own words. It is said¹ to be the result of the deeper psychological observation, a result in which J. Böhme, Fr. Baader, Schelling, and the younger Fichte agree, that not thought or reason, but the will is the first, innermost, most original, and most central in the human soul, that both our theoretical and our practical consciousness has its psychological root in a pre-conscious will, which manifests itself in these two main forms, that accordingly self-consciousness and thought itself is a form of the will, namely the form of mirroring, in which the willing being objectifies itself, itself and its world. But inasmuch as self-consciousness and thinking are in themselves nothing other than the mere act of mirroring, they presuppose a really willing subject that mirrors itself therein. This real subject, whose fundamental being is will, is the substantial, consciousness is

¹Martensen: *Om Tro og Viden* pp. 45 f. 123 f. 129.

only quality, predicate, attribute for it: it is that through which the real being comes to clarity about itself and its relations, that through which the pre-conscious, potential will actualizes itself. —All observation is also to lead us back to desire, drive, and instinct as the first psychological, hence to an obscure will that includes reason and cognition, as that out of which consciousness develops. And if we ask about the fundamental relation of cognition and will in the actual consciousness, it is not cognition either, but the ethical will that has the primacy; not the ethical will as a merely practical, cognition-less will, but the ethical will that has cognition, the contemplative, as its own moment. And as in man the will is the first, not thought, so it is also in objective existence, in the universe, and thus, as theism precisely develops, will, not knowledge, is the first in God, and the ethical idea, the good, which is the will's idea, is the highest, the absolute idea, to which nothing is coordinated, but all subordinated.

The untenable in the reported psychological theory shows itself as soon as the main points in it are more closely illuminated.

1. Inasmuch as the will is set as the primitive, there is a going back to the concept of a "pre-conscious will" (Fichte's "vorbewußter Wille"), which is to be that out of which the spiritual life's various forms develop. But what is called "pre-conscious will" is, precisely as pre-conscious, i.e. as not yet will, not will; for will is—as Martensen himself concedes by letting the will be actualized through self-consciousness—only as conscious will. Therefore that will is also to be only an "obscure" will. But when the concept of will in the stricter sense becomes inapplicable, the question must be raised: what it is in the determination will that becomes applicable to that primitive working. The answer must be: it is the determination of energy; but energy as a subject's, a self's energy we designate as selfhood-energy. Energy is not a predicate of a presupposed subject, for thus apprehended the subject would become the energy-less, its connection with the predicate contradictory; energy is an essence-determination, expression for the very essence as ideal-real². But the essence-energy, the selfhood-energy, comes forward first through the organic forming; through this it forms the conditions for the will, but just as fully and just as originally the conditions for cognition: the selfhood-energy therefore stands in its first form of appearance no closer to the former than to the latter, and inasmuch as the will and cognition are realized, energy becomes the determination for both, the concept embracing both, and we speak with the same right of an energy of cognition as of an

²The "real, willing being" is in Martensen and Fichte a contradictory reminiscence of Herbart's immutable, inactive, and unconscious Real. "Reality" here becomes for Martensen a meaningless determination; it could at most designate the monadic, but thereby, in this connection, nothing would be gained.

energy of will; in cognition and will energy realizes its inner possibility in two mutually supplementing fundamental forms. That one has transferred the will's determination to energy and designated it as pre-conscious will, also at the stage where the will would be only physically (organically) working, derives from a misunderstanding of the will's relation to energy and to real working. While one on the one hand overlooks cognition's determination as energy and the cognitive activity's unconscious working upon the real in the organism, one overlooks on the other hand that inasmuch as the will as will exercises a conscious working upon the real, this its activity presupposes the selfhood-energy's organ-forming activity, which continues also after the will as will has come to appearance, is independent of the will, and precisely thereby distinctly separates itself from it. Inasmuch as one calls the original energy will, one slips in the representation of a being working as it were behind our essence, whose activity is represented in analogy with the conscious will's working upon an external through the organism.

2. If there thus takes place a confusion of concepts in the determination of the primitive in the *essence*, then the determination of that which for observation is the psychologically first suffers from a similar confusion. The first for observation becomes, when one thereby understands the first psychological functions that go beyond the merely organic forming, not desire and drive. Instinct one could at a pinch use as designation for this first, but instinct would then, just as in animal life, from which the designation is taken, embrace intelligence's and will's most rudimentary working, the unconscious and half-conscious functions of cognition, and the unconscious and half-conscious functions of will. The first psychological is that to which desire and drive point back. Desire and drive are a striving to hold fast or to remove a determinate state; but this state is only a state of the self as felt, through the organic sensation or the sense-sensation. The psychologically first is accordingly sensation: cognition's rudimentary form, just as drive is the will's rudimentary form. This relation is conceded by Martensen in so far as it is said that in the relation of reflection, i.e. in the relation to the objective, it is to be correct to set the will as the second, cognition as the first. But in the relation to the subject itself the will is to be the first. This distinction can, however, not be maintained. The self's relation to itself is constantly a relation to itself as a member in an existence, as determined by the objective. Even in sensation's most primitive form as organic sensation, in which the self relates itself to its own side of reality, the relation to the objective, which is set as such in the sense-sensation, is implicitly present. But the organic sensation is the first form of the self's being-for-itself.

3. The apprehension of self-consciousness and thought as a mere reflection, which is

asserted by Martensen, is impracticable. They are to be the real, willing being's mirroring, in which it objectifies itself. But mirroring expresses reflection. In consciousness's mirroring the real being is set as reflected in itself. But such a reflection is the absolutely inexplicable when reflection is not originally set as an essence-determination. Without this the essence would not become clear to itself in reflection, would not objectify itself for itself. The reflection would merely become a reflection in another, apprehended by a supposed outside-standing consciousness. The essence would become the obscure-to-itself in spite of the supervening predicate, which as this subject's predicate would become a purely incomprehensible, and the willing that expressed the essence would, when reflection's determination inseparable from the actual will was taken away, be only a working similar to one material's mechanical working upon another material. If, on the contrary, reflection is set as an original essence-determination, then the essence is originally determined by reflection, i.e. unconscious thinking, by the universal self's being-for-itself. That apprehension of thought and consciousness as the originally reflection-less being's mirroring in itself would likewise make it absolutely inexplicable how a consciousness of another and a comprehension of this other can take place. Only where reflection becomes an original determination is there given, in the self's doubling, in the determination of otherness thereby set within the self, the connection to a relation to the otherness outside the self.

4. By the determination Martensen gives of the psychological fundamental relation, he cannot avoid entangling himself in contradictions. It is a contradiction when there is talk of a common root for the will and cognition, when they are accordingly coordinated, and the will is yet set as the higher unity. It is likewise a contradiction when the will, which is to be the primitive, as will is to be actualized by self-consciousness; for that by which the actualization takes place must be the first, just as it must be a substantial. It is a contradiction that the will, not reason, is to be the first; for thus the will as reason-less would have to ground reason. It is finally a contradiction that Martensen pronounces that knowledge and will cannot be separated, that the one cannot be without the other (p. 40), and that he everywhere urges an *essential* significance for the theoretical alongside the practical, but yet would deprive thought and self-consciousness of substantiality and reduce them to being merely quality and reflection.

Against the psychological determinations given by Martensen we then set, supported on the foregoing developments, the following:

The fundamental determination of the human essence is a selfhood-energy that reveals itself in knowledge and will.

Knowledge and will both stand in that relation to the essence, to the substantial, that they cannot be determined as qualities of a presupposed “real” essence, but must be apprehended as forms of being for the subjective essence, as substantial forms of essence.

In the development of the human soul’s life the psychologically first is cognition’s first rudimentary form.

In accordance with that which marks the human essence’s peculiarity in relation to the animal’s: the essence’s universality, the form of subjective being-for-itself conditioned by universality, which, determined by the universal relation to itself, comes forward in the energy of self-consciousness and thought, becomes the form of being principal according to concept for the human essence.

The significance and power that are ascribed by Martensen to the will, in accordance with its posited primacy, in relation to cognition (as governing thinking and as choosing truth), cannot be maintained; it rests essentially on a confusion of concepts, partly of the will and the energy of cognition, partly of the will and the human essence determined as self by energy.

From these psychological determinations it will then follow as a consequence that there cannot belong to the will, inasmuch as it determines itself as ethical, an autonomy and a primacy in the meaning in which Martensen ascribes it to it. The will becomes ethical will first as determined by cognition: the cognition of the good is the condition for willing it³.

The ethical will is an essence-willing, but the essence is principally the being disposed to self-consciousness, thinking according to its concept: an essence-willing is therefore determined by cognition, by self-conscious thought.

3.3 Will and Knowledge in God

The same fundamental relation that was posited with respect to the human essence is, as already stated, also posited with respect to the divine. The concept of God to which philosophy attains through the cognition of nature and reason, and which expresses the absolute principle of reason and of the thought-determined reality, is not, even though it determines the Absolute as absolute subjectivity, to be the true concept of God, not to be the expression for the actual God, and it is not so because God is in it determined by knowledge, and along a logical way. In his truth and reality God is to be apprehended only when he is apprehended as the God whose essence is will, and when the ethical

³cf. Martensen’s statement (*Om Tro og Viden* p. 26): the existing good is the condition for our willing of the good, for our striving after it.

concept of God resting upon this apprehension, reached through a cognition determined by the will, which determines him as the *Good*, as the personal God, supersedes the logical-physical⁴, which it is yet not to exclude, but to preserve in itself as a moment. The ethical concept of God, which, in opposition to the logical-physical, apprehends God as a supernatural principle, sets determinations of will, such as: absolute freedom, holiness, love, as this supernatural principle of spirit's determinations; it determines God as the personal creator-God. In this determinateness God becomes the object of the higher science, which Martensen gives the name of science of revelation or philosophy of religion.

As regards this apprehension of the will's relation to God's essence and the concept of God conditioned thereby, it is now at once evident that the apparent grounding by which, for man's part, the will was to be asserted as the principal, and which without further ado seems to be supposed to hold for the divine, can acquire no application to the latter, onto which the human's relations could not immediately be transferred. The obscure, pre-conscious will, which in man is set as presupposition for the conscious will and for thinking, acquires no place in the divine essence; for even though there is talk of a physis, a ground of nature, in God, God is yet not to be thought as coming-to-be out of this obscure, consciousness-less ground, but as eternally being in his free knowledge of himself, in the knowledge that has its reality in the Trinity. Knowledge and will have then the same eternity in God, nor can there, when this relation is regarded, be ascribed to the will a primacy of concept; for the will in its clarity would precisely have God's knowledge of himself as conceptual presupposition, and if a higher third were to be sought, it would be to be sought, not in the will, but in the divine self's energy, by which it eternally sets its being and sets it as determined by omniscience and omnipotence.

If, then, the will's primacy in the divine is to be asserted, it must happen along another way: it must be asserted by showing that inasmuch as the will *as will*, that is, in its original autonomy, not as determined by cognition, is the principle of the ethical, it as such must be the highest, because the ethical, which expresses freedom, is the higher in relation to the logical and physical, which do not reach beyond necessity.

⁴By the logical concept of God Martensen understands (cf. *Om Tro og Viden*, p. 11) "the concept of God as impersonal idea, all-intelligence, Noûs, ontological subjectivity, or the like"; by the physical "the concept of God as an all-producing nature, *natura naturans*, substance, etc."; by the ethical: "the concept of God as personality and will, as the God of the good, of love, of grace, and the God of the not merely logical but holy truth".

3.4 Critique of the Concept of God

That the will as will was the principle of the ethical would be demonstrated if it were shown that the ethical was higher than the logical in such a way that it could not be taken up by the latter, but yet included it, in the same way as it is to be higher than the physical, which it is to include as a moment. But a development by which this was shown is not given in Martensen, although he in many turns of phrase pronounces that the ethical concept of God is the highest and the absolutely true; and by the determinations he gives, the postulated relation transforms itself arbitrarily: that which was postulated to be a higher goes back to that in comparison with which it was to be the higher, indeed, it even goes down below this. And this is in him nothing accidental, but is grounded in the nature of the case. This is here to be demonstrated with respect to the ethical's relation to the logical; it will later be demonstrated with respect to its relation to the physical.

3.4.1 The Relation of the Ethical Concept of God to the Logical

When the ethical concept of God is set by Martensen as higher than the logical and physical, this is not to be apprehended as if it comprehended the logical and the physical in a logical-physical unity that as such becomes the higher, but in such a way that it, inasmuch as it includes in itself the logical-physical, is a higher than this very unity. But from this follows the immediate consequence, which is really only a tautological paraphrase of the relation, that the essence of the ethical cannot be determined by an immanent development of thought. Were the essence and relation of the ethical determined by such a one, it would itself go in under the logical and become only its highest concept; logic would, as metaphysics, also be the ethical's metaphysics, include the fundamental concepts of ethics, naturally in logical determinateness of form.

In order to maintain the presupposition, the ethical must be set as transcending the logical according to its *whole* extent, and this could be apprehended either in such a way that another relation to reality was posited in the ethical than in the logical, or in such a way that the ethical was given a content richer than that of the logical.

To the first apprehension we are pointed when Martensen sets the relation to existence as the decisive thing. The ethical is to be a higher than the logical because it points to existence, while the logical is to be indifferent to existence, to have only ideal, not factual being. But this opposition and these determinations rest on an unclarity. The logical, as subjective, formal logical, has only a "thought-being." The logical, apprehended in

unity with the ontological, expresses that which has ideal-real being. "Factual existence," which, in opposition to this being, would be only external, finite being, it does not have, but it grounds that which exists in this form. And the being of the ethical is precisely a being of the same kind as that of the logical-metaphysical; the ethical concept of God has as concept the same sphere as the logical. Were the existence of the ethical of another kind, it would be only that finite, sensible existence, and it will later show itself, in the development of the concept of personality, that Martensen precisely cannot free himself from the representation of this. But if now the being of the ethical is of the same kind as that of the logical, then there could accordingly not, through the relation to the latter, be secured for the will the demanded primacy.

As regards the second apprehension, it will not be able to be maintained, neither when we look to the relation that must be set in the eternal principle between its forms of activity, nor when we look to the relation of human cognition. For if we look to the first-named relation, it lies in the concept of the eternally actual God that there must be set in God an eternal unity and congruence of knowledge and will—both concepts apprehended thus as they can be transferred to the Absolute—, that nothing can be set by God's will that is not transparent in his knowledge, which must be thought as that which makes his will manifest, while this has his knowledge for its content. And if we look to the second relation, it shows itself that the fact that the ethical is determined as richer with respect to content must lead to the ethical's supra-logical content having to be set as that which can only be grasped through another function of spirit than the logical: by a "free thinking," as Schelling expresses it; by "a knowledge that has gone through the will," as Baader designates it; by a willing knowledge, a knowledge chosen by the will, as Martensen would say. But the possibility of this relation cannot be demonstrated. To point to the will as to a principle absolutely heterogeneous with knowledge, in the way Nielsen apprehends it, is cut off by the presuppositions. Were that relation therefore to be made thinkable, it would have to happen in such a way that the logical thinking at once determined its own boundary and pointed out beyond it, and at the same time indicated the organ that was to supersede it, and stated a negative norm with respect to that which fell outside the boundary, a norm that secured against the arbitrary and absurd being set as a higher truth. But such a self-delimitation of thought by thought itself is the impossible. As expression for the essence-energy, thought is a reality, every one of its activities is a confirmation, a corroboration of this reality, a self-confirmation: an activity by which it was to negate itself is therefore a self-contradictory. The relation would then have to be determined in such a way that not thought as such, but the

thinking subject out of its totality of essence, embracing also other functions, delimited thought. But from the psychological developments given in the foregoing it follows that this subject in its unity must enclose the fundamental functions as harmoniously united, as determined by the same goal, and that knowledge, cognition, as a whole, is a fundamental function, and that which in the human spirit has ideal priority. Nor along this way, then, could that posited relation be asserted. Were one to let the ethical as the higher come forward by a break, and yet at the same time hold it fast as that which included knowledge, then the knowledge that the ethical will included would be only homonymous with the knowledge that preceded the break, and is knowledge in the strict sense. The relation would then in reality be the relation between two absolutely heterogeneous principles, which as such could not reasonably be set as standing in the relation of super- and subordination to one another that Martensen posits.

It thus shows itself to be not accidental that the postulated relation is not demonstrated as the true one: a demonstration of it is an impossibility. And if we were to suppose that the will's primacy in the indicated meaning were asserted, it would imply that our knowledge's necessity was not only suspended for the higher domain's part, but in general made impossible. Were the will asserted as the essence-grounding, then the concept of essence would be absorbed in that of the will, the necessity of essence would then be abolished in the will's freedom, which, as transcending the necessity of essence, would become *absolute* arbitrariness («*bonum est quia deus vult*»); knowledge would in God, as expression for the will preceding the essence, determining the essence, only express the absolute arbitrariness's consciousness of itself and of that which is arbitrarily set by the arbitrariness; and in man it would in the same way lack every ground of necessity. And when thus the will's primacy abolished knowledge's necessity, this would imply that in reality it could never become an object of knowledge, when knowledge is taken in the proper meaning.

When, for the indicated reasons, it is impracticable to furnish a proof for the set-up relation, then it becomes inevitable that the relation transforms itself where there is made, most nearly in the form of thetically set-up propositions, an attempt to give closer determinations with respect to the ethical concept of God's higher worth than that of the logical. The essence with its necessity, which becomes knowledge's determination, acquires involuntarily the primacy in relation to the will. The demonstration of this becomes so far the less essential, as the developments given by Martensen could suffer from accidental defects; but it is yet of interest, after the general relation has been demonstrated above, to see how the natural relation involuntarily makes itself felt, in

spite of the point of departure's conflict therewith.

We here emphasize those determinations of the relation between the ethical and the logical, between the will and knowledge, that come forward inasmuch as the relation between the Good (one) and the good is to be indicated, and we emphasize them also for the reason that they include moments for the apprehension of the concept of the freedom that was to raise the will above knowledge. The relation between the good and the Good points back to those relations, inasmuch as the good, as "the eternally existing good," points to the theoretical, the Good, in accordance with the indicated apprehension of the constitutive, to the will. The development of this relation is in Martensen vacillating and uncertain, and leads precisely to the opposite result of the intended. It is said⁵ that the good—which is demanded with necessity—can only exist as a free will, and therefore must be determined as the Good. "Now," it is continued, "God as the Good is doubtless the one existing with necessity; but were he only this, then we had not yet come out beyond the physical and logical; for a God who is only good with necessity (the good nature) is not the in-truth ethical God. But the good as his essence's necessity demands precisely that he with freedom realizes it, or that he, as the one who does not have a law outside himself or above himself, but who is to himself the holy law, as the absolutely autonomous, actualizes, brings forth himself as the Good, and in so far as he brings forth the good outside himself, does not do it by natural necessity, but by freedom's necessity." —Precisely in the given determinations lies that, when there is to be talk of a law at all, the essence-determination and the essence-necessity becomes the first, the presupposition for the will; accordingly the essence becomes the holy law: the good becomes law for the Good. And when there is talk of an actualizing, then there lies in the concept of actualization a working, hence an activity not yet determined as "the Good's" will, hence an energy determined by the essence-necessity, which acquires its expression in knowledge, by which the ethical will is, and which, inasmuch as it is the ideally grounding, becomes the principal. And this essence-necessary working can, since God is not to be coming-to-be, and since he is eternally knowing, not be brought by Martensen in under "the obscure will's" determination.

To the same result lead also the subsequent developments, in which the ethical concept of God is to be shown as the truth of the logical and physical. As the absolutely willing, God is at the same time to be the absolutely knowing, who knows himself in an eternal ideal-system. But the ethical God is not to be the in-the-idea-included, idea-bound, and so to speak in-the-idea-absorbed God. His knowledge is to determine

⁵Martensen: *Om Tro og Viden*, p. 67 f.

itself as wisdom, which is precisely to designate the absolutely idea-free in his existence in opposition to heathendom's idea-bound, merely logical God, and to designate his knowledge not merely as a logical, but as an ethical, a willing knowledge. —For when God is set as the *absolutely* knowing, he accordingly also knows himself in the determination of the Good, and inasmuch as in God there can be no talk of a merely reflecting or of an inadequate knowledge, the divine will goes in under knowledge's necessity, is seen as the form for the essence's *libera necessitas*. And when knowledge is determined as wisdom, then wisdom's *content* and wisdom's *goal* lead back to the same overarching of knowledge, however much there is talk of the difference between eternal ideas and eternal counsels. The determination of God's relation to the idea becomes very unclear and the idea raises itself, against what is intended, as the highest. The idea expresses a logical, but yet not only are the ideas to have their principle of unity in God, although the absolute idea, which yet would surely have to be the ideas' principle of unity, is not to be God; but an idea: the will's idea, is to be the expression for the ethically determined God, accordingly for that which is above the logical, and the absolute personality is apprehended as the highest *ontological* determination. The will's idea is to be that under which all is subordinated. It is to include the determination of existence, accordingly precisely that determination which is to characterize the actual God in distinction from the logical concept of God.

The result of what has been developed is accordingly: that the attempts to determine the relation between will and knowledge in the divine essence through the relation between the ethical and the logical must lead back to the unity of the will and its freedom with knowledge and its necessity, so that the logical comes to embrace also the concept of the ethical God, and that what has been set forth about the will's primacy and what stands in connection therewith is not demonstrated and cannot be demonstrated.

3.4.2 The Freedom of the Divine Will

What has been developed with respect to the relation between will and knowledge in connection with the relation between the ethical and the logical can acquire a new illumination from the fact that the set-up concept of the will as principle of freedom is analyzed, and thereby the posited freedom's kind and relation to knowledge's necessity is clarified, since it will thereby show itself why this freedom cannot assert for the will the demanded precedence in relation to that determined by necessity. The result of this analysis is in essentials anticipated in the determinations won through the foregoing developments.

We here, as in the earlier developments, leave aside the question: how far the transference of the psychological determination will onto God is at all justified, and whether this concept must not necessarily in this transference onto the Absolute undergo a transformation; a question to which we come back in the development of the concept of God's personality. We here raise, inasmuch as we apply the concepts will and knowledge to the divine, the question: how would that freedom be determined by which the will was to be asserted as the principal, as the superordinate in relation to knowledge and its necessity? The freedom that was to raise the will to this significance would have to be a freedom loosened from the determination of necessity, for this determination, as determination by freedom, would lead it back to the essence's and knowledge's in their ground identical necessity. But such a freedom would, as the *absolutely* necessity-less freedom, be a *liberium arbitrium* that has no ground in the essence, and therefore becomes only groundless arbitrariness. That it is in fact apprehended thus will become clear when the doctrine of creation and the doctrine of the miracles are analyzed. But a freedom of this kind, which moreover, by annihilating all of knowledge's necessity, would annihilate knowledge and become a "non-intelligent" freedom, would not be able to assert for the will a higher validity. Just as it is itself a lower than the freedom determined by the necessity of reason, than that essence's *libera necessitas* which expresses the self-transparent essence's law of freedom and reveals itself equally in knowledge and the will, so it would make the will, not the highest, but a lower; it would set a sublate of human arbitrariness, a mere fantasy-image of the will, in place of the will's true concept: to be essence-willing, expression for the total essence's energy, in which knowledge and will are in unity, and which therefore can express itself only law-determinedly, in free necessity.

Through that concept of freedom the will, which is designated as "the only principle that can begin anything," is set not only as knowledge's, but as the essence's *prius*; in its aseity it at once sets the essence and transcends it⁶. Instead of being an utterance of essence, bound by the essence's law of freedom and the essence's content, it accordingly becomes an unlimited will borne by nothing, which proteus-like transforms itself and can will everything possible⁷ i.e. all *the possibilities of fantasy*; for this will is in its lawlessness precisely determined only by the barrierless fantasy's lawless omnipotence. Were the will itself set as essence, this would either lead to the will, against the presupposition,

⁶The distinction of will and essence becomes clear in the doctrine of creation out of nothing. Inasmuch as God creates by the will out of nothing, he does not create out of the essence, and the distinction between will and essence is set. The will sets being, sets the essence, but transcends being and essence.

⁷This finds its expression in the representation of an "all-possibility," and of God as "the lord of possibilities."

acquiring the determination of necessity in itself, or—when the freedom in that meaning was maintained—to freedom, that is, arbitrariness, in its unboundness by all conditions, hence also by that set by itself, negating this in every utterance of freedom, hence negating the will identical with the essence, whose determination it itself is, so that the will accordingly, while it was to be an essential, i.e. an abiding, unabolishable, would only be in the incessant change that is only self-abolition.

Through that concept of freedom, which stands in close connection with the “ethical” concept of God, it thus becomes impossible to assert the will’s precedence in the divine. We are again pointed to the necessity of setting will and knowledge in eternal unity and congruence in the divine, of setting the ethical and logical in unity, and it becomes evident that the endeavors to assert for the will that higher worth, inasmuch as they must aim at excluding all determination of necessity from it, must precisely acquire the opposite result of the intended, namely: to draw the will and that which is called the ethical and freedom in God down below that which was to be the subordinate: below knowledge, below the logical and below the essence-necessity. But the name of the ethical and of freedom is also only used here by a misuse; that which is so named does not even reach to the boundary of the ethical, does not touch the true concept of freedom, in general not the sphere of the concept.

3.4.3 God’s Personality

What has been said concerning the apprehension of the concepts treated is confirmed by the apprehension of God’s personality determined thereby.

In order first to be able to apply this concept to God at all, the objection must be met that personality, as presupposing limitation by an other, hence finitude, is inapplicable as a determination for the Absolute. This objection is essentially met only through postulates. It is to be invalid because the fact that besides God there are created beings is not to be a barrier that violates the concept of the perfect being. Self-limitation is to be inseparable from the perfect nature. “God mirrors the fullness of his essence in the inner infinity of his self-consciousness and thereby in truth takes it into possession. For an all-perfect being that does not know of its perfection lacks a very essential perfection. God limits his power inasmuch as he calls forth out of his eternal depth of life a world of created beings, to which he gives, in a derived sense, to have life in themselves; but precisely by being the power in a free world, he reveals the inner greatness of his power. For not that power is the true one which tolerates no stirring of freedom outside itself, because it itself would immediately be all and work all; but that power is the true one

which creates freedom, and which nonetheless is able to make itself all in all.”

These determinations, which are not reached through a deduction, but only thetically set forth, link together immediately self-abolishing oppositions (e.g. “a power that creates freedom,” “in a derived sense to have life in themselves”), and transfer concepts from one sphere to another where precisely that is lacking which gives them their determinateness. Self-consciousness is postulated of God as *conditio sine qua non* for perfection. But self-consciousness, such as we know it in *man*, that is, such as we know it at all, is possible only through the opposition to otherness, hence through limitedness. But in God it is to precede the limitation by an other and nevertheless be self-consciousness. The limitation necessary for human self-consciousness is then yet brought into God *afterward* by the fact that the self-conscious God limits himself by calling forth out of his eternal depth of life that world of created beings, to which he gives, in a derived sense, to have life in themselves. He limits himself, and this limitation becomes not only a limitation by a spiritual, by a life of freedom centralized in itself, which has the possibility of setting itself in a relation of opposition to God's will, but a limitation by a material, by an other opposed to God's spiritual essence, and yet it is not to do harm to the infinity: the infinity is to be *inner* infinity. But by what then does God's essence distinguish itself from every single spiritual, indeed, from every single living creature, which also has inner infinity? *Inner* infinity is relative abstract infinity, relative abstract relation to itself through its abolished other, or else possibility's infinity; but can this be an adequate determination of God? is it a determination that removes finitude from him? These questions we can only answer in the negative.

But inasmuch as it does not succeed in freeing the determination of personality from limitation, finitude, the consequence becomes that God is by that determination constantly drawn down into the sphere of finite representation, that the representation of the sensibly determined individuality slips in under the concept of God's personality. This representation of the sensible single individual Martensen cannot and will not keep away from the apprehension of the divine. He says⁸: “the personal God must inevitably be thought analogous with the psychological consciousness,” and by “analogous” is here understood, as appears from the subsequent developments, more than a mere analogy: there is understood thereby the identity of form. The necessity of holding fast that finite representation lies in the double that is aimed at through the determination of God as personal. There is aimed at, in the first place, to give God a being *outside our thought*: precisely the determination of personality is to hold God in the single

⁸Martensen: Om Tro og Viden, p. 47.

existence's distinction from the human, to assert the transcendence of representation. But this distinction by an "outside," by which emphasis is laid on God's not merely being in our thought, our spirit, not merely having the being of the ideal, makes precisely God *finite* by giving his being a determinateness of *sensibility*, even though this is again formally negated. There is aimed at, in *the second* place, to free God from the law of necessity, to find a point of attachment for the apprehension of will and freedom criticized above, and since this cannot be found above the universal, it is sought *below* it in the representation of the single being, which in the finitude that the relation of consciousness intimates has a possibility for the will's arbitrary loosening from the universal of the necessity of reason,—admittedly only on the condition that the will unconsciously falls in under the universal of natural necessity; and the determination of the human single being is therefore transferred onto the divine. Precisely for the reason that this double is sought in the determination of God's personality, the concept of an idea of subjectivity, of an absolute subjectivity, that is, of an absolutely concrete subjectivity, does not satisfy—one that does not, like the human, in abstract self-consciousness set itself off from its object of consciousness and its content of consciousness, but in its being-for-itself sets and idealizingly comprehends the totality of the real. Without one's giving account of the transformation of the concept that must take place in the transference from the human personality, which is bound to the finitude-form of consciousness, to the absolutely infinite, there is demanded, in opposition to the concept of an absolute subjectivity, an "actual" subject, a "real subject";⁹ but actual and real become for Martensen synonymous with limited, finite, with an existing in the form of the human will and self-consciousness, although this last is by him explained only as a form of mirroring.

The same apprehension also makes itself felt in the closer determinations of this divine personality's relation to man in revelation, and of the organ for man's apprehension of the personal God.

Concerning the relation of revelation it is said¹⁰ that if God is the personal, willing God, then we can cognize neither more nor less of him than he himself will reveal to us. "It already holds in the relation between man and man that a personality can *only* be cognized by its free *actions*, and that every closer acquaintance rests on the fact that it itself will come to meet us and open itself to us in free communication; and this holds in the most eminent sense of the divine personality. *A priori* construct him we cannot; for only the logically necessary, but not the free spirit, lets itself be constructed *a priori*. Even the human genius cannot be constructed *a priori*, but only cognized when

⁹cf. Martensen: Om Tro og Viden pp. 38, 49, 53.

¹⁰Martensen: Om Tro og Viden, p. 93 f.

its wondrous reality is given. Only after the reality can we cognize that such a thing is possible, since its possibility far surpasses the mere possibilities of reason.” —It is here striking that the representation of the separated single existence is again brought in, and that it is therefore forgotten that God’s essence is determined as love, love accordingly as a necessary communication of essence, which, precisely according to Martensen, must also be apprehended as a communication to cognition. By the skewed analogy with the genius it is likewise overlooked that there is, in relation to God, no question of constructing *a priori* a historical future, but of comprehending a universal, eternal fundamental relation, a relation of essence. When there is then added: “no revelation of personality lets itself be dissolved into mere thought- determinations. It can only be grasped by intuition like everything individual and original, and here there is indeed question of the absolute single being,”—then it is forgotten that the “*absolute single being*” is *eo ipso ens universalissimum*, and when this last determination is overlooked, then there comes no comprehension at all, but only a sensible intuiting that relates itself to a sensibly determined. But the character of the “intuition” by which the higher relation of experience is to be realized, and which is to acquire its significance in the grounding of the higher science, will be more closely illuminated in the critique of the latter’s concept.

3.4.4 The Ethical Concept of God in Relation to the Physical

The juxtaposition of the *logical* concept of God with that which is designated as the ethical has accordingly shown the superiority of the first, has shown that the logical, apprehended in its unity with the metaphysical, embraces also the essence-determinations of the ethical—something Martensen himself involuntarily comes to concede by using the determinations the absolute idea, the idea of the good;—while that which was called the ethical concept of God, on account of the finite representation of personality, will, and freedom, does not reach the in-truth ethical, and, instead of becoming a higher than the logical, remains in the alogical, for which reason also the attempts to deduce this “concept of God’s” determinations rationally must fail. And when we now pass over from the consideration of the “ethical” concept of God’s content in relation to the logical to the consideration of its relation to the physical, then the essence-connection between the logical and the physical will entail that the result becomes an analogous one. When nature is seen as a living unity, as teleologically striving toward spirit, as that whose essence is spirit, and whose concept first finds its fulfillment in spirit, then nature is seen as the objectively existing rational, the logical as immanent in it, and logic as metaphysics expresses at once nature’s and spirit’s reason-determined essence, becomes

at once nature's logic and spirit's logic. And in man the natural becomes the will's foundation, and, as the reason-determined real, the basis of the ethical, that which is to give the free, conscious spirit's action fullness and reality, to become, clarified through cognition, content for the ethical will.

In Martensen's apprehension of the physical, nature's reason-determinateness is not overlooked either. Reason is in nature, and nature does the works of thought. But nature is yet only the blindly existing: blind in the subjective sense, in so far as nature is not self-thinking, blind in the objective sense because nature exists only with necessity, not with freedom, and every unfree necessity is a blind, so to speak fatalistic, necessity. And the physical concept of God, which has this blindly existing nature for its substratum, no dialectic is to be able to bring into true unity with the logical, because the logical God is the purely ideal, indifferent to existence. Existence and idea are to have their actual point of unity only in a will: only in the ethical God is their perfect unity to be found.

In the ethical concept of God the physical is therefore to be included as a moment and as a necessary moment, but in such a way that the ethical, just as it transcended the logical according to its whole extent, also in its absolute freedom raises itself above all the physical, again negates it as a condition.

3.4.5 The Duality in the Conception

In these determinations there shows itself a duality in the determination of the relation.

When the "ethical concept of God" is to be made comprehensible, made the object of a cognition, then that side must be accentuated that the physical is a necessary moment, a necessary condition for the ethical, and the physical then acquires essential validity, is seen as determining the ethical.

When, on the contrary, the accent falls on the "ethical" representation of God, on the representation of freedom in the meaning indicated above, then the essentiality of the natural is again abolished. God becomes nature-less and it becomes impossible, from the representation of this God, to reach the determination of the physical.

The duality becomes at once clear in the determinations Martensen gives inasmuch as he is *more closely* to indicate the relation between the ethical and the physical in God. We can leave aside such statements, perhaps according to form more accidental, as e.g. that God's ethical will cannot be without a nature in relation to which it can determine itself as ethical¹¹, a statement that would point partly back to an impracticable analogy with the human, partly to the doctrine, not approved by Martensen, of a coming-to-be

¹¹Martensen: Om Tro og Viden. p. 51.

God who frees himself out of an obscure ground to spirit and personality. We hold to other statements that, as definitively determining the relation, cannot have this character of accidentality. It is said¹² that God, as the absolutely knowing and willing, is at the same time to be the absolutely able. God's ethical will is not to be thinkable without an eternal nature, physis, in God, without which his will would be without instruments and potencies of production; it is not to be thinkable without an eternal fullness of power. —In these determinations there is ascribed to the physical a real validity and an essential significance for the will and the ethical, precisely by the fact that the will, without that physis, is set as being without possibility of production, impotent for bringing-forth and in general for working¹³. And there lies in them the further-reaching consequence that when the will, in order to work, presupposes instruments, and these instruments accordingly cannot be thought as set by the will, since in this setting it would precisely have worked without instruments; then the instruments must acquire equal originality with the will, and, when the determination physis is taken seriously, we get either the same dualism that Martensen reproaches Nielsen with, or we get a natural God, for whose physical necessity the will becomes the form of activity. But precisely the opposite is aimed at, and therefore the following determinations recall that on which these consequences rest. For it is said, in immediate connection with what is stated above, that that eternal fullness of power is an all-possibility that relates itself to the ethical in God as the serving, subordinate, to the superordinate, ruling, and royal, as God's inauthentic other-essence to his authentic innermost essence. "God is, as the God of freedom, the lord of possibilities, and can freely reveal himself, which does not hold of the logical and physical God, whose possibilities blindly pass over into their consequences. God is the absolutely nature-free (not nature-less), and as such he is in himself the perfect spirit, the perfect personality, the true God, who has the logical and physical for attributes, predicates, qualities, is a living unity of different moments."

Inasmuch as the fullness of power is set as equal to an all-possibility, inasmuch as it is determined as the serving, subordinate, hence becomes that which is to be mastered by something that falls outside the fullness of power, inasmuch as God's freedom in the meaning developed above is appealed to, and inasmuch as God is determined as the absolutely nature-free, as absolutely, unconditionally disposing over the physical, his

¹²Same place. p. 68.

¹³If the will is seen as that by which the divine essence's being is eternally set, then this setting is in the highest sense a working, and, more determinately, a working with respect to that to whose essence a physis is to stand in necessary relation; the will's working can accordingly not here either be thought without "instruments," that is, without an eternally existing physical, when it is not to be thinkable without a physical with respect to that existing outside God.

instrument, then the determination physis is deprived of its reality, for inasmuch as the divine will, whose absolute priority accordingly also in relation to this physis continues to be the presupposition, unconditionally disposes over the instruments, then the will is not determined by their nature, it can, while by using them it apparently ascribes to them reality as instruments, substitute in their place everything possible, and by this substitution their reality is negated. And when the concept of the ethical God is identified with the concept of the “supernatural” principle, then it becomes still clearer that physis in God becomes only a semblance of nature, a fantasy’s sublimation of the actual nature, which is taken up only for the benefit of the analogy with the human, and for the benefit of an illusory deduction. And yet the divine essence is to be unity, true unity of the different moments. This becomes only a postulate: the reality of nature and the necessity of nature must always become incomprehensible from such a representation of God.

3.4.6 Creation

This consequence will confirm itself when the “ethical,” personal God is set in relation to actual nature, and when a deduction of the doctrine of creation and of the miracles is attempted.

If we first analyze the representation of creation such as the religious consciousness apprehends it, then there lie in it the following determinations:

- 1) Creation is creation out of nothing; but that which is created out of nothing, that is, in its origin is nothing, is in its being continually a nothing, not *natura*, but *creatura*. By the representation of creation the concept of nature is therefore negated.
- 2) Inasmuch as the created is set by the in-itself perfect God, determined as spirit, and set in the determination of a material, i.e. in a determination absolutely opposed to the purely spiritual God’s essence, then creation is not grounded in God’s essence’s necessity, but in a will unbound by the essence, in an absolute arbitrariness, whose working, inasmuch as it falls purely outside the necessity of essence and sets that which is opposed to the essence, is the absolutely incomprehensible.

Against these consequences, which sharply indicate the simple conceptual relations, Martensen makes objection. He maintains against the first partly that a physis in God is the presupposition of creation, and that, inasmuch as this physis becomes equal to an all-possibility, the nothing out of which the world is created is to be one with God’s will’s

eternal possibilities;—partly that creation is not to set a nothing, but a something that produces and develops itself in given independence. Against the second consequence he objects that the ground of creation must not be sought in an absolute arbitrariness, but in the ethical, in the ethically determined omnipotence.

As regards the objections against the first consequence, the representation of a physis in God has already above been shown in its inner contradiction. This representation, such as it has come forward in its originality in Jacob Böhme, has proceeded from a feeling of unsatisfaction at the representation of nature's origin from a nature-less God, from the feeling of the nothing-explaining in the explanation of nature's coming-to-be by an absolutely groundless divine act of will. In order to explain nature, one then places nature in God; one indirectly pronounces that nature can only be explained by nature itself, that it has essentiality and self-validity, one accordingly unconsciously betrays a doubt with respect to the representation of creation. But the involuntary acknowledgment of nature one again takes back, precisely by placing nature in God, by exchanging the actual nature for its image in fantasy, from which then the former is to be explained. It is the nature metamorphosed by fantasy, the nature which, though "wahrhaftig und eigentlich," is yet "himmlisch und geistlich," that one places in God, and inasmuch as one makes it the ground for the real nature, one lets on the one hand the metamorphosis conceal that which deviates from the religious apprehension, on the other hand the likeness of the name bring about the semblance of an explanation of the actual nature's existence. But the spiritualized, dematerialized, denatured physis in God explains nothing with respect to the real nature's being, and an actual nature-determinateness in God would let the representation of creation be superseded by the concept of an eternal necessary unfolding of essence.

When nature in God is then made into an all-possibility, and the nothing out of which the world is created is set as equal to God's will's eternal possibilities, then this identification becomes an exchanging of two entirely *different* concepts. The eternal possibilities in the eternally actual God must indeed for God be eternally realized possibilities, i.e. realities, hence as far as possible from nothing. Were they to be possibilities that first acquired reality by the finite existence, then there would lie therein consequences with respect to God's relation to this existence that Martensen would least of all be able to accept.

The objection that creation does not set a *nothing*, but a *something* that *produces* and develops itself in *given independence*, abolishes itself by its immediate combining of opposite, mutually negating determinations. From what consideration of natural

existence this objection has proceeded will be illuminated in what follows.

The objection against the *second* consequence drawn above is carried out in Martensen in the following way¹⁴. It is to be entirely superficial and unjustified to trace creation back to an absolute act of arbitrariness of the mere omnipotence and accordingly to set it as the incomprehensible. Creation is to presuppose unconditionally the ethical concept of God, and without this it is to be entirely unreasonable to speak of creation; there is to be no question of the mere omnipotence—a pure physical determination—but of the omnipotence determined by love and wisdom, hence ethically. In love's ethical "necessity" the ground of creation is to be sought; through it creation is to become comprehensible, not indeed in such a way that one pretends to fathom its how, but in such a way that it is seen in its necessary connection with the determination of God's essence.

But this appeal to the ethical becomes completely useless, and would already for the reason have to become so that, as shown above, the ethical in Martensen's apprehension does not in reality acquire the physical for its moment. Here there is question of a creation of a material existing: in what connection does it indeed stand with the determination of the ethical? Martensen postulates the connection, but does not even make an attempt to show what is the connecting thing, and what, in the ethical concept of God, is to be able to explain the possibility of such a creation. Against the postulate that the ethical determinateness in God is to be the explaining thing, it holds that what is in truth to be ethical must be determined by God's essence; were the moment of nature accordingly excluded from God's essence, a creation of the real would have no positive relation to the ethical. And above it was shown that the moment of nature was in reality excluded, and that one had to exclude it if one was not, instead of a creation, to get a development of nature. But when therefore nature in God is reduced to an unreal, to a mere fantasy-image, then one acquires no point of attachment for the possibility of a creation of the material; but where the possibility is lacking, it is meaningless to speak of the necessity. Even if one would let love, which yet, according to Martensen's deduction, is already to have its actual object, hence its real satisfaction, in the relation of the Trinity, be the ground of explanation for a setting of created spirits, one would not have come a step further with respect to the creation of the material. And such a representation of a purely spiritual creation would abolish itself. That which is set by a creation would have to be a finite; but a finite is determined by time and space, and time and space, which cannot be thought without each other, can only be thought where a material is. A creating of purely spiritual, an existing of created spirits, in actual distinction, with

¹⁴Martensen: *Om Tro og Viden*. p. 59 f.

actual beginning, with an actual life-history without the real existence's fundamental forms, would accordingly be self-contradictory. However the working of creation is represented, creation remains equally incomprehensible.¹⁵

3.4.7 The Miracle

What holds with respect to *creation*, the universal miracle, must also have validity with respect to *the miracle*, the partial *creation*.

If we analyze the representation of the miracle, we will accordingly obtain results analogous to those to which the analysis of the representation of creation led. The miracle, as the working of the divine, absolutely free, almighty will, is a working in which the nothingness of the natural is set. It is set inasmuch as omnipotence in the miracle works without all that is real, and inasmuch as in the miracle the existing real is set as a nothing. Only apparently does the miracle-working omnipotence, according to its concept *sole-working*, use means, only apparently does that which has come to be by the miracle have a real presupposition. The apparent means is no means, the apparent presupposition is no actual presupposition, for there is no essence-connection between the means and the goal, between the presupposition and that which follows after; the former's determinateness is in relation to the latter's determinateness a nothing. The miracle is a new creation and as creation a creation out of nothing: only the fact that it is in the partial creation gives the semblance of an actual presupposition. For a new creation the preceding becomes a stuff whose essence is negated in the moment of creation, i.e. it becomes a nothing in relation to the new; that which precedes becomes, in other words, not a positive presupposition, but such a one as is only negated in order to give place to the new. —From the miracle's relation to omnipotence it then follows that the miracle, like creation, must be the incomprehensible, an explanation of it an impossibility. Of this the religious consciousness too is clear: for it the miracle is omnipotence's immediate working ("he spoke and it happened," "he commanded and there it stood"), and that which surpasses all human thought.

Against the indicated apprehension of the miracle Martensen makes objection from the same standpoint from which he made objection against the conceptual determinations given above with respect to creation. The miracle is not to be without a presupposition of nature, which in the miracle itself acquires a relative validity, and the science of faith is to be able to explain, not indeed the miracle's how, but the miracle's possibility in

¹⁵It naturally explains nothing that it is said (in the Dogmatics) that "the Logos releases out of its spiritual depth the whole manifold of life-forces to self-movement".

general, inasmuch as the miracle is seen in connection with God's revelation's economy and the freely self-revealing God is seen as "the Lord of nature," who "can do what nature cannot." The miracle's relative comprehensibility rests accordingly, like creation's, on its relation to the ethical concept of God, more nearly: on its connection with the ethical teleology.

In order to assert for the miracle a presupposition of nature, it is maintained that the ethical world-teleology, in connection with which the miracle is to be apprehended, is not to abolish the lower circles of existence's autonomy and independence, or contradict natural science's presupposition of a law-determined order of existence. An ethical view of the world is declared entirely impossible without a relatively independent physis, and the miracle itself impossible without an ordered system of natural laws, since it is precisely to presuppose an order of nature in order therein to be able to come forward as the miracle. Likewise it is demanded with respect to the miracle that the higher divine activity must always be logically conditioned, inasmuch as God cannot contradict himself, in which lies that God's miracle-working must not be annihilating in relation to the natural set by God; which is also indirectly demanded by the positing of physical conditions for the divine will's working. —But these general determinations show themselves not only as impracticable as soon as the *determinate* miracle is drawn forth; they also acquire closer determinations by which they are again abolished. The miracle is set in relation to the teleological. But that which is designated as miracle is determined as that which cannot be derived from the preceding stages of creation: it is a specifically higher, not only in the meaning in which a teleological development's more advanced stages of development are a higher in relation to the lower, and in reality are that by which these are to be comprehended, but in the meaning in which the supernatural is higher than the natural. *Inasmuch as the miracle therefore comes forward, the teleology is broken, the order of nature negated*; the preceding is a nothing in relation to the miracle and this comes forward as the purely immediate and arbitrary. It is correct that the miracle, as this single, in time limited miracle, in a certain sense involuntarily presupposes, *though only in order to abolish it*, an order of natural existence, in so far as it presupposes a continuity that is broken by the miracle. Were there not a relative continuity, the miracle could not become visible as miracle; for inasmuch as the miracle was set in all single discrete points of time, the miracle would become the law, the very order of existence: *the miracle's infinite discreteness would become the law's infinite continuity*. But that relative continuity does not designate an order grounded in nature's substantial essence; it is not an expression for the substantiality itself, but is

only the expression for something arbitrarily set and arbitrarily repeated by the creating will. It is precisely a "stage of creation," to use Martensen's expression. It is abolished by the miracle and again arbitrarily set: God's freedom is for the religious consciousness only absolute inasmuch as it is unconditionally unbound by everything, also by the presuppositions set by itself. Consistently this consciousness would make everything a miracle; that it, in its immediacy, does not do so and cannot do so without letting the miracle become invisible, shows that it never fills the human spirit wholly, that it has the natural consciousness alongside itself, and only is by constantly negating this.

From this latter there originally presses into the former the representation of the relatively constant in nature; but inasmuch as the relatively constant is seen as that which can be broken through by the miracle, it has already ceased to be a law of nature, and when the religious consciousness sees it in its own illumination, it becomes for the religious reflection the arbitrarily set by omnipotence, hence miracle, like the specific, striking miracle, so that the miracle again embraces the whole of existence, but at the same time becomes invisible as miracle, for which reason consciousness is involuntarily led back to that point of departure, but only to run through the same cycle anew.

As regards the miracle's comprehensibility, it is attempted to be asserted partly through a polemic against the representation of the immutability of the laws of nature, partly through the attachment to the ethical, through the determination of the natural's serving relation to this. In order to procure a place for the miracle, the representation of the immutability of the laws of nature is sought to be abolished. But inasmuch as the apprehension of the laws of nature as immutable is sought to be refuted, there comes forward a striking unclarity, both with respect to the difference between a change of the laws of nature and the same unchanged laws of nature's different working under changed conditions, and with respect to the relation between the laws of nature and the mathematical laws, whose inseparability the laws of mechanics show. The attempt at a refutation of that representation rests essentially on the fact that the way by which we come to the determination of the laws of nature must determine their character, and since the way is that of experience, the laws of nature are to have no other validity than that which experience can secure for them. Inasmuch as the laws of nature are determined by the way of experience, through induction and analogy, they can, it is said¹⁶, only acquire relative universality and necessity, their immutable validity can never acquire more than the highest degree of probability. And they would, even if within this determinate circle they had unconditional validity, as laws of experience yet only

¹⁶Martensen: *Om Tro og Viden*. p. 108 ff.

have validity in a given facticity, within this determinate, this present existence, but not have it for all existence. Natural science can, as a mere science of experience, decide nothing about the in an absolute sense possible or impossible; it does not even have, with respect to the reality to which it relates itself, a cognition that embraces beginning and end: these are for it enveloped in an impenetrable darkness; it moves only as it were in a middle, within a circle of conditions that have once for all factually been made, it does not itself even know how. It can therefore not contradict that there can be a higher existence than nature's, which can penetrate this and work upon it, be it redemptively or transfiguringly, set it as organ and means for a goal that is higher than nature's own. Since the miracle does not refer itself to the world of pure concepts and pure forms, but to existence, it is precisely the question whether nature itself is the highest existence, which as such must not be able to be exchanged, or whether that higher existence exists. Only from a physical concept of God as the highest could the immutability of the laws of nature be demonstrated.

In this argumentation it is *first overlooked* that the fact *that the laws of nature can come to our knowledge only by the aid of experience* does not abolish the possibility of a comprehension that gives them a higher necessity than that *attainable by the way of mere experience*; in other words: does not exclude the possibility *that the empirical law can be transformed into a rational one*, a transformation that is precisely the task of natural cognition, and whose possibility it is incumbent on the miracle's defenders to disprove. Natural cognition is and remains indeed always *an experiential cognition*, but not in the meaning that it is to rest on *an isolated experience*; it takes its point of departure in experience in order from it to reach a comprehension whose possibility is conceded when there is talk of reason in nature, of nature's doing the works of thought. —When it is then concluded that the laws of nature, as only valid in a given facticity, within this determinate existence, cannot have unconditional immutability and necessity, then here partly the confusion touched upon above between a change in the laws of nature and in the conditions is to be removed, partly it is to be urged that the conclusion's validity depends on the relation that is set between this form of existence and the supposed higher one. Is this—to which the expression *world-teleology* points—a *higher stage of development*, then the laws retain, under the new conditions of activity, under the new complications, unchanged their validity, just as we see the laws of the inorganic retain it within the organic; they hold for all existence, i.e. for all natural existence, and we get in the higher not a miracle, at most a *mirabile*. *Nature's primitive laws must, since nature must always be thought as a whole, be the same at all stages of nature's development; for*

the laws are precisely the expression for the unfolded essence thought in activity. In order to come to the abolition of the law of nature's validity one would have to presuppose that the higher had come forward by a break, by an absolute abolition of the continuity. But then the higher would have come to be by a new creation, and the relation would—what is precisely to be avoided—be incomprehensible. When the higher, the miracle, is not to be thought as a new stage of development, but as a re-creating, then it leads to the consequence that the miracle, the partial creation, is to enter into a reality that is changed only at this point, and that accordingly this reality, thus partially changed, would become the contradictory: a defective reality, an incomplete whole, a discordant harmony. Is there posited “an ordered system of natural laws,” then the break at this one point is a break on the whole of the system. And even if one looks most nearly to the single real that is negated in the miracle, then an annihilation of even the most insignificant real, an abolition of it against the law, is a break on the whole order of existence, a disturbance of the whole. *And that change in existence reaches from existence into the world of pure concepts and pure forms.* Analyze whatever miracle one will, it will bring a contradiction into the sphere of concepts, inasmuch as it is a working without means, a causing of that which negates its cause's essence, a setting of a real without all that is real, a setting that negates that set by the eternal activity; and it will, inasmuch as *all physical existence is mathematically determined*, bring a contradiction into the world of pure forms: that of the mathematical; for it is a setting of a something, a by quantum determined, out of a nothing, of a form-determined out of the formless. It becomes not only the merely physical concept of God, from which the miracle is negated, and the immutability of the laws of nature, which is only the expression for nature's essentiality, asserted; as soon as there is posited a ground of nature, a physis in God, the miracle is set as impossible. And is the moment of nature in God negated, openly or covertly, then the miracle is again, though for another reason, the impossible, the purely incomprehensible, like creation. Because the miracle is denied, nature as nature is not set as the highest, but the higher being than nature: the being of spirit, is seen as nature's fulfillment, not as nature's arbitrary negation. The laws that, as holding at a *determinate* stage of nature's development, hold for nature in general, hold for nature as the nature ensouled by spirit, as the nature that has its goal in spirit. Nature is spirit's abiding, essential foundation.

From the *negative proof for the miracle's comprehensibility* we turn to *the positive*, it rests on the ethical concept of God. By this there is, it is said¹⁷, not only set a living relation of interaction between God and the creature, but the world-teleology is at the

¹⁷Martensen: Om Tro og Viden. p. 111 f.

same time determined as ethical teleology; that is, the ethical is, as the fundamental purpose, thus also the innermost fundamental-determining in existence, that for whose sake all else is, and which all else must serve. This is yet not to mean that the ethical teleology at all points of existence would come forward entirely arbitrarily and purely immediately, and everything without further ado be able to be stamped with the ethical and religious relation of dependence. As indicated above, the ethical world-teleology is precisely to presuppose and confirm a relatively independent physis, a law-determined order of existence. The meaning is to be that the ethical view of the world and the ethical concept of God necessarily entail that nature in its arrangement cannot make impossible the divine world-plan, or that the concept of nature cannot deny the concept of creation, that nature cannot deny its dependence on the Creator. For the ethical view of the world nature is to be an intermediate being that has the significance, not only of being itself and of fulfilling its own purposes, but also of being organ, means for freedom, and of serving purposes that are far higher than its own. It is to be receptive to freedom's workings, of which it is said that, when the God of freedom is presupposed, it would be most strange to restrict them to human freedom's. And when now the divine world-plan entailed that in mankind's history there entered periods, determinate times, in which God in his relation to mankind would in a pregnant and entirely unambiguous way reveal himself as the one he always is, as the Lord of nature, in order through workings that cannot be explained from the created to bring himself nearer to human consciousness, because the content of his world-plan was an economy for man's salvation, then such times would in a peculiar and strictest meaning be *the times of the miracle or the great times of revelation*. And the science of revelation or of religion would have to seek a closer understanding, seek to see these miracles' significance in and with the great total connection, naturally without wishing to comprehend the miracle's how.

By the reference to the ethical concept of God, however, nothing is gained. This lies already in what was developed with respect to creation; it becomes, when account is taken of the form in which the argumentation comes forward in Martensen, clear in the following way.

Spirit's primacy in relation to nature; the fact that nature serves spirit and is receptive to freedom's workings, does not make the miracle comprehensible. Nature serves spirit *as nature*, i.e. in accordance with its laws, and freedom's workings are not, like the miracle's, arbitrary and purely immediate, but through natural means, i.e. again in accordance with the cognized reason-determined laws of nature. Inasmuch as nature serves the human rational freedom, the free spirit bows beneath the infinite reason that

is at once its own and nature's essence; only the fantastic freedom dreams of a magical, immediate dominion over the subjugated nature. Nature, which in the living immediately shows the power of the ideal, does not deny its determinateness by the ideal, which is precisely its essence; but the concept of nature must deny the concept of creation, hence also the concept of the miracle, because the concept of creation denies the concept of nature, negates all of nature's reality. The realization of reason-determined freedom through reason-determined nature includes no difficulty for thought, but a revelation of God as *the Lord of nature in the indicated meaning*, as the one who can do what nature cannot, and, mark well, *can do it within nature, in relation to a natural, without all that is natural*, is the incomprehensible.

The miracle can next not become explicable by any historical connection, for just as the miracle has no nature, so it has no history either. It is, as expression for the unconditioned, almighty will, the absolutely sudden, discrete, connectionless; its comprehension out of a total connection is impossible, is a contradiction.

The miracle finally does not become comprehensible either by being supposed to be a condition for God's unambiguous revelation. God is in the miracle to reveal himself in an entirely unambiguous way, by workings that cannot be explained from the created: the miracle was thus to *create faith*. But, according to Martensen's own premises, it cannot be known that this working, which takes place in nature, cannot have natural causes. Experience, which, according to Martensen's determination, is *natural cognition's only source*, cannot say it: since it is indeed to know nothing about possibility or impossibility. But in what way then does God's revelation become unambiguous? And how is it to be understood that God in this determinate working is to reveal himself more clearly than in his natural workings, bring himself nearer to human consciousness than through his essence-revelation in nature and reason? It is only to be understood thus, *that the miracle unambiguously reveals God when man has by a miracle been led to see it as miracle*. That is, in other words: *the miracle is acknowledged as miracle only through faith: through a miracle; it presupposes faith: the primitive miracle, the miracle in us, by which we first see the miracle outside us*; not the outer miracle, but the wondrous working in the spirit becomes accordingly the decisive thing with respect to the unambiguous revelation. That the miracle is apprehended only by a miracle, not understood by thought, lies also in what Martensen says, that the sought understanding of the miracle is unthinkable without the mind receptive to revelation; for revelation and its reception is indeed precisely a miracle.

Inasmuch as the miracle thus presupposes itself, and is as it were the only way to

itself, every attempt to make it comprehensible, also in that more indeterminate meaning, must fail, and the attempt to make it comprehensible in this meaning leads inevitably, inasmuch as the miracle is to be fitted into a teleological connection that at the same time becomes a natural connection, to involuntary attempts also to determine its how, which was excluded by the presuppositions.

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3.4.8 The General View of Existence

The general view of existence, to which the apprehension of creation and the miracle points back, is pronounced in the Dogmatics. It is set as the task to bring about a Christian apprehension of existence, which yet *must not come into conflict with nature and reason according to their truth*. The standpoint for this apprehension of existence is to be taken from that which is existence's highest, its τέλος, from Christ's person, who is the midpoint of the holy history and Christianity's proper content. The holy history is to explain history, history nature. But by the representation of a holy history and especially of Christ there is pointed to the miracle, to an absolutely new beginning, a spiritual creation in mankind, which is to have not only ethical, but also cosmic significance, the deepest significance for nature. The miracle of the Incarnation, and the miracle of Inspiration attached to it, by which a new sense arises in mankind, a new beginning is set in mankind's consciousness, is Christianity's fundamental miracles, which the supernaturalistic view of the world is to assert against naturalism and rationalism, but in such a way that nature and reason see their right, that no disturbing dualism is brought in.

With respect to nature it is then set as the Christian intuition, what was developed above: that it is not an in-itself eternal and concluded system of laws and forces, but a system that finds itself in a continued teleological development, a continued creation, so that there must be able to be thought to enter new potencies, new laws and forces, whose *entrance is prepared and prefigured by the preceding stages of creation, but which cannot be derived from these*. Christ's revelation, as the last potency in the work of creation, is therefore to be thought to work *teleologically changing and determining* upon the lower potencies, inasmuch as these do not have an eternal and concluded significance in themselves, but have only a temporal intermediate significance. The point of unity of the natural and supernatural is thus to lie in nature's teleological determination for God's kingdom and in the receptivity and formability for the supernatural creative activity thereby given. *Nature is not to deny the concept of creation, but just as little is creation*

to deny the concept of nature. For although the new creation in Christ is an abolition of this nature's laws, it is yet by no means to be an abolition of the very concept of nature. For it is precisely nature's concept to be, not the hampering barrier for freedom, but freedom's organ.

By freedom there is pointed to the kingdom of history, but within this is already intimated the repetition of the same relation that obtained in the kingdom of nature. For rationalism history is the unfolding of human nature, of the human essence's nature-determined dispositions; the universal reason (κοινὸς λόγος) is for it the only source of cognition; it acknowledges no other truths than those that are explications of mankind's innate reason. Christianity, on the contrary, must demand that to the new source of life that is opened in Christ there corresponds a new source of cognition, a kingdom of divine, hitherto concealed counsels, a kingdom of new cognitions that do not let themselves be derived from the concept of mankind's advancing development of reason. But just as the miracle did not conflict with nature, so these new, supernaturally communicated cognitions are by no means to conflict with mankind's general cognitions of reason, although they in many ways *more closely determine these*; for partly they relate themselves *completely and concludingly* to the proper cognitions of reason, partly *redemptively*, inasmuch as they free them from the darkness with which they, on account of the all-embracing sinfulness, are afflicted. By them there is just as little to be posited a dualism as by the doctrine of the two creations: *there is only one kingdom of reason, although in this there are two potencies of reason's revelation*. Objectively the unity is to lie in this, that it is *the same Logos* that reveals itself in the two creations, so that the revelation of the Logos in Christ is the revelation in higher potency, therein different from the universal revelation of the Logos, that it is the world-completing and world-redeeming revelation, while that universal one is merely the world-creating and sustaining. Subjectively the unity is to lie in this, that human reason is receptive to Christ's spirit as the spirit of the world's completion and the world's redemption: a receptivity through which reason is to be raised to a higher stage of productivity. That the revelation in Christ is to conflict with reason's laws is only to be conceded in the meaning that it, in the same way as the moral laws are abolished in their abstract independence in order to be confirmed in love, abolishes the laws of reason in their abstraction in order to confirm them in the Christ-wisdom that is the fullness of the law of reason.

The relation that this "Christian intuition" of existence posits can accordingly in brief be determined thus: *the miracle is nature's higher potency, revelation reason's; the miracle is prefigured and prepared in nature, revelation in reason, but the first cannot be derived*

from the last. The relation has thus a duality in itself: *on the one hand there is pointed to the higher unity, on the other hand the unity is again abolished and the break enters between the higher set by a new creation and the preceding lower.* The impracticability of this duality has already been shown by the doctrine of creation and the miracle; what there has been developed with respect to the concept of creation, which embraces the concept “new creation,” “continued creation,” and with respect to teleology’s relation to the absolutely new beginning, finds, just as that which was developed about the lack of an attachment for the physical in the “ethical concept of God,” about the immutability of the laws of nature, about freedom’s relation to nature, etc., its application here too. The turns of phrase peculiar to the given development do not lead closer to the aimed-at goal. When there is thus talk of a *receptivity and formability of nature for the supernatural*, and in analogy herewith of *the general human reason’s receptivity and formability for the supernatural revelation*, then *receptivity and formability presuppose essential unity*: only what agrees with my essence can I receive; for receptivity is inseparable from a self-activity corresponding to the received, and the self-activity expresses the essence. Without self-activity the reception would be an annihilation of the receiving thing. When there is therefore talk of the natural’s receptivity for the supernatural, reason’s for revelation, then we must either set the difference as a merely quantitative one, or, when we will hold it fast as a decisive difference of quality, let the receptivity become an empty word without significance, let the “teleological reaction,” i.e. the afterward set teleology, be an actual re-creation, the reception of revelation into the I a break in the I, a re-creation that makes self-consciousness’s identity incomprehensible.

It is on the whole characteristic of the given development that the determinations suffer from ambiguity and vagueness. When it is thus said of the higher, which cannot be derived from the lower, that it is “prepared and prefigured” by this, then there lies in the “preparation” an *objective connection*, in the “prefiguration” a *merely figurative, merely subjectively valid* one. By the combination of these expressions it is accordingly held in suspense of what kind the relation is; it becomes at once a real and a not-real relation, at once inner connection and break on the connection. And when there is talk of the lower’s *heightening and confirmation in the heightening*, and of the higher potencies’ reaction, then these expressions acquire a significance only for the fantasy so long as they are held in the universal, not attempted to be brought into relation with the single and concrete. The change and determination of the lower potencies is to coincide with the realization of their receptivity for the supernatural creative activity. But this realization, which would have to be brought about by removing that which

hampered the possibility, would, since the hampering thing could only be a real, have real consequences and be visible in nature—unless precisely nature were annihilated by this working, which is indeed not the presupposition. But let one only attempt in the concrete to demonstrate the change in nature's laws, in the logical and mathematical laws, that was supposed to have taken place by the Incarnation, which is indeed to have the deepest cosmic significance, or the heightening of the forces of nature by the single miracle, and one will soon discover the hopelessness of the attempt. And even without this: when one attempts to think the thought of a defective nature and of a defective reason, which were yet nature and reason—a thought that that representation of higher potencies presupposes—then the representation's inner contradiction will show itself.

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3.4.9 The Result of the Critique of the Concept of God

If we summarize the results of the investigation of the ethical concept of God's relation to the physical, they become the following:

1. The ethical concept of God does not in reality acquire the physical in itself as a moment; it becomes the concept of a *nature-less God*, and therefore *the natural's existence, and divine workings in the natural, become inexplicable* from it.
2. The freedom by which the "ethical" concept of God is determined does not give it a worth higher than that which belongs to the reason-determined nature apprehended according to its true concept; this freedom, which becomes only *essence-less arbitrariness*, becomes on the contrary a lower than the reason-necessity manifest in nature, and it becomes a self-contradictory and self-abolishing.
3. The apprehension of existence that rests on this ethical concept of God does not become the higher. It negates the law of reason in natural existence; it abolishes, with nature's laws, *the concept of nature*, and history becomes for it, whether it is seen from God's or man's standpoint, only a *necessity-less, i.e. arbitrary freedom's working*. (Precisely because this apprehension sees in the human essence the *necessity-less will freed from nature's necessity as the first*, and therefore in mankind's history sees only that freedom's kingdom, inasmuch as spirit, as "the free," becomes the one unbound by law, it accentuates "the historical" because this, as that which is withdrawn from the law, forms the analogy to the divine "working of freedom" that comes forward in the free revelation and in the miracle.

Yet this historical acquires also for another reason so great a significance for it, namely because it, by being the medium in which God immediately comes forward and reveals “himself,” satisfies the religious consciousness’s urge to acquire *the eternal for intuition in that form of sensibility*¹⁸, which is inseparable from this consciousness at the standpoint of positive religion).

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Thus we are led, by the investigation of the determinations of God’s essence given by Martensen, from the as ethical named, but not in reality ethical, concept of God back to the logical, apprehended according to the logical’s true and complete meaning, according to which it expresses the essence-determinations of nature and spirit. And we are led from the representation of the natural’s coming-to-be by an arbitrary creative act and of the outer revelation proceeding from the will’s arbitrariness back to the concept of a nature standing in eternal essence-relation to the divine, resting on immutable laws, and of the eternal essence-communication, determined by the divine essence’s free necessity, to the human spirit grounded in God.

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3.4.10 What is Typical for Theology in the Criticized Conception

What in the foregoing has been developed in close attachment to the theological attempt present in Martensen’s writings is now to be seen as holding for theology in general, inasmuch as Martensen’s apprehension, in its *decisive fundamental features*, is shown to be typical for theology.

In order to demonstrate the typical character of his apprehension, it will not be sufficient to demonstrate corresponding fundamental features in significant representatives of theology at various times. By this way, on which one alongside the agreeing would always be able to find the more or less deviating, one would only be able to reach an approximate. The apprehension’s typical character can only be asserted incontestably by going back to that which becomes theology’s object: the content of the religious consciousness, and when the form is sought that this content must consistently assume when it is to become content for a “science of faith.”

It will here, where there is question of the apprehension of the concept of God, be enough to draw forth *one phenomenon that is as it were the religious consciousness’s*

¹⁸cf. O. Waage: J. P. Mynster og de filosofiske Bevægelser paa hans Tid i Danmark, p. 122, cf. 116, 144, 163.

ur-phenomenon and runs through all, even the lowest, religious forms, namely: prayer. In the act of prayer the peculiarity of the positively religious lies concentrated; the analysis of the concept of prayer gives the essential moments for the determination of the positive religions' apprehension of the divine.

In the concept of prayer there lie essentially two moments: 1) *prayer is prayer to the personal God, whose will is determined by the prayer*; 2) *the object of prayer is the miracle.*

1. Inasmuch as the praying one prays to God, in the prayer "says Thou to his God," he relates himself to God as to a *single personality outside himself*, and in the very form of prayer there lies expressed that this *single personality can be moved by the prayer, be affected from man's side*. As the one to whom there is prayed, God is the one who is not bound by any eternal law, but has the possibility of constantly new counsels, and of counsels that relate themselves particularly to the single one who prays, to his welfare, his wishes, his blessedness. "Ask, and it shall be given you," is the expression for the immediate religious consciousness's apprehension of prayer. "God, who is good, will give you good gifts when you ask him for them" expresses *prayer's conditioning power*. "Give us this day our daily bread" expresses that prayer relates itself to a determinate object. Even when there is prayed: "thy will be done," then the will whose fulfillment is prayed for is that will of omnipotence which wills *the believing and praying one's best, omnipotence is goodness's omnipotence*. Is there prayed: "not my, but thy will be done," then the prayer again concerns the same will of omnipotence apprehended in the same way. In this prayer a beginning reflection is manifest, which is yet bound by the immediate religious feeling. Inasmuch as God is the religious feeling's object as the absolutely exalted, knowing, the prayer acquires this form of resignation, but *prayer's determining of God's will is therefore not negated. To an immutable will one cannot pray*. The prayer leaves to God in what way he in his goodness will best fulfill the praying one's wishes, but the latter does not doubt prayer's significance for the fulfillment of these wishes. Precisely the fact that to the determinate prayer there is added the prayer: see not my, but thy will be done, includes that the praying one, who represents to himself the possibility of a divine willing that does not at all refer itself to the first prayer's object, will yet by the prayer determine God in relation to this. Is prayer apprehended only as the lively expression for *the contemplation of God*, then the specific for prayer is taken away, another concept is slipped in under the name of prayer. Is prayer's working to be only the *indirect subjective reaction* upon the praying one, then prayer's essence is undermined by reflection and the apprehension comes into manifest conflict with the

immediate religious consciousness's apprehension¹⁹. Such a prayer without objective goal indeed preserves prayer's form, is formally a prayer, but in such a way that, through the consciousness of its merely subjective working, *prayer as prayer is recalled in the very prayer: it is in reality not faith's, but unbelief's prayer*. When the concept of prayer is taken, without distortion, in the meaning in which the religious consciousness takes it, then it is apprehended as that which *changes God's will*, and this is understood more closely in such a way that *prayer determines God*, but determines God to an utterance of omnipotence. The contradiction lying herein the religious consciousness as such does not see: *prayer's omnipotence is concealed by God's omnipotence*.

2. That which is prayed for is *the miracle and only the miracle*. The concept of prayer in the general religious consciousness's apprehension includes that there is prayed, not for what as an ethical task rests in our will's decision, or for what follows from existence's universal law or from an immutable divine decision from eternity, but that there is prayed for what has its ground only in an absolutely free divine will. It is the almighty will's working that prayer invokes, and it invokes the will as the one that is not bound by any presupposition, neither by one existing outside God nor by one given in God's essence-determination, not even by the will's preceding determinations. But the thus apprehended almighty will is the miracle-working will. And the miracle that is expected of the will is as miracle always a miracle "*in the strictest sense*"²⁰. *There are just as little degrees in the miracle as there are degrees in omnipotence; for the miracle is omnipotence's expression*. There can be a difference between what is more or less *mirabile*; but inasmuch as this *mirabile* is seen as *miraculum*, and thus it is seen by faith and by faith alone, the difference is abolished: then omnipotence, which is subjected to no quantification, is seen as sole-working cause.

But the God to whom prayer points: the God determined by the form of single personality, whose almighty will transcends his essence and thereby all essence, all law; this God, in whom the immediate religious consciousness finds satisfaction for its willing and for its representing inasmuch as both are determined by fantasy²¹,—this God is precisely the God who, when the representation of him is made the object of a science of faith, must yield a concept of God like that set forth by Martensen. In the carrying-out nuances can occur: the essential fundamental features must be the same where theology

¹⁹Let one only take account of such a prayer as the prayer to saints or to the Madonna for intercession: *Ora pro nobis*, or recall e.g. Luther's statement about his prayer for the recovery of the mortally ill Melanchthon.

²⁰cf. Martensen's utterances: *Om Tro og Viden*, p. 112.

²¹For thought there is here no reconciliation, because the spirit's development still remains in the sporadic, the unworked-through.

with consciousness holds fast its task.

The latter's task as a science of faith was at an earlier point determined in such a way that it had to apprehend revelation and God's essence and working in such a way that they were drawn out of the purely incomprehensible's sphere toward the rational, that there accordingly forced itself in a gleam of knowledge's and grounding's necessity, while yet the content's supra-rational character was not given up, and knowledge, which was subordinated to the revealed's norm, did not with its forms bring its essence-determinateness into the object.

The investigation of how this task is sought to be more closely determined and carried through, and what influence in general its carrying-through must have on theology's treatment of its object, now becomes the second main point with which the critique of theology's standpoint has to occupy itself. The critique of the concept of God acquires for its supplement the critique of the concept of science that lies at the ground of the apprehension of a science of faith's possibility and peculiarity.

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3.5 Critique of the Concept of Science

At the beginning of this section (p. 44 ff.) it has been briefly indicated how Martensen seeks to demonstrate the possibility of a science of faith as an organic unity of faith and knowledge; how he determines its task, its form, and its scientific character. It has at the same time been shown how his apprehension of that which is peculiar to the "higher science" and of this science's right to the primacy rested on his apprehension of the fundamental relation in the human essence and of the concept of God.

Through the critical investigation of the theory's psychological foundation and of the "ethical concept of God" the premises for the judgment on such a "higher" science have already in all essentials been won. When the will cannot be asserted the aimed-at primacy in the human essence, and when in the divine the will's transcending of the essence's and knowledge's necessity, by which the ethical concept of God was to acquire its peculiarity and its higher rank in comparison with the logical, cannot be carried through, then that which is conditioned thereby: a science resting on the free divine personality's supernatural revelation, in which knowledge's necessity was to be limited, its laws corrected through the will, is impossible: the logical asserts its right and the divine's communication to man becomes one determined by the essence's necessity, apprehensible through the forms of thought. From the untenability of the

postulated “higher” science’s principle follows as a necessary consequence this science’s untenability. This will confirm itself when we, after having supplemented the earlier-made determinations of the higher science’s essence by a more exact determination of its relation to science in the general meaning, more closely illuminate the given determinations and by some examples briefly demonstrate the results to which the higher science leads and must lead. These examples will then show the correctness of the general formula for the higher science’s method which we set up, and which most clearly reveals the contradictions and ambiguities that are inseparable from theology as theology and that deprive it of the character of science in the proper meaning.

3.5.1 The Relation of the Higher Science to the Merely Rational

The relation between the “higher” science and science in the general meaning is determined²² by the opposition, drawn from *Schelling*, between the *positive science*, the *positive philosophy*, and the *merely negative*. This latter is determined as the seeking philosophy, which, through a continued negation of the merely relative principles, seeks *the true Absolute, higher than which nothing can be thought or be*, while the positive philosophy takes its point of departure from the *thus-found principle*, developing its positive richness in so far as this lets itself be cognized through its factual revelations. The negative philosophy, whose principle is a merely logical one, is to be the *abstract necessity’s*, the *impersonal’s* philosophy, whose final goal is, from necessity to come to freedom, and whose categories contain only the negative condition, *conditio sine qua non*, for the cognition of truth, but do not give us the actual living truth; the *positive philosophy*, whose principle is a more than a logical one, is to be *freedom’s*, the *personal’s* philosophy, which more closely determines itself as *history’s and revelation’s philosophy*, inasmuch as it investigates in history the personal God’s testimony, and from this standpoint it cognizes also nature, which now will show itself in a new light. *The negative philosophy cannot give an explanation of reality*, since it can only seek the principle that is the all-explaining; this, on the contrary, the positive philosophy, the philosophy for life, reality’s philosophy, can do.

The positive philosophy is determined namely as *a science of experience, empiricism*, but as *metaphysical empiricism* (cf. *Schelling*), which through intuition as organ sees in the working the working cause, in the fact the idea, in that which reveals itself in the midst of time that which was before the foundation of the world was laid, and seeks to develop the intuition into concept. It begins, inasmuch as it sets freedom’s God as

²²Martensen: Om Tro og Viden, p. 94 f.

the truth, with a great affirmation, a great fundamental assumption,—it hereby goes beyond the logical and the logical's necessity. But it is to furnish a *progressing proof* for its fundamental assumption, inasmuch as it demonstrates and cognizingly absorbs itself in the proof which the willing and acting God himself continues to furnish for his existence in his continued relation to mankind. *Only an uninterruptedly progressing proof and not a concluded one* is namely to be suited to the *personal God's existence*. Just as we demand that human individuals who are important to us shall continually give us new proofs of their existence, so we demand it also with respect to God. We demand that the Godhead always comes nearer to man's consciousness, we require that it not only in its workings, but itself, becomes an object for consciousness, which can yet only be reached by degrees. The full proof for the personal God's existence must therefore be furnished through the whole of reality; it goes back to our race's past and reaches out into its furthest future. *In freedom's philosophy there can therefore be no question of any concluded system because reality's system is not concluded*, and freedom's God, who has introduced himself into history, is not only the one who is and who was, but is also the one who comes²³.

To this higher science: the science of revelation, the ethical science, the science of the good in the eminent meaning, the science of God, the one Good, in his free self-communication to man, theology relates itself in such a way that *the former becomes the universal science, theology the central science*, which exclusively absorbs itself in the One, in God's kingdom as such.

3.5.2 Critique of the Attempt to Ground the Possibility of a Science of Faith

The critique of this concept of science must first illuminate the attempt to demonstrate the possibility of a scientific knowledge of faith's content.

In what turns of phrase this attempt is made has in essentials already been indicated at an earlier place²⁴. What is there stated is more closely determined by the statements that *revelation does not indeed want to give us a scientific system of concepts*, but that this by no means is to say that it has wanted to teach us nothing about the highest questions whose solution metaphysics seeks; for even though it does not give us *abstract concepts*, it gives us a *comprehensive total intuition that embraces heaven and earth, nature and*

²³Martensen, op. cit., p. 95 f.

²⁴See above, p. 44 ff.

*history, the past, present, and to-come*²⁵; and it “has its own metaphysics, of which it will give up not the least.”

It will at first glance be evident that the sought proof for that scientific knowledge is reached only through *subreptions* by the aid of ambiguity in the use of the concepts. It is the concepts *knowledge, truth, thought, and science* that are used in a double meaning or in an effaced meaning. The fact that the believer must *know what he believes*, i.e. *be conscious of what he believes*, is made into his having to be able to know it in the meaning of having *a scientific cognition of it*. When faith was not itself a knowledge, it is said, then the believer would not be able to confess his faith and not be able to reject and combat the erring doctrines. Here is again the same exchange of concepts. The believer must be conscious of the *faith-content*, it must be for his consciousness in unfolded form in order that he can confess it; but he can be conscious of it as that which precisely *cannot be known scientifically*, i.e. comprehended by a rational principle, because its metaphysics, that is, the metaphysical expression to which its determinations can be reduced, is a contradictory, a contradictory combination of the metaphysical determinations valid for thought. The believer can, out of that consciousness, combat opposite doctrines in the way in which it has factually happened: either by demonstrating inner contradictions in the opponents, or by arguing out of the religious presuppositions not acknowledged by the opponents. —It is further said that when faith was not already in itself a knowledge, then *it was not the faith of truth*. Faith’s truth designates for the religious consciousness that faith’s content is the *true*, i.e. *actual God*, in opposition to the *false*, i.e. *unreal gods*. But the concept *truth* is transferred from this meaning to *the meaning of theoretical cognition in the form of science*. The consciousness of the *Christian truth* in the meaning of that which really is the Christian is by a *subreption* made into the *Christian idea of truth*, and through the determination *idea* there is reached by a new *subreption the scientific*. In the apocryphal writings’ representation, taken over from the later Greek philosophy, of *wisdom*, “the divine thought that before the creation of the world played before God’s countenance,” and which has stamped itself in revelation, there is sought a possibility for the believing consciousness to be able *thinkingly* to search out revelation and scrutinize, not only for connection, but also for ground; there is talk of a divine *thought of revelation and wisdom that in the believing consciousness grounds a unity of knowledge and conscience*. But when God’s essence is determined by the will transcending all knowledge’s necessity, then *wisdom* relates itself to the “eternal counsels,” which, as proceeding from a will grounding only in itself and

²⁵Martensen: Om Tro og Viden, p. 26 f.

therefore groundless, are unfathomable. Therefore the divine wisdom becomes that which surpasses all human knowledge; revelation reveals the counsels and the counsels' subject as that which is *incommensurable* with knowledge, as that of which there can only be known a That, not a How. Faith's content can with inner consistency be linked together, but the principle becomes the *inaccessible to thought*, therefore *the connected as a whole becomes unthinkable*; only the *formal connection in the comprehended* becomes object for thought. That the faith-content does not become object for *a proper knowledge*, i.e. *for a comprehension*, is also partly indirectly conceded through the determinations that are given of the science of faith's essence, partly it follows from the results of the attempt to present such a science.

The determinations of *the science of faith's peculiarity* are so constituted that they, while they show an uncertainty in the apprehension of its relation to *the purely rational science*: an uncertainty that is precisely grounded in the impossibility of limiting the latter's domain, at the same time, precisely inasmuch as they are to secure for the science of faith a higher rank, *draw it down below the sphere of knowledge and science, deprive it of the right to the name of science*.

3.5.3 Critique of the Determination of its Relation to Rational Science

As regards the apprehension of that relation, the negative philosophy is first determined in such a way that it not only *seeks*, but *finds*²⁶ the true principle, higher than which nothing can be thought or be, hence reaches *cognition's highest, the in-truth Absolute*, and embraces *the whole domain of metaphysics*; while the positive philosophy is determined in such a way that it had to coincide with *the philosophy of nature and of spirit*, so that accordingly both, the negative and the positive, would fall within *the purely rational philosophy's sphere*, as parts of it. Then, however, *the purely rational science*, which is identified with *the negative*, is sought to be distinguished from *the positive*; but the separation acquires only a semblance of validity when one arbitrarily abstracts from that which is set as the negative philosophy's conclusion or breaks off where the goal is touched without developing the concept of the Absolute. Thereupon there is postulated as condition for the positive philosophy's beginning "a great fundamental assumption." But the negative philosophy is indeed already to have "found the principle"; there is accordingly needed no separate new fundamental assumption. By these determinations the positive philosophy is therefore not in reality withdrawn from the purely rational's

²⁶cf. Martensen: Om Tro og Viden, p. 94: "the thus-found principle".

compass, and when the “higher” science’s principle, which, in opposition to the merely logical-physical truth, is designated as the absolute truth, is determined as “the Good itself in its revelation for thought as the highest reality,” then this points in the same direction. *But thus the positive science would accordingly draw its scientific character only from the unity with the negative, purely rational one.*

The involuntary concession of the rational philosophy’s universality is with necessity grounded in the nature of the case. Science is science only as system, as the according to its essence universal thought’s organic unfolding. A limitation of science by an other, which is yet to be an object for a cognition, is an impossibility, because it is a negation of science’s essence, and because this is determined by the indivisible self-consciousness’s universal nature.

This conclusion one will from Martensen’s standpoint reject by saying: it is not science as such that is limited, but only the lower science, and inasmuch as that which limits this is the higher science, then *the lower science is precisely in this limitation supplemented into science’s true system, embracing all given reality.*

Hereby we are led to investigate the determinations by which the postulated science was to assert itself as the higher.

That which in reality is to justify the distinction of the positive science from the rational, and the former’s higher worth, is the postulate of a new kind of cognition, a free cognition determined by the will, which is first to make itself felt in that “fundamental assumption,” which accordingly in reality is not to become an attachment to the purely rational philosophy’s point of conclusion, but a setting of a new, heterogeneous point of departure, in virtue of a subordination under faith’s and revelation’s content, of a “free relation of dependence” to revelation. But this higher cognition that is postulated will show itself in reality not to be cognition, but only *an activity of fantasy determined by craving.*

The new form of cognition, which is set as a higher than the merely logical thinking, is to be the higher and make the positive science built thereon a higher, because it is *a cognition of the free personal God’s revelations.* But the concept of a divine personality to which there is pointed is already illuminated, and it has been shown that it has only the finite single personality’s content, whereby there is brought in a determinateness of finitude that makes that proceeding from this source a lower than that derived from the idea. One is placed before the dilemma: *when nature and history are to be cognized as God’s revelations, then they must be seen as grounded in God’s essence, and this can then, as all existence’s absolute principle, not be determined by personality;—is, on the*

contrary, the determination of personality maintained, then God becomes the absolutely incomprehensible, and nature and history cannot by thought be apprehended as God's revelations. *Personality is precisely to be that which does not go up into the concept*, that which becomes only object for intuition, feeling, adoration. The *absolute personality* would be the most personal of all personalities, the absolutely singular being, which had no universal predicates at all, and therefore no points of attachment for thinking. "Indeed God acquires, when he is determined as personal, a determination that also belongs to me, but its absoluteness is its singularity, its distinction from me. Concerning another finite personality I can, on account of its kinship with me, indeed guess and surmise something; but about the absolute person I can, since here even the basis for the presupposition of a possible likeness with me in thinking and acting falls away, only dream and fantasize." (Feuerbach.) —What is revealed by the free, personal God is to be able to be cognized by man only *by freedom*, and this *relation of freedom*, which is opposed to *the relation of thought-necessity*, is then to designate the new cognition's and the new science's higher worth. But this free cognition, which is to be a higher cognition, must be thought to come into being by a break, set by the will,—an actual conceptual determination of the relation Martensen does not give—; so that thought-necessity is interrupted by the act of will, which sets a new beginning. *The will that sets this then becomes a will different from cognition*, but for such a will we have no other designation than *arbitrariness*, and the cognition that is to rest on this act of will becomes such a one as is borne by "the will's plumage" fantasy, and lacks every corrective, every regulator. Its "freedom" is a lower than thought's necessity; for the thought-necessity which in the rational science is to be the sign of the latter's lower worth is precisely the expression for thought's determinateness by its own essence, its own law; it is therefore *the mark of all proper science*, and it is a *misunderstanding* when it is restricted to science's most abstract and contentless forms. The more concrete and richer science's content is, the more difficult becomes the assimilation that gives the object the form of thought-necessity, but therefore this assimilation becomes just as fully the task, when the concrete, only successively appropriable, is not confused with that which, in accordance with its irrational nature, is incommensurable with thought and absolutely unappropriable for it. And in these domains we get not an abstract thought-necessity, but *the concrete thought's necessity, which is compelling for thought because it is thought's own essence*.

The new cognition's and the new science's higher worth is finally motivated by the fact that they are to give a *cognition of reality*, which the negative philosophy is not to be able to do. Here, however, the same confusion of concepts is present that was

demonstrated at an earlier point. The thought-necessity that is my thinking essence's necessity has *existential certainty* for me and is precisely the highest assurance, while the certainty of outer existence can always become doubtful. But the existence Martensen seeks is precisely an existence in analogy with the outer, sensible reality's, such an existence as becomes object for intuition. To such a one there is also pointed when there is talk of the higher science's personal principle and this principle's revelation. Precisely inasmuch as there is demanded a continuing proof for this personal God's existence, he is drawn down into likeness with the single individual, whose existence as finitely determined can be interrupted. The higher cognition, which is designated by the contradictory concept *metaphysical empiricism*, thus becomes in reality only *an empiricism that relates itself to a finite, sensible, fantasy-determined object*, and the cognition of this is to be *cognition of reality*, while the cognition of the idea and of that grounded in the idea is not to be it. And yet it is surely evident that when it is demanded of the higher science that it shall relate itself to existence, then existence, as set in thought, even though this thought is a thought determined by will, *must always become existence's thought, hence in its truth the idea's being in thought*. Is existence to be something other than the existence the ideal has in my thought, then it becomes *sensible existence*, and thought, which is to take it up, becomes only *formal consciousness of a sensible relation, an experiential relation in the general meaning*. When emphasis is laid on God's revealing himself in a single personality in order thereby to be immediately revealed, then it is forgotten that such a single personality, in its separation from the other human individuals and in its being in man's form, yet becomes only a *mediate revelation* and a revelation through a working of God. *God's revelation of himself can only be thought as an essence-communication to the spirit*.

When thus everything that was to assert for the positive science a higher rank precisely points in the opposite direction, and when this higher science, inasmuch as it is not to be able to give its object the form of necessity, inasmuch as it is not to reach an actual comprehension of it, and inasmuch as it is to bow beneath an authority that is not thought's, and cannot be higher than thought's, because, as has shown itself, the highest in the spirit's world finds its expression in the logical, outside which only the alogical falls—precisely lacks that which constitutes science's essence and form, that which characterizes science as science, and shows itself as resting on a foundation that is lower than the concept, then it loses *the right to bear the name of science and still more to be the higher and ruling science*. It preserves of that which designates science only this, that from the principle coherent consequences are drawn; but the principle, which

bears the consequences and cannot be transformed by a reaction of the consequences, becomes an uncomprehended. *Science in the true sense and ruling science becomes the science that comprehends the Absolute in its true infinity as existence's principle of reality, and this science is philosophy.*

3.5.4 The Method of the Science of Faith

The judgment that has here been passed with respect to the "higher" science: the science of faith, confirms itself completely when we consider its results. Already above it has, with respect to essential points in the doctrine of faith: God's personality, creation, and the miracle, been demonstrated how the attempt to make them the object of a cognition failed, and how the attempted rationalization, consistently carried through, would set something quite other in place of the religious doctrines. The same would be able to be demonstrated with respect to any dogma whatever. Everywhere the development must be carried forward by postulates, everywhere the conceptual determinations must be used in a double sense, everywhere the result must become an immediate union of the contradictory.

The method will, when everything concealing is removed, show itself to be the following. In order to give the movement of thought a point of attachment, there is a setting out from determinations drawn from nature's and spirit's reality, but which, inasmuch as they are to be applied to faith's object, are arbitrarily, in part fantastically, transformed in order that the original determinateness can be forgotten and the application become possible. That thus transformed now becomes the ground for new determinations won by postulates, and inasmuch as the consequences of the rational are arbitrarily broken off, or a quantification to which no concept can be attached is applied, the faith-content that is to be grounded for thought is brought forward through an illusory grounding, in reality only through postulates, and it is concluded therewith that the two opposite elements that meet in the science of faith both find their expression, but in such a way that the expressions neutralize each other in indeterminacy, inasmuch as the rational element is paralyzed by the faith-element, but yet by its presence affects this. The subject in the proposition that is set up as result is determined by predicates that deprive it of its content and leave only an indeterminate, vague representation for consciousness, which then precisely in the indeterminacy, in the lack of the determinate, clear limitation, imagines itself to have something deep, something speculative, something infinite.

3.5.5 Its Results

When we seek determinate examples of this method, whose necessity lies in the task that is set, then we can e.g. find them in the development of the dogma of the Trinity in the Dogmatics and in the work on Faith and Knowledge. There one will find all the method's moments united: a setting out from rational determinations: self-consciousness's and community's determinations; a transformation of them by which they lose their specific meaning (self-consciousness's ideal doubling becomes a multiplication of personality positing several self-consciousnesses; community is to be a person); an arbitrary advancing through postulates (e.g. that the person as absolute, divine person is to be a plurality of persons; that the persons, in spite of their difference, are yet to be God; that the unity, although a unity of oppositions, must not be a higher unity); an arbitrary breaking off (at the threeness of the persons, while the premises lead to an indeterminable plurality); an immediate linking together of the mutually abolishing. *We can find them in the development of creation's relation to cosmogony*, where first the representation of creation is illusorily rationalized by the concept of cosmogony, but then this is factually abolished by being brought in under the one creative supernatural beginning. *We can find them in the development of the doctrine of the Fall*, which one is at once to think as a both unconditioned and conditioned divine counsel, that is, as a counsel not only determined from eternity, but also as determinable by the creature's freedom, as a coming-to-be counsel that determines itself to historical movement of life; in other words: not only as a logical, but as an ethical counsel, the holy will's counsel, in which there is still something undecided, but which yet in its essence does not cease to be unconditioned. *We can find them in the development of the relation between grace and freedom*, where on the one hand, inasmuch as grace, in distinction from the mere omnipotence, is not to work irresistibly, but to respect human freedom, there is asserted for the freedom of the will a significance, but this is then again taken back by the added determinations, inasmuch as the essential freedom is determined as the co-created grace that comes to breakthrough in the natural will, and is to be regarded as grace in nature, while the merely natural, human will can only offer resistance. We can finally, in order not unnecessarily to multiply these examples, which are only to supplement those already analyzed by others, point in conclusion to the Dogmatics' last section, to *the doctrine of the last things*, where eternal damnation is maintained alongside God's counsel for the blessedness of all, where there is ascribed to the damned an unlosable possibility for the good, but in such a way that this possibility is to be absolutely cut off from all conditions of reality for its development, and where fantasy creates the representation

of a “spatiality” within spirituality and inwardness, of an intermediate state after death with an “intermediate corporeality,” etc.

As soon as the ambiguous and indeterminate in the science of faith's designations is removed, then the faith-determinations and the knowledge-determinations show themselves here, instead of being combined in organic unity, as disturbing and abolishing each other. *A science of faith is accordingly here factually not given; whether it can be given at all depends on whether this theological attempt expresses something universally valid for theology or not.*

3.5.6 What is Typical for Theology in the Criticized Conception of the Science of Faith

This becomes easy to decide when the relation between the form of science that theology as a science of faith aims at, and the content that is to be taken up into this form, is considered. *Thought's forms are inseparable from a content of thought, determined by its essence; if accordingly the faith-content is really to be formed by these forms, i.e. go up as formed-through in these forms, not only partially and in an external way be determined by them,* it must in the proper sense be able to be a *content of knowledge*. Can it not be this, such an application of the forms as that by which science is conditioned will be impossible. Science, as comprehending cognition of an organically unfolded whole, is conditioned by the fact that *its content in its wholeness is a rational one, i.e. a thought-necessary forming-out of a principle determined by thought, homogeneous with thought, not merely something formally linked together by thought-determinations, heterogeneous with thought.*

To the question whether the faith-content can stand in such a relation of unity to forms and content of knowledge, the answer is already intimated at the beginning of this section, and by the later developments new moments are given for the answering. It was emphasized in the first place that the religious consciousness's distinction between the transcendent God and man had to lead to a relation of opposition, inasmuch as reflection determined the relation. Faith with its transcendent, supernatural object and its transcendent supernatural principle must distinguish itself from knowledge's content and knowledge's principle; for *knowledge, thought, is the determination of human nature, its forms accordingly natural forms, its content determined by these forms. As expression for human nature, thought cannot take up the supernatural; for what can be received is determined by the receiving organ. A reception of a qualitatively higher would presuppose a re-creating of the organ.* The distinction between the supernatural object and the natural

organ has then, by the later developments, acquired the more determinate form that *the faith-content becomes the content of the free, personal, by no necessity of essence or of knowledge bound God's supernatural revelation*, a content that concerns God's essence surpassing thought, the works of omnipotence, the divine counsels. *The supernatural revelation is for the religious consciousness a miracle: the reception of that communicated by the revelation is a miracle*, by which there is set a new beginning of cognition that does not have a connection and an essence-unity with the preceding, in-itself concluded knowledge. *The content of revelation therefore becomes an incomprehensible, an opposite of the content of knowledge*. That the opposition would just as fully come forward when one began with a quantitatively sounding difference between human knowledge and that which abidingly surpasses it has been demonstrated in the foregoing.

The religious consciousness must thus determine the relation as a relation of opposition, but in this it agrees with the scientific consciousness, which cannot acknowledge any other principle for science than the knowledge determined by its own essence's law, and which sees in the positive religion's content that which by the representational form is determined as a finite, and as such stands in opposition to the content of knowledge determined by thought's infinity.

Theology shows itself accordingly, inasmuch as it would found a science of faith, to acquire a task contradictory in principle. For its task is indeed, inasmuch as it has that supernatural content of revelation, set by the religious consciousness from whose standpoint theology would reflect on religion, in opposition to human knowledge and its content, for its object, to make it a content of knowledge. If an attempt is to be made to solve this task without the contradiction at once becoming striking, then there must everywhere be resorted to what can make the relation untransparent: arbitrary restrictions and double-sounding determinations must be applied everywhere where boundaries are to be indicated, hence precisely where the opposition would come forward, and the two opposites that are to be united must both receive a transformation conflicting with their nature. *This is to say, in other words: on the one hand the concept of knowledge and science must be distorted, while a semblance of their subsistence is preserved; on the other hand the concept of the God whose essence is will, whose working is the miracle, must acquire a distorting admixture of an apparently rational: i.e. the rational must be made half irrational, the irrational half rational.*

As regards the first, the concept of science, to be the cognition of that which with rational consistency is derived from rational presuppositions, is extended to designate a derivation of formal consequences from an anti-rational presupposition. *Science ac-*

cordingly acquires a double meaning. The name is preserved as a common name for the essentially different, indeed in essence opposite, determined by an opposite principle. The science of faith's knowledge becomes a consciousness of that *formal connection*, not a comprehension of the whole out of the principle. And inasmuch as theology, in the consciousness of the difference between the thus-transformed science and science in its general meaning, would determine the former's peculiarity and, instead of that science's freedom which is the expression for its determinateness by its own principle, by thought's necessity, ascribes to it a dependence on a principle heterogeneous with thought, and yet "correcting thought," then it must, by a postulate, in order to preserve the semblance of what characterizes science, determine this dependence as free dependence, and by an ambiguity use the mediate, scientific cognition's relation to its immediate point of departure in order to bring about a semblance of likeness. But along neither of these ways is the aimed-at goal reached. That postulate of freedom cannot be justified. Science, which relates itself to a *real object*, can set itself in a free relation of dependence to this, and must do so in order through the assimilation of the object in its reality to become master of the objectivity; but it makes itself dependent only because it in the object acknowledges a *rational*, hence such a one in which its own essence is affirmed. But knowledge's subordination under the faith-content's authority is the subordination under the heterogeneous, hence not science's true dependence on reason's universal essence-law, but an unfree dependence abolishing science's essence. *Knowledge's subordination under the foreign authority must take place by an act of an activity different from knowledge, by an act of will not determined by knowledge*; therefore all theology must consistently accentuate the will as the theological science's organ. —The ambiguity in the appeal to the immediate lies in this, that inasmuch as it is emphasized that all science rests on an immediate point of departure, and inasmuch as it is concluded therefrom that there is accordingly no contradiction in a science resting on the faith-relation's immediacy, but that on the contrary it must be demanded that faith be the first, the primitive truth, science the derived, the concept: the immediate is at once used of that which is object for cognition's phenomenologically first form: sensation, experience, and which is to be converted into a comprehended, deduced and justified by being comprehended, and of that which is object for faith in this word's proper—not in the effaced Jacobian—meaning, and which cannot and shall not be converted into knowledge, or justified by thought.

It is thus only by ambiguities and distorting transformations of the decisive concepts that the relation of opposition can be concealed. In whatever forms the science of faith can be presented, it must in reality constantly, because it rests on a ground absolutely

incommensurable with thought, unconvertible into knowledge, lack that which constitutes knowledge's essence and form; it preserves only the name of science, a name that loses all its content by being supposed to comprise the in essence opposite, and gives only a semblance of science by partially preserving the merely formal. *The rational in the science of faith becomes the formal connection; an only apparently rational becomes the grounding*, whose necessity becomes illusory, on account of the principle's groundlessness for thought. Science according to the concept's true meaning, true science is only one: that which draws its content from the idea, the universal science, which by its principle is in unity with the personal life's principle. It is science without particularizing predicates, not "Christian" or "believing" science, but science alone.

To theology's distortion of the concept of science corresponds the distortion of the positive religion's apprehension of that which is peculiar to the Godhead's essence and working: of *the miracle*, the expression for the almightily willing God's form of working and form of revelation. The miracle, which expresses the absolute opposition to thought and to the law of existence by which thought is borne, must apparently be made accessible to cognition when a knowledge of faith is to become possible. That is to say: the concept of the miracle must be used ambiguously, so that it at once designates what is a *mirabile* and what is a *miraculum*, so that there is applied a *quantification* that draws it toward the merely wonderful, astonishing, and through this brings about an illusory continuity, a "teleological" continuity, with the universal and natural. But with the distortion of the miracle *faith's essence* is distorted, for in the miracle the positively religious's peculiarity is concentrated and with it all the dogmas' peculiar determinations stand in indissoluble connection. To the distortion of the concept of science there corresponds accordingly in theology the distortion of the faith-content.

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3.6 Final Result

The final result of these investigations is accordingly that the defects in scientific respect which were demonstrated in Martensen must become typical for theology in general, and that the discord between the faith-determinations and the knowledge-determinations, which was factually present in Martensen, must, inasmuch as both determinations are seen from the standpoint of cognition, become inevitable for any theological attempt whatever.

There then remains only the possibility that the relation could be changed if the

standpoint were changed and the two territories: that of knowledge and that of faith, were seen as separated in principle, and as, by this separation, which as it were made the content incomparable, withdrawn from the collision. In Martensen, in spite of the polemic against this view as it is stamped in Prof. Nielsen, such a separation in principle is present. Inasmuch as he lets revelation "from first to last be practical," and inasmuch as he accentuates the will's absolute priority and its difference from cognition, he in reality gives Nielsen the right with respect to his fundamental separation. That the will is set by Martensen as highest unity and constitutive principle does not remove the principled separation; for it is not demonstrated whence comes the difference that constitutes cognition, how this accordingly proceeds from the constitutive.

From the critique of theology's unachievable attempt at unification we then proceed, in order to test that possibility, to the critical investigation of the theory that, precisely by positing the principled separation of the territories of faith and knowledge, would vindicate both in their validity; and we occupy ourselves first with the theory in the form in which it has been presented by its founder: S. Kierkegaard.

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Chapter 4

The Principled Separation of Faith and Knowledge in the Interest of Reconciliation

4.1 The Main Features of S. Kierkegaard's Theory

In the historical introduction the main features of S. Kierkegaard's conception of the relation between faith and knowledge have already been indicated, with particular attention to the comparison with Nielsen's theory. At this point these main features are to be developed more fully.

Kierkegaard's conception is developed through a polemic against speculation, particularly as it appears in Hegelian philosophy; but the polemic is directed against speculation because Kierkegaard sees in it the strongest expression of the whole age's misdirection: having forgotten to exist, forgotten what inwardness is. For speculative philosophy the highest task of the human spirit was to transpose itself into a medium of eternity, to live a pure life of eternity, and this task was to be realized through pure thought, in that the individual's thinking of the Absolute was posited as one and the same with the Absolute's thinking of itself, with the absolute thought existing in the element of eternity. The life of the individual, which found its exhaustive expression in logical thought, through its thinking of the Absolute's eternal life-process encompassing all truth and reality, became a moment in this eternal process, and was freed from the determination of finitude. Against this conception of human life and its task Kierkegaard protests. Against speculation's volatilization of existence, against its forgetting of existence's claim upon the individual who is subject to the demands of the ethical, against

its overlooking of the conditions of existence, against the illusory movement in a sphere of abstract eternity, Kierkegaard accentuates existence, gathers everything around the question: how do I, as existing, express the truth? As existing, the human being is not merely eternal, as speculation would have it, but is a synthesis of the temporal and the eternal, of the finite and the infinite; as existing, the spirit that is eternal according to its nature is subject to conditions of finitude, is in becoming; as existing, the thinker must in all his thought think along with it that he is existing; he must set all his thought into becoming. But becoming is the alternation between being and non-being; through becoming the determination of negation is brought at every moment into the spirit's being and thinking. From this it follows with necessity that the human being is prevented by existence from reaching the positive, secure rest in eternity; for since the existing being cannot hold fast the infinite and eternal—which is the only thing certain—in the element of infinity, but must hold it fast in the element of finitude, in existence, the relation does not become one of secure certainty, but must express the determination of negation that lies in becoming, and the eternal can therefore be had by the existing being—for whom it converts itself into something future—only in the form of uncertainty for cognition. Herein lies, then, that objective knowledge in none of its forms can attain such security that it could become the foundation for the infinite decision for the subject, for a decision with respect to what concerns the subject's deepest need. Sensory certainty is a deception, historical knowledge is an approximation, mathematical cognition is an abstraction, speculative thinking likewise an abstraction and in the last instance a hypothesis in relation to existence; upon none of these forms of knowledge can the decision that infinitely interests the individual therefore be built. But if the goal cannot be reached by the path of objectivity, then it must be reached by that of subjectivity: in a relation of subjectivity the eternal must be grasped, and this relation of subjectivity is the one in which the certainty of the eternal is grasped with the passion of faith out of objective uncertainty. Faith is "objective uncertainty, held fast in the most passionate appropriation of inwardness."

The task for the individual is therefore: to become subjective; and since what is posited as a task is what every human being might seem, without further ado, already to be, the becoming subjective acquires the more determinate meaning: to become what the human being according to its nature is, to let subjectivity develop, be transformed in itself over against the eternal. Only for such a subjectivity, which is the developed possibility of subjectivity's first possibility, does truth come into being. The subject, which is referred to itself, receives the task of being infinitely concerned about itself;

but this infinite concern about oneself is the direction toward the eternal in relation to existence; it leads toward the ethical and the ethico-religious, the essential truth and the only essential cognition. The claim of existence prevents the individual from remaining in the metaphysical, sets it the task: to understand itself in existence. In being referred to a relation of subjectivity, the subject is thus referred to the fact that it reaches it only through a choice between this and the relation of objectivity, and this choice is the choice between the personal and the impersonal relation to truth. For the existing being there is no mediation's unity of the subjective and the objective relation. Mediation, which would connect them, leads us only back to abstraction; it does not explain how the eternal truth is to be understood in the determination of time by one who, by existing, is himself in time.

In the subjective relation, the how of the relation becomes the essential. In the objective relation the direction goes away from the individual, strives toward the objective, finished result, and its maximum is the self-contradiction that the existing subjectivity vanishes, while the objectivity that comes into being is, subjectively considered, either a hypothesis or an approximation, because all eternal decision lies in subjectivity. In the subjective relation, objectivity drops out, and the how of the relation becomes the decisive. At its maximum this how is the passion of infinity, and the passion of infinity is truth itself. But the passion of infinity is precisely subjectivity, and thus subjectivity is truth.

The relation of faith, the expression for the relation of subjectivity, for the relation of infinitely passionate interest, is thus the highest, because in existence it becomes the only possible relation to truth, the form of truth in the actuality of existence. Truth in the conception of objective thinking, as the unity of thought and being, becomes merely a chimera of abstraction and in truth only a creature's longing—not because truth is not this, but because the knower is an existing being, and thus truth cannot be this for him so long as he exists, because existence spaces apart thought and being and for the existing spirit sets truth itself into becoming. The passion of faith, the infinitely passionate interest, thus becomes the form in which the eternal is grasped; in it the eternal is present in a negative way in subjectivity, and the negative infinity becomes in existence the one true expression for the infinite; the infinite negative resolution becomes individuality's form for God's being in it. And faith in the strictest sense is faith in the absolute paradox, which is constituted not, as the Socratic, by the eternal truth's relating itself to the existing being, but by the eternal truth itself becoming the paradox by coming into being in time. As faith in the paradox, faith is the infinitely passionate

holding fast of what is absurd for thought, and precisely through the repulsion of the absurd is passion potentiated to its highest. The absolute paradox is the central point of Christianity, and the question of how I as existing express the truth thus coincides with the question: how do I become a Christian? The answer is: through faith in the paradox; and what in the last instance bears the burden of the paradox and compels the individual to hold it fast in faith despite its absolute unthinkability is the despair of the consciousness of sin, which does not find reconciliation in the ethical, nor in the religiosity that still rests in the unbroken relation of immanence, but only in the Christian, in faith in “the god in time.”

In this theory there is thus posited a self-limitation of knowledge, grounded in the fundamental relation of the existing spirit. Knowledge receives its limitation—conditioned by the contradiction of existence and acknowledged by knowledge itself—a limitation in a double respect: in respect of certainty and in respect of concretion; and through this double limitation there is established an incommensurability-relation between objective knowledge and the striving and need of personality. But under the limitation, knowledge is vindicated a justified place, though a subordinate one, and a validity, though only a relative one. It receives its validity and security within the sphere of the abstract and the impersonal, within the mathematical and logical; it finds its limit where it reaches the concrete and existential; it does not, on account of this limit, become decisive for personality’s deepest and highest interests, for the relation to eternal blessedness; the decisive conclusion does not become possible in its territory. Its sphere extends to the point where the sphere of faith begins, where the relation of faith is posited through a breach with objective knowledge; and within the sphere of faith, thought, in entering into a serving relation to faith, again acquires a significance through the task of unfolding the de-

terminations in which one is to exist, and to defend the paradox as paradox, to protect it against every attempt to comprehend it. A comprehension of the paradox would precisely be an annihilation of its distinctive significance, of faith’s specific object; therefore theology, which posits such a comprehension as its goal, rests on a fundamental contradiction.

In that faith comes into being through a breach with objective knowledge, it vindicates its distinctive territory and its principled validity; it becomes—while it is unattainable for knowledge—inaccessible to knowledge’s attack. Knowledge and faith each receive their own sphere, to which they relate as distinctive principles. Faith as religious faith rests on a choice that in a higher potency expresses the same decision of subjectivity as the

choice by which the individual's ethical life is constituted. The reconciliation between faith and knowledge is grounded in the separation of the spheres and principles, and in the subordination of knowledge under faith. The certainty of faith, which victoriously rises above doubt, is the higher certainty compared to that of cognition, which, in its relation to the concrete and actual, continually remains afflicted with doubt.

4.2 Its Relation to Other Contemporary Conceptions

Through what has been developed, the relation between Kierkegaard's conception of religion and faith and other contemporary conceptions becomes clear.

Speculative philosophy of religion had let religion be a stage in the spirit's development of cognition, which found its completion in philosophy, in speculative thought that with logical necessity unfolded itself from the lower form. Only in the concept did it let the content of faith find its true form; by being converted into the form of philosophical cognition, the content of faith received a higher truth; for the truth of thought, of the concept, is the highest truth. In Kierkegaard the relation of the spheres is seen from a different point of view. Science becomes one thing, life another; the unfolding of thought in the form of objectivity, in the medium of possibility, according to the law of necessity, is separated from truth's appropriation in the individual in the form of subjectivity, in the medium of actuality, according to the law of freedom. The personal existence of truth is accentuated as the highest; the relation of subjectivity becomes the form of this existence; and within the personal forms of existence the religious becomes the highest, and within it again the relation of faith to what is absolutely inaccessible to thought: the paradoxical, the specific determination of Christianity. The task of thought here becomes not to assimilate the object of faith, to dissolve it in the concept, but to discover thought's opposite: the absolutely unthinkable, the paradox, and to hold it fast as paradox so that one may then believe by virtue of the absurd.

Ordinary theology immerses itself objectively in learned investigations; it aims through these to bring out what Christianity is as objective doctrine; by the path of history and criticism it aims to secure certainty on this point, and in this striving, which by the nature of the case loses itself in an infinite approximation, it lets it be the presupposition that the investigator is a Christian and that what matters is the scientific result, whose appropriation is supposed to follow of itself. For Kierkegaard the infinite decision of existence is the main thing: the approximation, by which precisely the decision is prevented, is the deception; appropriation is the task, and what is essential

is not a what but a how. The question is not what Christianity historically is; but the question is: how do I become a Christian? Truth is the inwardness of appropriation; truth is subjectivity.

In Feuerbach, as in Kierkegaard, the spheres of knowledge and faith are separated, but in that Feuerbach determines religion as the irrational, he vindicates the right of thought against faith and posits religion as the untrue, which is to be abandoned. The opposition between Feuerbach and Kierkegaard in the conception of religion and especially of Christianity is therefore the greatest possible, and yet there is no contemporary with whom Kierkegaard has more points of contact in the determination of what Christianity is. This has not escaped him either, and he has, precisely on account of his conception of Christianity, not been able to wonder at it. If the individual's relation to Christianity is a relation of subjectivity, and more precisely one in which subjectivity is at its highest potentiation, at its most energetic passion, then besides the believer, who in passion holds it fast as truth, only the one who in passion rejects it can grasp its nature. The latter, standing outside Christianity, will be able decisively and sharply to say what Christianity is; he will be able to portray it in such a way that the believer can in everything recognize his portrayal. It is undoubtedly Feuerbach whom Kierkegaard has had in mind when he (in the *Concluding Unscientific Postscript*, p. 473), after having discussed theology's and revivalism's confusion of the Christian, says: "on the other side: a scoffer attacks Christianity and presents it at the same time so admirably that it is a pleasure to read him, so that one who is at a loss to have it determinately presented almost has to resort to him." We also find an agreement in the conception on a series of the most essential points. Feuerbach and Kierkegaard agree in determining the relation of religion as a subjective one, even if the nature of the subjectivity is conceived differently; they agree in the conception of the religious standpoint as a practical one, and of faith's opposition to thought; in the denial of the possibility of a knowledge of a being higher than the human; in vindicating the category of the single individual for the religious; in the conception of religion's absolute relation as separating itself from and therefore in reality negating the relative relations; in holding fast the equal relation of the Incarnation to all subsequent ages; in conceiving Christianity's relation to the world as unchangeable, as an abiding relation of opposition; in the conception of suffering as Christianity's mark, of dying away as the believer's wish; in the determination of the Christian's relation to the natural, in the limitation of Christians' sympathy to Christians, and in the close connection in which they place the concepts: God as the absolute τέλος, and eternal blessedness. These parallels could be further multiplied, but those cited are the most

prominent.

The relation between Kierkegaard's and Nielsen's conceptions has been treated in the foregoing and determined in such a way that the two forms of the theory agree in all the main points significant for the development of the problem, while what Nielsen has added does not advance the problem and is self-contradictory and untenable. On account of this relation, the connected presentation of the theory's secondary form is immediately appended to the presentation of the original, and the more detailed critique of the standpoint is attached to the former, to be then completed by a critique of what is distinctive to the theory in its primitive form.

4.3 The Main Features of Prof. R. Nielsen's Theory

In that Nielsen, like Kierkegaard, determines the fundamental relation between faith and knowledge as one of separation, and more precisely as a relation of principled separation, and precisely through the separation seeks the possibility of vindicating both principles and both spheres in their validity and letting them subsist as reconciled in the same consciousness, he concentrates his theory in the proposition: the absolutely heterogeneous principles, faith and knowledge, can, precisely on account of their absolute heterogeneity, be united in the same consciousness. The principled opposition, which is here determined as an opposition between faith and knowledge, is also brought under other determinations already found in Kierkegaard: under the determinations life (existence) and knowledge, subjectivity and objectivity, personal and impersonal truth, or under the determinations: will and knowledge.

this last opposition, and through it the others, is then led by Nielsen back to the metaphysical opposition, the opposition between the fundamental ideas: Power and Knowledge, or the Good and the True.

The opposition between will and knowledge, between the principle of will and the principle of thought, becomes the predominant one in the later, more detailed communications from Nielsen's own hand and from his expositors. Both the opposed activities of spirit are sought to be conceived as totalities, such that in the activity of cognition a will is present, but everywhere as serving thought, as a will-to-know, while in the activity of will a thought is said to be present, but as subordinate to and serving will, as a will-thought. Faith is led back to will; the religious, which is conceived as exclusively practical, is through the principle of will inseparably connected with the ethical, which has its highest form in the anti-rational religio-ethical.

From the psychological starting point, the underivable distinctiveness of will in relation to knowledge is then accentuated. Will is said indeed to presuppose thought, but not theoretical, only practical thinking, and in this presupposing it is said to be just as original as thought. In its distinctiveness will has its principled significance and its ideal just as knowledge does, and as the determinations of will and the determinations of knowledge develop in their independence, governed by their distinctive principle, they form two self-enclosed totalities that do not come into conflict with each other. This lies precisely in the absolute heterogeneity. The form of the opposition is the expression of the factual dualism in the human spirit. In the Absolute, the principle of knowledge and the principle of will—the Idea of the Good and the Idea of the True—are in concrete, absolutely transparent unity; in the finite spirit, the psychological consciousness, a dualism is present that lets what is united in the Idea step forth in absolute opposition. The task for the individual is precisely to comprehend the opposition as such and thereby to win the reconciliation. Philosophy's main task is to discover the limits of human knowledge—that is, its own limits—and, in discovering them, to acknowledge the other principle, which, together with the whole sphere of determinations attached to it, is mirrored by knowledge but not assimilated, not comprehended. Since the two spheres are contained in the same consciousness, they must indeed touch each other and to that extent have a boundary against each other; but the boundary is not a hampering, restricting boundary, for it is set from within by each principle's distinctive determinateness, and “the absolute mystery” prevents the collision. While knowledge thus, mirroring its opposite, clarifies the relation of the principles, it unfolds itself unhindered within its own sphere, following only its own laws: it unfolds a science on the foundation of the Idea that encompasses all the humane forms of life and gives a true expression of the concrete, real existence. And at the same time faith unfolds its content for the believing consciousness, whose cognition is practical, not theoretical. The gap between religion and philosophy is to be filled by ethics in its double form as rational and religious ethics. The border-science is the philosophy of religion, which as science belongs to the circle of knowledge, while, as having the religious for its content, it is to provide orientation in the sphere of faith. It is to show how one and the same concept can become heterogeneous with itself depending on whether it is developed into a “knowledge-concept” or a “faith-concept.” It is to demonstrate an all-sidedly articulated reciprocal determination, an exact mutual correspondence, between the heterogeneous concepts, which occurs in such a way that the knowledge-concepts serve as intellectual substratum, while the faith-concepts step into the foreground and are developed systematically.

As will, which has its autonomy by virtue of its distinctive principle and in choice asserts its independence, autonomously potentiates itself through ever more intensive concentrations, the progressive series of stages of will appears—the stages of the ethical—whose advance is marked by the cognitive moment being more and more absorbed and becoming invisible, and by the regard for theory being more and more displaced by the energy of will. The maximum of the rationally ethical is present where subjectivity, by virtue of a decision of will, turns its back on theory. But even beyond this standpoint one advances into the paradoxical, anti-rationally ethical. “The concentration is here so decisive that all regard for theory vanishes.” The energy of will is so intensive that it not only takes no account of theory but even breaks with it. Indeed not even rational ethics at its maximum can here come into consideration, because its tasks are immanent, its faith a faith of reason. At the height of the paradoxical ethics, the human being is addressed in nothing but imperatives; it acts by virtue of the absurd.

The ethical is here placed in the closest relation to the paradoxically religious, just as in general its principle is posited in unity with the principle of religion; and the ethical is conceived as by itself pointing toward the religious, because the Good is to be comprehended only through the Good One. Already in the territory of the ethical there is therefore talk of faith, but this faith is a “rational faith” before it, through the progressive concentration of will, becomes a faith in relation to the paradox. Religion has its stages just as the ethical does, and they are marked, like those of the ethical, by the deepening of will and faith—a deepening that becomes clear when, for example, Greek religion with its myths is compared with Judaism with its conception of Jehovah as holy will, and with Christianity.

As the concluding stages of the ethical and the religious are reached, the original apparent relation of coordination between faith and knowledge transforms itself into a relation of subordination. The relation of faith and the ideal of will become the highest; knowledge the subordinate. There is talk of “religion’s supra-scientific truths,” of “something higher than science,” of a “supra-scientific teleology.” To this corresponds exactly the conception of will as the true constitutive element in the human being. At the concluding stage of the ethical, where the breach with theory has occurred, the whole of life is so absorbed in acts of will, in action, in a working upon the task of becoming an ethical character, that no room remains for an independent cognition, for a life in knowledge.

Through the given presentation of the main points in Kierkegaard’s and Nielsen’s theory, the earlier demonstration of the agreement between them will have been sup-

plemented, while the real and apparent deviations also emerge more determinately. Through the developments that follow, the relation between the original theory and the derived one will be still more completely clarified.

4.4 Critique of Nielsen's Theory

The critique of the theory in the form that Nielsen has given it must first confine itself to the determination of the form of the principled opposition. But in several of the expressions that have been given for the opposition, especially those taken from Kierkegaard, there appears an ambiguity and an arbitrariness in the conception that render them unfit to serve as starting points for the critique; they need only be illuminated in order to make the relation between Nielsen and Kierkegaard clearer.

What has been said here applies to the opposition between existence (life) and knowledge (theory), and between the subjective and the objective. As for the first opposition, the concept of existence is taken in an arbitrary double meaning, upon which a sophistical inference is built. Existence is taken, first, in order to be asserted as a universal presupposition and necessary condition for every concrete determination—thus also for knowledge—in the meaning of individual being in general; and then, in order that through the concept of existence the practical may be claimed a priority and a preponderance, in the meaning of volitional being (“existence is practical”). Without this subreption the argumentation, which is supposed to lead to the conclusion that it is possible to place existence highest and yet retain theory, but impossible to place theory highest and yet retain existence, and further to establish the superiority of faith over knowledge, could not advance at all. And in the proof of this proposition, the first premise—that a consciousness can exist without being theoretical, but cannot be theoretical without existing—also contains an untruth. All being in the form of individuality is existence; there can therefore be an existence that is not consciousness, not theoretical. But when consciousness becomes the subject of existence, existence includes theory, for consciousness is only existing as being theoretical.

The unclarity arises from Nielsen's taking up Kierkegaard's determinations but altering the presuppositions. Kierkegaard accentuated in the determination “existence” the alternation between being and non-being, which set the existing person's thought into becoming and cut off objective knowledge's certainty from it. He then obtained the opposition between existential (subjective) thinking and objective thinking, and subjective thinking became for him the thinking whose goal was existential inwardness,

existing in what is thought. Nielsen lets knowledge unfold itself into a system, with a different certainty and a different relation to the system of existence than in Kierkegaard. Existence is then conceived not as that which, as a determination for the thinker, prevents objectively certain knowledge; rather, existence receives the determination of particularity in opposition to universality, and since universality is the determination of knowledge, existence is posited as practical. The fact that existence, in Kierkegaard's conception, becomes that to which regard must be paid, from which one cannot abstract without conflict with the ethical and without inner contradiction, becomes for Nielsen the claim that existence, i.e. the practical, is the presupposition; but in order to be asserted as such, it must be taken in the double meaning demonstrated above.

A similar unclarity and arbitrariness appears where the opposition is determined by the subjective and the objective, of which the former relates to life, the latter to science. Where the opposition is determined by these forms (e.g. in the *Philosophisk Propædeutik* §15), "subjectivity" and "the subjective" are taken in a double meaning, so that it now comes to express the accidentally individual and the egoistic, which falls outside the objectively valid, and now the universal form of subjectivity. Here too the relation to Kierkegaard is determinative. For Kierkegaard, subjective truth designated appropriated truth. This truth is, in the territory of the ethical, the universal that is realized in existence and that must be thought in order that one may exist in it. In the territory of the paradoxically religious, the truth that is to be appropriated has the determination of the paradox. In all spheres, the appropriation of truth is posited, because existence prevents objective certainty, as conditioned by an act that everywhere can be designated as an act of faith. In Nielsen, where it is not the uncertainty of existence but the abstract opposition between the universal and the particular that conditions the disjunction between knowledge and existence, the subjective, in relation to the objectivity of knowledge, is placed under the determinateness of a one-sided opposition, as being in individuality's opposition to the universal, and from this comes the double meaning, in that partly the Kierkegaardian determination continues to operate, and partly the new meaning exclusively comes forward. But in that the concept of subjectivity is conceived in this meaning through a one-sided and abstract opposition, it is overlooked that the form of subjectivity also contains what is objectively valid, that the subject takes it up as a norm in itself without the content being changed, that subjective action can have objective principles, that there is an objectively true and valid element in reason-determined subjectivity. The standpoint of subjectivity, of life, comes in that conception to coincide with the standpoint of egoism.

In the same way as the concept of subjectivity, the concept of objectivity also receives a double meaning. Where the main stages of subjectivity are developed, the objective now means objective evil or the merely abstract universal, and now the universal and universally valid that encompasses the totality of the subjective. And as the abstract opposition is definitively maintained, it is arbitrarily ignored that at the different stages the subject's determinateness—which especially appears clearly at the stage designated as that of infinite subjectivity—is precisely by virtue of what has been determined as the objective principle of existence, and that it expresses this. It is overlooked that subjective truth is precisely the appropriated and, in the appropriation, essentially identical objective truth.

The opposition between life and science, subjective and objective, is led by Nielsen back to the opposition between will and cognition, which becomes the psychological foundation for the opposition between faith and knowledge, just as this last opposition has its metaphysical foundation in the opposition of the fundamental ideas, in the ontological fundamental determinations of absolute subjectivity. The opposition between will and cognition, the fundamental psychological opposition, must become the critique's proper starting point; the examination of the determination of their relation must be the fundamental one; and from the psychological we shall then, through the ethical, be led to the metaphysical, where the definitive decision is to take place and the final result to be won.

4.4.1 The Psychological Opposition between Will and Knowledge

What is rightly urged by Nielsen is that will, as a primitive function of spirit, has a distinctiveness that makes it impossible to reduce it to thought, in the sense that it should become a mere modification of the latter. From the fact that it, like cognition, has its distinctiveness, there must then follow a total activity of spirit, a presence of all the spirit's functions within each of the two activities of spirit, and a distinctive fundamental form for these; and they must in this distinctive form be objectified for consciousness, which encompasses both the theoretical and the practical.

But when Nielsen rightly asserts the distinctiveness, and rightly polemicizes against a one-sidedness which, in the form in which he combats it, has no other representative than Spinoza, he loses his right when by a subreption he transforms the distinctiveness into an *opposition* that is carried over from the form to the content, and which is more closely determined as an *absolute heterogeneity between the two activities of spirit with respect to content, goal, and ideal*; and he becomes inconsistent both when he posits

the absolute heterogeneity while demanding the therewith incompatible unity in the absolute principle, and when he holds fast that absolute heterogeneity, although he, by one-sidedly setting the will as the properly constitutive in the human essence, lets it become a higher than knowledge and ground the latter.

The untruth in these further-reaching determinations will become clear by a closer investigation of the way in which Nielsen apprehends the relation.

When we set out from the concession that cognition and will must be set as distinctive, self-valid forms of utterance of the essence, which cannot be reduced to modifications of each other, then it at once becomes the task to determine how much lies in this concession and whether it must lead to the postulated consequences: the relation of subordination and the absolute heterogeneity. Nielsen determines the will's relation to the self in the proposition: "the most subjective of all in subjectivity is the self; but the selfish in the self is self-determination, is will." By using the concept self-determination in such a way that it at once becomes the essential expression for the selfhood-energy and is identified with the will, the emphasis falls on this latter; it appropriates—even though thinking's, like also the artistic fantasy's, original distinctiveness is pronounced—in reality the primacy, and the nearest and immediate consequence becomes that the placing of will and knowledge side by side, to which the principled opposition leads, becomes the subordination of the knowledge-principle under the will-principle: a subordination that during the theory's development comes forward in many forms. To this apprehension contributes also the above- demonstrated one-sided apprehension of the concept existence (life), which identifies it exclusively with the practical, with the will ("life is in the will"). The relation presents itself otherwise when that arbitrariness is avoided, when we, in accordance with what was intimated at an earlier point, in the apprehension of the human set out from the determination that categorically distinguishes human life from life's lower stages: from the determination of essence-universality, which expresses itself in the being-for-itself in the form of liberated universality that is self-consciousness's, and when we apprehend the essence's fundamental determination as *energy*, more closely as selfhood-energy. Both forms: cognition and will, then become primitive expressions for the energy of the essence revealed in self-consciousness as unity, for the self's self-determination through which it, determining itself, realizes itself: in both functions selfhood and energy assert themselves under distinctive fundamental forms. The task then becomes to determine more closely the distinctiveness of the forms of utterance, and the determination of it will decide the question about the relation of opposition and more closely illuminate the postulated relation of subordination. The distinctiveness is

to be determined in such a way that in cognition the selfhood-energy has most nearly the form of universality and ideality, in the will that of singularity and reality. But these determinations, given as points of departure, point to each other and determine themselves toward each other. The reality that is constituted by the will is a realization of the ideal essence's determinations in the self or outside the self. The ideality that is realized through cognition is an idealizing of a real conditioned by the self's side of reality, and is such even in the ideal self's self-cognition. And in the same way the universality that characterizes cognition is a universality that strives toward concretion, punctuality, and whose final goal is the concrete cognition of existence, in which the cognition of the self according to its individualized essence-determinations and essential relations is comprised; in other words: the individual-universal essence's transparency to itself as a member in a totality of existence. Conversely the determination of singularity in the will is such a one as with necessity unfolds the universal in itself, because the will is only will as the self-conscious, i.e. according to its concept universal and general, essence's will. The will must unfold itself from the will determined by the single, positing the single, to the will determined by the universally rational that expresses the essence, realizing the universal. The will-utterance's form of singularity is here not abolished, but the determinateness of singularity has here become transparent in the universal. In a manner similar to the determinations of universality and singularity it stands with the therewith so closely connected ones: those of objectivity and subjectivity. Cognition has most nearly the stamp of objectivity; through the determinateness by otherness, through the subject's relation to the for all cognizing individuals common, universally valid forms of thought and laws of thought, which determine it with necessity. But cognition completes itself only in the cognition embracing the subject as it were concentrated about the self clear to itself, and it is, as realization of an essence-determination of the subject, as ideal extension of the self, object for an interest that can have the most intensive stamp of subjectivity, as a *passion* of cognition, and in it there is in general, because it is *essence-utterance, the subjective essence active according to its wholeness, its undivided personality*. On the other side the will's subjectivity has, the more the will- realization removes itself from the instinctual, drive-like, and egoistic, the more it becomes a realization of the universally rational, of the essence's law, an essence-willing, the determinateness of objectivity, of the universally valid, in itself.

At the will's and cognition's imperfect stage of development they diverge and can come forward in isolation; at their culminating stage, i.e. at the stage of rational determinateness, there arises, while the distinctiveness is preserved, the most indissoluble

connection and the most complete harmony. The cognition that has reached its goal would, as expression for the in-itself transparent essence's energy, in accordance with the one essence's necessary being in both forms, immediately convert itself into the will's energy determined by the essence-cognition, the essence's self-revealedness, and the will that with the most intensive energy, in the most embracing meaning, was essence-willing: realization of the essence according to its concretion, would be a will that immediately converted itself into consciousness, into cognition, and into a cognition that was determined by knowledge's universal, objectively valid laws.

By what is here developed there is thus abolished the sharp opposition posited by Nielsen between will and knowledge, and between the corresponding "practical" and "theoretical consciousness." The practical consciousness is to be personal, interested, in conflict with existence, moved by fear and hope, full of self-regard; the theoretical impersonal, contemplative, disinterested, lost in the universal, moved by necessity, forgetting itself in the grounding of the objective. The relative truth in these oppositions is acknowledged through what is developed above, but the abstract and absolute opposition is denied.

And when the question is raised: whether, without the two essence-utterances' distinctiveness and primitivity being given up, there can be ascribed to one of them an ideal primacy, then this question must be answered in another way than Nielsen has done it by ascribing the primacy to the will; which he does partly for the reason stated above, and partly because cognition is to stop at the universal and at the essence-necessity and not reach the single as such and freedom. From the point of departure indicated above the primacy must be ascribed to cognition. The essence's universality expresses itself *immediately* in the form of liberated universality that is cognition's fundamental form; the determinateness of singularity, which is the will's form, rests on the ground of universality, and the will is only will as the cognizing essence's will. The ethical willing as primitive decision, which creates the relation to the good, in which the will constitutes itself as ethical, and as concrete willing of the good in its determinateness, is conditioned by knowledge and is only possible through it. The consciousness of the *obligating presupposes in its clarity and certainty thought*.

But when thus the primacy is ascribed to cognition, which in the human essence thereby acquires the same relation to the will as in the Absolute the determination of ideality to the determination of reality; then, in accordance with what is developed above, both essence-utterances' distinctiveness is to be held fast in order that the will not be reduced to a modification of thinking. In the transition from the one essence-utterance to

the other there takes place a *conversion, a transformation of form*, whose kind definitively determines the relation. Inasmuch as the content of cognition is converted into a content of will, the conversion is most nearly to be characterized as a conversion from the sphere of reflection and of the universal to that of immediate being and of singularity. Inasmuch as the content of will is converted into a content of cognition—and this means not only: formally reproduced by consciousness—the conversion takes place in the opposite direction. In the moment of decision that separated by reflection is closed together into unity, reflection goes to rest in the decision's act of will, and there is acted in this sense reflectionlessly. Conversely, inasmuch as the act of will with its content is converted into cognition, reflection is again called forth, the immediate unity is dissolved into reflection's distinction, the action's single is translated into cognition's universal.

What then is the categorical determinateness of the relation in accordance with this conversion? The distinctiveness of the essence-utterances brings a *differentia specifica*, a difference of kind, in between will and cognition, but how is the heterogeneity to be more closely determined? We will here see the matter from the psychological standpoint alone, and leave aside the postulate that an absolute heterogeneity is to be grounded in the relations of the ideas. The question then acquires the form: whether the heterogeneity becomes such a one that it, in Nielsen's expression, allows only a reflection of the will in knowledge as a foreign, only by itself determined, which does not become transparent for knowledge, or whether the difference is governed by the essence-unity. The answer depends essentially on the apprehension of the determination of singularity in the will. Is it overlooked, in the apprehension of this, that the will is only will as the self-conscious, i.e. according to its nature universal and general, essence's will, then the will's singularity and the moment of immediacy in it is traced back to the immediate nature-determinateness's utterance of activity in the drive, the sensible-egoistic craving, and inasmuch as this is most nearly seen from the side through which it hangs together with the individual nature-being's unopened singularity, which stands in *immediate opposition to knowledge's universal*, then the activity that proceeds from it is apprehended as everywhere determined by this form of singularity, and, where it does not in general withdraw itself from consciousness, as that which at most is reproduced by consciousness as the in its immediacy with cognition's universal absolutely incommensurable. Is, on the contrary, this apprehension of singularity abandoned—which would little agree with freedom's being ascribed to the will—and is it held fast that the will's singularity is the universal essence's form of appearance, is *spirit-determinateness*, the relation becomes an essentially other. In the thus determined single the universal goes to rest

only in such a way that the single becomes transparent: the conversion is a conversion from thinking's, and expressly from the "theoretical" thinking's, universality to the personal living's singularity; but the individual as rationally willing expresses in the singularity the universal, gives it being in its form, which transparently reveals the universal. The difference of form is accordingly governed by the essential unity; the content of consciousness becomes under both forms: as content of cognition and content of will, essentially the same. I cognize duty—and that is again: I cognize it theoretically—e.g. the duty to fight for the fatherland; I resolve to exist in the cognized, and inasmuch as the resolve is realized, the content, as realized in the single will, is essentially the same. The unity comes forward most determinately in the relation where cognition itself becomes the will's object.

4.4.2 The Ethical and the Religious in Relation to Cognition

4.4.3 The Presuppositions of the Psychological Determinations in the Metaphysical

4.5 The Theory's Consequences

4.5.1 With Respect to the Psychological

4.5.2 With Respect to the Ethical

4.5.3 With Respect to the Religious

4.6 Result of the Critique of Nielsen's Theory

4.7 What is Common to Kierkegaard and Nielsen and What is Distinctive to Each

4.8 Critique of the Determinations Distinctive to Kierkegaard

4.9 Final Result

Conclusion